Things that Stay/Things Left Behind

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38112733.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Starla (She-Ra), Adora & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Light Hope (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra & Mara (She-Ra), Catra & Lonnie (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Starla (She-Ra), Jewelstar (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Divorce, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Married to Separated, Separated to Friends, Friends to Lovers, Slow Burn, Slow Build, Family Feels, Family Bonding, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Catra is So Done (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, Tattoo Artist Catra (She-Ra), Idiots in Love, First Love, Useless Lesbians, Mutual Pining, Pining, Flashbacks, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Alternating, Getting Back Together, Angst and Feels, friends to idiots to lovers

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Things that Stay/Things Left Behind Universe

Stats:
Published: 2022-04-08 Completed: 2022-08-23 Words: 82,101 Chapters: 21/21

Things that Stay/Things Left Behind
Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38112733.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra/Starla (She-Ra), Adora & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora & Light Hope (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra & Mara (She-Ra), Catra & Lonnie (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Starla (She-Ra), Jewelstar (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:

Angst, Divorce, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Married to Separated, Separated to Friends, Friends to Lovers, Slow Burn, Slow Build, Family Feels, Family Bonding, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Catra is So Done (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, Tattoo Artist Catra (She-Ra), Idiots in Love, First Love, Useless Lesbians, Mutual Pining, Pining, Flashbacks, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Alternating, Getting Back Together, Angst and Feels, friends to idiots to lovers

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Things that Stay/Things Left Behind Universe

Stats:
Published: 2022-04-08 Completed: 2022-08-23 Words: 82,101
Chapters: 21/21

Things that Stay/Things Left Behind

by ResFlower

Summary

"Glim, I really didnt think this separation would last this long," Adora breathed into the phone as she closed her eyes. "Cat' s my home Glim, and I thought I was hers."

Adora's bent her head forward to press against her desk, feeling more hopeless than ever. Glimmer was silent~~for~~ once~~on~~ the other end of the line. She picked up one of her many fountain pens and twirled it around her fingers.

"Honestly , Adora I never thought you two would be apart for this long either."Glimmer 's voice was filled not only with sadness but with something worse~~d~~doubt.

"Y ou dont think we are going to stay together , do you?Or I guess~~g~~et back together ."Adora asked her closest friend. The silence was deafening.

OR

Adora and Catra, childhood friends and college sweethearts, have been separated for a year and are on the verge of divorce. Although they manage to co-parent their eight-year-old Finn, it seems that all hope is lost for their marriage. Adora and Catra try to navigate their separation and recover at least part of what they lost.

Divorce/Separation AU

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

A Sunkissed Sectional

Chapter Summary

Adora waits.

A family reads together.

A family falls apart.

Chapter Notes

I am SO EXCITED to share this with y'all!I hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora would never get used to this. She drummed her fingers on the marble countertop as she sneaked glances at the clock in the living room. As an engaged couple hunting for their first house, she and Catra had fallen deeply in love with the open spaces and great lighting on the first floor, prompting them to make an immediate offer. They'd felt blessed when it was accepted~~now~~ the warm beams only served to widen the hollow feeling in her gut.

From her spot in the kitchen, she could see most of the living room, the furniture all dark wood, whites, and blues. The centerpiece of the room was a big L sectional that used to be the perfect spot for Catra's naps when the sun hit it just right. Currently , the floor was littered with toys and a stack of warm blankets rested on the couch.

On the far side of the room~~wh~~ere most people expected to find a wall-mounted television~~wa~~s the vintage clock Adora periodically stared at to keep track of the time. It seemed a bit out of place with the other décor , a relic of the past amongst typical IKEA furniture.

Looking at the clock brought a sharp pang to her chest~~it h~~ad been a wedding gift from Catra's parents, a family heirloom. Catra insisted

the clock looked best in its current spot, foregoing a television in the living room entirely. Adora always teased her when she had to set up an old-school projector to do movie night in the living room.

Catra usually dropped Finn off at seven when she had them on Sundays, squeezing in as much time as possible with them. Today, however, Catra moved the drop-off time to four. Adora's hand clenched at her side. She knew the drop-off change was so Catra could catch a new play with her girlfriend, *Starla*. Adora scoffed to herself. Even the girl's name was beautiful, soft, and shiny. She couldn't quite imagine how the shorter curvier blonde fit with Catra but she honestly never wanted to know.

Catra failed to explain the reason she wanted to drop Finn off earlier, but Adora figured it out when she overheard Scorpia and Perfuma discussing their double date tonight. It had taken everything in her to pretend she hadn't heard, to keep walking past the couple towards the bathroom and spill her tears there. She didn't want to cause a scene and ruin a perfectly nice outing with the tangled mess of emotions that lived in her chest.

She and Catra used to go on double dates with Scorpia and Perfuma all the time. They would go to shows and art museums when Perfuma and Catra got their way and when it was Adora or Scorpia's turn to pick the double date activity was typically more physical. Hundreds of memories of playing volleyball, eating dinner, going sightseeing, watching movies, plays—

It's only natural that they continued to do that without her she reminded herself. Adora gritted her teeth, *doesn't make it any easier*.

Remembering that Catra was dating Starla always made her skin crawl. Knowing that there was someone else who took Catra out, supported her dreams, slept beside her at night—it was the worst kind of gut punch. She stared at the clock and continued to tap on the countertop, the tips of her fingers red and sore. It felt so wrong to imagine Catra with anyone else. She *knew* they were separated and

Catra had every right it just it just wasnt Adora' s choice. She still loved her wife.

The separation blindsided Adora, leaving her reeling when she had to pick up the pieces. If she was perfectly honest, she had no idea how she and Catra, her best friend since she was a child, could turn into strangers like this. It wasnt long ago that they lived happily in this house together.

Then

Adora arrived home to find Catra splayed out on one side of the sectional and Finn on the other. Catra's cropped brunette locks and Finn's unruly blond hair almost touched where the two ends of the cream couch met. Their noses stuck in their respective books, neither looked up when Adora arrived.

At five years old, Finn still hadnt lost some of the roundness from their toddler days and Adora mourned the day they might look like the big kid they already claimed to be. Adora dropped her purse onto the closest chair, finally grabbing the attention of the couch surfers.

"Is there any room for me on that couch?" Adora said teasingly , hands on her hips.

Finn sat up with wide eyes, perking at the sound of Adora's voice. "Mom! Look!" Finn pointed at their book, a new one with big pictures and words that Adora recently bought for them to practice their sight words.

"Wow, buddy! Were you reading it all by yourself?" She asked, purposefully infusing wonder into the question. Finn nodded enthusiastically, practically bouncing from the force of it. The covert look her wife sent her made Adora suspect Finn *might* have had some help along the way. They were still learning to sound out their words and sometimes preferred to tell their own stories based on the pictures.

“Let me say hi to your mama, bud.”Adora hoisted Finn onto her shoulder and plopped with them dramatically on the couch, causing them to giggle. She then turned and gave Catra a lingering kiss, that was probably a touch too heated for a Saturday morning. It wasn't Adora's fault that her wife was so effortlessly gorgeous, her eyes, one blue and the other hazel, holding Adora in a trance.

"Hi."Adora breathed, the tip of her nose still touching Catra's as she broke the kiss off. Catra's hair was especially wild and curly as she grinned up at her wife. The smile made Adora's heart skip a beat.

"Hello to you Mrs. Boss Lady ."She leaned forward and gave Adora another sweet kiss. She sighed into the kiss trying to draw Catra closer still, one arm wrapping around her waist. "You know I have to get to work soon, right?"Catra asked while raising an eyebrow and smirking.

Adora groaned, leaning further into the cushions. She hadn't forgotten that Catra was scheduled to work at her tattoo apprenticeship, but she wasn't looking forward to spending the afternoon without her, especially since Adora was busier than ever since she got promoted to manager.

"I know , I just want to spend some time together before you abandon me.”Adora pouted playfully and pulled Catra close to her chest. Adora pressed a kiss to her forehead. Catra turned to put down her book, but Adora gripped her tighter, shaking her head.

"Don't let me interrupt reading time, I just wanted to claim the couch space that is rightfully mine.”Adora made a show of spreading out on the couch.

Catra hummed. "Is that so?"She gingerly grabbed Adora’s hand rubbing circles into it before moving away briefly to open her book again. Catra settled into Adora’s side again, with Finn on the other, all squeezing tightly onto one section. It was lovely .

"Yeah, everyone knows that mom is the best mattress for reading time, isn't that right?" She directed the words at Finn as she wiggled her fingers into their side, making them laugh.

"Shh, mom reading time is quite time!" Finn whispered urgently, reopening their book. They tried to recreate a stern, serious face but it missed the mark, looking entirely too cute on Finn's small features.

"Yeah Dor, you are *so* bad at being quiet." Her voice dropped low and her lips brushed along Adora's neck, the words drenched with implication. As if that wasn't enough, Catra leered at Adora, making her flush to her collarbones. Thankfully the innuendo flew past an unsuspecting Finn.

The family finally settled into silence. Adora occasionally read some passages over Catra's shoulder or helped Finn sound out words. Mostly, she enjoyed having her two favorite people cuddled close to her. She buried her head in Catra's hair, occasionally dropping kisses there.

They stayed like that for another twenty minutes before Finn fell asleep, snoring softly on Adora's shoulder. Their book gently fell onto the couch cushions as they turned to snuggle closer into her side. Seeing Finn burrowed into her shirt with their mouth hanging open made Adora's heart grow three sizes too big for her chest. She carried Finn to their room, softly padding up the stairs with Catra following close behind, the warmth of her hand seeping through Adora's shirt.

She gently put them down once she carefully walked around the toys on their bedroom floor. Finn currently had a race car bed they would soon outgrow as well as what had to be one of the largest lego collections known to toddlers. The look of Finn as they slept, so soft, unguarded, and still never failed to make Adora's chest feel like it would split wide open. Catra looked down at Finn in much the same way.

She then turned her gaze to Adora, her eyes twinkled up at her as she placed a kiss on Adora's jaw. Adora grabbed her hand, gently tugging her forward. They walked out of Finn's room quietly, but Adora pulled Catra to a stop before she could take the first step down the stairs.

"Do you want to go take a *nap* in our room?" Adora asked the questions loaded with intention, a nap the last thing on her mind. She crowded Catra's body with her own, her hands brushing slowly down Catra's sides. Catra looked torn, biting her lower lip. As Adora's hands fiddled with her waist band, she finally spoke up.

"Stars, I want to, but I *do* have to get ready for work. Raincheck?" Although she was saying no, she leaned into Adora's touch and started kissing down her neck.

Adora let out a groan at the sensation, her eyes fluttering shut as she focused on that and little else. "Of course, love. But if you keep doing that, the raincheck will probably happen earlier than you're thinking." Adora's hands slowly crept to her ass while she whispered into Catra's ear. Catra groaned as she stopped her trail of kisses.

"Ugh, working on Saturdays sucks." Catra leaned her head on Adora's collarbone as they caught their breath. Adora tightly hugged her wife before letting go reluctantly.

"How about we make lunch together?" Adora proposed as she caught Catra's eyes to smile at her.

Catra snorted and rolled her eyes knowingly. "Yeah, if you mean that I'll make us an edible lunch while you watch, then sure."

Adora made an indignant noise in the back of her throat. "I'm not that bad!" Adora protested like she had since the first time she burned food in front of Catra at the ripe old age of fifteen.

Catra grabbed her hand and led her down the stairs with a dismissive, "sure princess."

As they made their way to the kitchen, Adora caught sight of their clock in the living room. Catra had about an hour before she had to leave for work. She tightened her grip on her hand.

"You know, I could probably put my feet up and watch some TV if my wife wasn't a weirdo who didn't want a TV in the living room." Adora joked as she knocked shoulders with Catra.

She let out a disapproving grunt. "You can set up the projector if you want to watch TV." Catra's eyes flashed as she raised an eyebrow. "Besides, you don't even like TV. I need to drag you to our room to make you watch Netflix with me."

"I mean, I'll be honest, that's mostly because you look so cute and small when you try dragging me." She paused for dramatic effect. "And I usually end up with your boobs in my face at some point which is always the highlight of my day." Adora waggled her eyebrows. Catra let out a squeaky laugh, shaking her head at Adora with a faux look of disapproval.

Adora was incredibly unhelpful in the kitchen, mostly following Catra around, asking questions, and sneaking in kisses where she could. Despite this, Catra managed to make a quick ravioli dish with a side salad. They sat side by side, eating on the large marble countertop that doubled as their dining table.

"So, what are you doing today? Like the tattoo I mean." She asked around a mouthful of romaine. Adora loved hearing Catra talk about her art.

Catra bopped her wife's forehead. "I knew what you meant dummy. I sent them two designs for a sea turtle of all things. I really hope they pick the second design because the first one is a bit too cutesy for my taste." Catra shrugged. "But you know, not going on my body so I'm not particularly invested." Catra finished as she popped another ravioli in her mouth.

Adora scoffed.

"Please Cat you are the most invested in your tattoos. I've never seen you tattoo something that isn't amazing, and it's because you are always making sure it's perfect." She would know she had a few of Catra's tattoos on her own body. Catra looked away as she smiled, clearly pleased by the compliment.

"I have to go now, make sure I have a home to get back to tonight after my session." Catra's words were teasing but her tone was tender. She smiled warmly at Adora and placed a chaste kiss on her lips.

Adora sighed, chasing after her. "You'll always have a home to come back to, just hurry back when you can," Adora told her, already missing her before she left. Catra gave her a tender look that warmed her from the inside out.

"Always Adora." It sounded like a promise.

Now

Catra arrived just as the clock struck four. She waited at the door for permission to enter the house which Adora found annoying—*you aren't a guest Cat this is your house too*—but she bit her tongue and kept those thoughts to herself. They weren't appropriate anymore. Now, they only engaged in minimal small talk and childcare logistical arrangements. *Joy.*

Adora opened the door wide open and gestured for Catra to come in. Catra bustled in quickly, hair in disarray as she rested her bag on the counter.

"Hey, I'm sorry I changed the time I'm dropping off Finn last minute, I forgot I'd made plans earlier. I hope it isn't a bother." Catra said as she rapidly twisted her hand around her opposite pinky finger. *She was nervous.* Worried Adora would ask about her plans, no doubt.

She waved her off. "It' s fine, I was home anyway, and I always have time to spend with Finn." She hoped her smile wasn't stif f, especially once Finn bounded up to her.

Finn's blue eyes were positively beaming, their blonde hair a sweaty mess sticking up in the oddest directions. *Well, they clearly had fun.*

"Mom! Mama and I went to the park with the lake, and we climbed one of the tall trees!" Finn launched into dif ferent stories about the fun they had at the park, their arms gesticulating wildly. Their limbs had started getting more gangly as they grew, making their arm gestures look even more hectic than normal. Their hair flopped in and out of the way of their eyes, all of them in motion as they recounted their tale.

Hearing about Finn's park adventures made Adora's heart ache. She missed watching Finn and Catra play at the park, especially worrying over their mutual love of heights. A part of her wondered if Catra was less adventurous when climbing now that there wasn't someone who could provide ground support. She tried not to linger on the thought.

"That' s great buddy." She assured her kid, not having to put in a lot of effort to find a warm smile just for them. Finn was about to crawl onto the couch, grass stains and all when Adora quickly grabbed their arm. "Why don't you go wash up, I can't imagine you smell too good after running around the park all day."

Adora made a big show of sniffing Finn which made them giggle and momentarily forget that they hate showering. She was right, Finn smelled awful. Finn promptly remembered that showering simply wasn't for them and huf fed in annoyance as they climbed the stairs two at a time to get ready for their bath.

Adora turned her attention back to Catra, who hugged Finn before they clamored up the stairs. Catra watched Finn disappear to their least favorite clean-up activity, the longing clear on her face.

"I miss them when they're away too," Adora said with soft understanding. She missed Finn to pieces when they were gone. She missed Catra too. The difference was she got to have Finn back — Catra was always gone.

She tears her gaze away from the stairs to Adora, for once her eyes unguarded. "Yeah, I know you do." Catra acknowledged, a bit stiff in her delivery but nonetheless genuine. Although sometimes it drove Adora crazy that all they talked about now was Finn, she was grateful that they managed to co-parent without major troubles. "Will it ever get easier, you think?" Her voice wavered as she asked.

Adora's eyes widen at the question, locking eyes with Catra. She looked tired like she didn't have a moment to herself all week. She was still beautiful though. She couldn't remember a time she didn't find Catra beautiful.

"What?" She asked as her pulse raced. Catra couldn't be asking about *them* now, could she? Adora rubbed her sweaty palm on her pants. Adora didn't think being apart from Catra could ever be easier. Not having Catra in her life was like cleaving herself in half.

"Being away from Finn." She clarified, head tilted in confusion as she tried to figure out where Adora's head was at, probably. She hoped she didn't connect the dots.

Adora deflated, her eyes lowering to the ground. "I don't know Catra. I hope so." She chanced a look back up at Catra only to find her looking away towards the clock. The silence extended for a beat and turned awkward, as it always did these days when it was just them without distractions. They couldn't even just *be* in the same space without it feeling unnatural.

"I guess you need to be heading off to your *plans*. Have fun." She tried not to sound bitter, and she thought she mostly succeeded. *Mostly.*

The incredulous look Catra shot her tipped her off that maybe she wasn't as convincing as she hoped. *Oh well.* It's not like she was ever good at hiding things from her wife. She shoved her hands into her pockets and took a step back, not that she was close to Catra to start with.

Catra paused and turned her body towards Adora again. It looked like she was about to say something, hand reaching toward Adora's, but she hesitated halfway through and dropped her arm. Adora felt her fingers twitch of their own accord, hidden in her pocket. She looked past Catra at the damn clock again, trying to not do something stupid. Like beg Catra to stay there with her. To never leave her again.

Catra straightened up and made her face perfectly smooth and indifferent. Adora hated it. "Yeah, I do need to head out now. Ill pick Finn up from school on Tuesday and drop them off for the weekend like we discussed. Ill see you then."She stated matter of factly while clutching the strap of her bag.

Adora nodded softly barely calling out a goodbye as Catra turned around and walk out of the house that used to be their home. To go out on a date with another woman.

Adora let out a deep groan rubbing her face with her hand. It had been almost a year since Catra left this house, but Adora knew the hole her absence left would only grow deeper in time. For Adora, there was no getting over Catra.

Chapter End Notes

> Well folks that's the start of it!As always, kudos and comments are incredibly appreciated. I have had a bear of a week at work (will likely be working 80 plus hours for the next two months) and got this ready to post through sheer force of will, so being rewarded with comments and kudos would be grand.
>
> Next week: We get our first look at Catra's point of view.

A Shared Coffee

Chapter Summary

Catra has lunch with Scorpia.

Catra goes on a first date.

Catra is indecisive.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra walked into Perfuma's tea shop and immediately spotted her friend. "Hey Scorp! How are you?" She called out.

Scorpia was near the checkout counter, fidgeting with the pastry display. Her eyes snapped up at the sound of Catra's voice. The small restaurant was covered in potted plants, some of their vines creeping along the walls. It always smelled comforting, like baked goods and fresh flowers. Scorpia and Perfuma really did a lot with the place.

"I'm good, I was just helping the missus with some stuf f while I waited for you to get in." she pointed at the delicious pastry stand.

Tea and Leaves was a convenient lunch spot for Scorpia and Catra's weekly lunch outing because Scorpia got to visit her wife, and Catra only walked two blocks from the tattoo shop where she worked. Although today she showed up half an hour late.

"Sorry , I got caught up finishing a session." She apologized. "I hate to make you wait up."

Scorpia waved her off as she rolled her eyes. "That' s fine Cat, I love hanging out here anyway." Perfuma walked out from the back and

caught the end of Scorpia's sentence.

"Is it the ambiance or the people, dear?" Perfuma quirked an eyebrow at Scorpia, who turned an interesting shade of red.

She rubbed the back of her neck with a shy smile. "Both honey bunny." Scorpia nodded as she placed the last of the pastries onto the display.

Perfuma turned to smile at Catra enveloping her in a brief hug. "Hello, Catra. I know just the thing to get you if you'll allow me to select your lunch." Perfuma's smile brightened ~~as~~ if Catra needed any convincing.

"Of course, Fuma. All your shit tastes good." It warmed Catra's heart to see Perfuma so happy as she carefully crafted plates for her and Scorpia. It was always Perfuma's dream to run a business like this ever since Catra met her in college.

"I'll bring the plates, you two sit and chat." Perfuma shooed them away as she bustled around looking for her apron. She quickly followed to Catra and Scorpia's usual table. "These will set your aura just right ~~it is~~ looking a little cloudy," Perfuma said with a disapproving tsk as she set the plates on the table. Catra resisted the urge to roll her eyes, nodding gratefully at her friend. "And here is your drink."

Perfuma placed a large, iced coffee next to Catra's plate. Catra immediately took a sip, counting on the caffeine and sugar to wake her up for the second half of her workday.

She sat across from Scorpia while each of them munched on the baked goods Perfuma deemed they "needed" to "right their auras" or whatever other nonsense. She didn't buy into Perfuma's aura schtick, but she wouldn't say no to a free rosemary scone. She loved Perfuma, so she put up with the woo factor.

They ate in companionable silence for a while. Catra zoned out for a bit as she stared at a peculiar plant on the windowsill. It had long leaves that looked almost wilted if not for the vibrant green color and small red flowers that looked like spikes. She was wondering if she could incorporate it into a tattoo design currently sitting on her desk when Scorpia suddenly piped up.

"Hey , Im sorry we cut in on your Finny time last Sunday , it's just the only day Fuma could get the tickets and we were so excited to get to see Starla again." Catra held up a hand in a stopping gesture with an easy smile.

"It' s fine big gal, I know it's not easy working around my schedule. I can be flexible when I have to be, I just dont want to give up time with Finn if I dont have to." Catra explained although she knew Scorpia understood.

Scorpia looked reassured that Catra wasnt upset. She then took on a sly look that was absolutely unsettling on Scorpia's face. Even though Scorpia was tall and intimidating at first glance, she didnt have a conniving bone in her body.

"So how's that going?" She singsonged, looking at Catra from behind her drink.

Catra felt her shoulders stiffen at Scorpia's question. She looked into her coffee mug, watching the ice cubes bob in her drink.

"What do you mean Scorp? Y ou are going to have to be more specific." Catra hedged as she looked at Scorpia over her mug. She really wasnt sure what her friend meant. *Please for the love of God, don't be asking about sex* —

"Y ou know! Things with Starla!" Scorpia leaned forward and Catra felt herself relax back into her chair . *This* she could do. Scorpia was bound to ask for an update about Starla and Catra didnt mind talking about her girlfriend.

"I mean you saw us together a few days ago, I think things are going well." Dating Starla was nice. Straightforward. They shared mutual interests in the arts, had good chemistry, and Starla didn't mind that Catra was a mom. She wasn't sure what more she could want in a relationship.

"Well yeah, I know *that*, but the important things can't just be seen on a double date. Do you think you are in love with her Cat?" Scorpia's eyes twinkled at the prospect.

She bit her lips as she thought over her words. The truth was that the question surprised her. She hadn't thought about loving Starla yet.

"I don't know Scorp, we haven't been together all that long." She dodged as she ran her pinky over the outer rim of her mug. At five months, her relationship with Starla was far from serious. "I think maybe I *could*, but I still want to feel things out."

Maybe one day, Catra could love again. She wasn't sure that her heart was whole enough to try and give it to someone else yet.

Scorpia's eyes dimmed a bit, but she smiled warmly at Catra. "Well, you still have time to figure stuff like that out! Never fear!" Scorpia smiled convincingly trying to cheer her.

Catra smiled back, she really did love Scorpia. She'd had her back since they became close friends in college and she'd been a godsend in the last year.

"Could I get you girls anything else?" Perfuma passed by their table, pretending they were any other customer. Her words were directed at both of them, but her eyes were only for Scorpia.

"I'm good Fuma. Everything is excellent as always." Catra responded. Her lunch at Tea and Leaves was always her best of the week, and it wasn't just because of Scorpia's company, although that was certainly a bonus.

"We had a great time on the double date the other day." Perfuma supplied as she put a gentle hand on Catra's shoulder.

She smiled and nodded. "Starla and I also had a good time." Catra offered as she rubbed at her elbow.

"You should bring her around more often Cat," Perfuma suggested while picking up plates, sending Catra a stern look as she did so. It seemed that was more of an instruction than an idea.

Catra laughed and rolled her eyes. "I'm getting that from Scorp too. Ill have Starla come over next week for dinner so she can meet Flora if that works for you two."

Perfuma hummed her approval and pressed a kiss to Scorpia's temple. "That sounds great Catra. Let Scorpia know what day. I've got to get back." She gave them a soft smile and then walked back to the register.

"How is Flora?" Catra asked after the rambunctious child.

Scorpia's eyes lit up. "Oh, she's great! She stayed with Perfuma's folks when we went out the other night. She loves when they babysit so she might have had more fun than we did." Flora was turning four soon and everything that was different was fun. Catra missed when Finn was that small.

"We should have the kids play together soon." Catra suggested. With all the back and forth, Finn had been missing time with their found family unless it was babysitting time and that didn't sit well with her. The closest thing to a cousin Finn had was Flora, all of the kids in Catra's family lived too far for them to play regularly and Mara didn't have any kids.

"Oh yes! Why don't you come over with Finn when we have dinner with Starla?" Scorpia proposed, stirring her mostly empty drink.

Catra winced looking back at the plants on the windowsill. If only things were that simple.

"Finn and Starla havent met yet. I dont think it would be the best environment to introduce them." She explained, once again feeling off-balance in this conversation.

Scorpia nodded understandingly. "Can I ask why they havent met?" She asked cautiously. Catra looked at the vines again, tracing the contours with her eyes.

"Adora and I havent talked to them about us seeing other people," Catra admitted as she rested her head in her hands. "Im not sure how to navigate it with Finn. Theyre so resilient, and took everything well so far, but theyre just a kid. Theyve already gone through so much, even before we adopted them." All Catra's worries spilled forward. She loved Finn to pieces and she wondered if she failed them by not making things work with Adora.

Scorpia eyed Catra seriously. "Are you sure that you are *just* worried about Finn?" Her voice took on a leading pitch, indicating she had *opinions* on the subject.

Catra groaned at being called out, now hiding behind her hands. "I mean, Im also trying to not complicate things with Starla? It's weird dating someone who I just met. Im not sure how to create intimacy from scratch. I always had that before—I mean Adora and I met on the playground!" Catra's tone edged on whining.

She never had to explain to Adora, she just knew Catra like the back of her hand. Hell, shed been there for most of her life. She didnt have to tell Adora stories about high school breakups or childhood knee scrapes, she was the one who picked up all the pieces of Catra and helped put them back together. Until now that was. With Starla, everything was new which was just as exhilarating as it was terrifying.

"I mean you dated before Adora." Scorpia pointed out.

"Yeah, I'm not sure a handful of dates with you and a few of the other girls in college really counts, Scorp." She glared at her friend for being optimistic to the point of ignoring reality. She sighed, looking at Catra with sympathy.

"I get what you mean. Even back then I could tell that you weren't particularly invested in anyone else." Scorpia acknowledged. "That has to be really tough, Cat. Starting from scratch I mean."

"It is. But I want to try to figure it out because I really like spending time with Starla. I can be who I am now without the baggage of who I used to be."

Catra tried to find the words to describe how freeing it felt to be with someone who didn't know every bad haircut, every loose tooth, every disappointment, every failure. She pressed her lips together, coming up short. Adora had been familiar and safe, but Catra wasn't sure she saw *her* anymore. It felt impossible to untangle the present from the past with the person she used to share everything with.

Catra tipped her mug up, taking a sip. "I mean you know the attitude I had when I went on that blind date with Starla, it's a miracle we made it to a second date." Scorpia hummed in acknowledgment. "But we did, and I worry how much further we can get if I don't introduce her to Finn and commit more fully."

It weighed on Catra's mind. There was something about Starla that made Catra comfortable in a way she hadn't been in a long while. She didn't want to lose that. But she couldn't compromise Finn and their well-being. She pressed her lips together, not wanting to consider the problem any longer.

Scorpia seemed to notice her distress. "If you figured it out after DT of all people set you up, I think you'll both be fine." She soothed.

Catra laughed at that. "Yeah, you are right. We'll figure it out."

Then

She *really* didn't think she needed to be here. She waited at a coffee shop for a girl, the most cliché of blind dates. She moved out of her house into her apartment six months ago and she thought it was still too soon to start dating. It didn't feel right.

But DT, the Horde's Tattoos receptionist and social media manager, wore her down, insisting that this Starla character was somehow perfect for Catra. She rolled her eyes at DT's antics. *I don't even know if D'Artagnan is her real name, that's how dramatic they are. Why did I let them set me up on this date?*

That's right, because DT said they were done with her moping. For the record, Catra didn't mope at least not publicly. If anything, she brooded that's what tattoo artists did. DT kept pretending to sympathize by saying things like *I'd be sad too darling if I couldn't climb that tree trunk of a wife you have.* It was hell.

It was fine. She was sure that Starla was going to be off the walls like DT, the date would tank, and she'd have evidence to show the world she should be left alone indefinitely. It ultimately wasn't a real date even. She tried to ignore the pit in her stomach as she waited.

"Hi, are you Catra?" She looked up at the soft sound and caught sight of who she assumed was Starla.

The first thing she noticed was how short Starla was shorter than Catra even and how bouncy her blonde curls were. She didn't know that Starla was her type, but she was certainly beautiful.

"Yes, you must be Starla." They walked up to the barista and got a drink, a cappuccino for Catra and a cold brew for Starla.

"Haven't you heard that coffee is supposed to be hot?" She teased as she took a sip from her own hot drink. The shorter woman rolled her eyes.

"Please, you're drinking a mountain of foam—save me the judgment," Starla replied dryly. Catra laughed, surprised by the swift response. "So, you're a tattoo artist?" Starla prompted.

Catra felt a smidgen uneasy talking about her job but pushed past the discomfort. "Yeah, I'm newer than most since I went to college instead of straight to my apprenticeship—waste of time, but I got to where I needed to be." The edges of a smile played on her lips as she thought about the look on a client's face when they saw her creation for the first time.

"It isn't a waste of time if you are where you need to be." Starla chided. She pushed her hand forward, palm up as if asking for something. Catra stared at it and tilted her head, puzzled by the unspoken demand. "Well then, let me see your art." Starla elaborated.

Catra felt caught off guard—someone hadn't asked about her work in a long time. She felt odd as she pulled up the Horde's Instagram account, somehow nervous about what this girl would think. But that was silly, this girl wasn't anyone to Catra, she showed her work to clients all the time.

"Here, let me show you three and you guess which one I did." Catra grinned. She pulled up two of Lonnie's tattoos and one of hers.

"This one has to be yours." She said definitively, pointing at the second picture Catra showed her. Starla was right—it was a back piece of a galaxy, full of deep purples and blues. She'd picked it because she loved the colors, it was a signature of Catra's.

"How'd you know?" Catra asked, genuinely curious.

"There's just something about it." Starla looked up and their gaze caught for a moment. "And I figured you'd showcase a galaxy for a girl whose name has the word star in it," Starla added, eyes twinkling.

Catra let out a full-bellied laugh. "I didn't even think of that! I swear I wasn't trying to be so cheesy."

"It's okay if you were." Starla offered, eyes warm. Starla continued to scroll the Instagram account, occasionally pausing to take in more details. "These really are amazing. Why'd you choose that color?"

She pointed to an ocean blue in one of her other works. Catra bit her lip. The truth was that it reminded her of Adora's eyes. It was often that her work was inspired by her wife.

"It resonated with me." Catra pushed the thoughts of Adora away. "What about you? What do you do when you aren't getting coffee with strangers?" Catra asked.

"I just play in a band." Starla shrugged.

Catra's eyes widen. "Wait, you had me searching for my lame tattoos when I'm sitting across from a rockstar?" She teased, holding out her hand the same way that Starla had when they first sat down.

Starla rolled her eyes, a slight blush creeping up her cheeks. "Rock *star* is also cheesy and I'm calling you out," Starla informed her as she searched through her phone.

She handed it to Catra who immediately pressed play. She played the bass and the backup vocals, in perfect rhythm and harmony with the rest of her band. The guy standing behind her on the guitar looked familiar, but Catra couldn't place him.

"That's really cool Starla." Catra stated honestly. "Can I see more?"

"Only if you show me more tattoos." Starla challenged with a grin. Catra's smile grew wide to match.

"Deal." She agreed easily. They crept closer so they could both look at the screen.

When DT arranged the blind date, Starla and Catra agreed to meet for about forty-five minutes. An hour and a half later they were still sitting in the cafe, chatting amicably between peals of laughter.

"You aren't what I expected." Catra commented, hoping Starla wouldn't take it poorly.

Starla raised an eyebrow highlighting a smattering of freckles high on her cheeks. "Why, were you expecting someone as dramatic and ridiculous as DT?" Don't worry, I was too." Starla let out a giggle. It was high-pitched and seemed to bounce off the walls.

Catra had to go pick up Finn soon. She didn't remember the last time she felt so seen while on a date. Starla was incredibly attentive, fun, and gorgeous. Catra felt that they connected well, at the very least they could make good friends with their common interests in art and music.

"I had a great time Catra. DT was right, you are a catch." Starla bit her bottom lip and looked up from beneath her eyelashes. *Oh-oh. This was flirting.* Catra sighed and looked away from the interested and interesting girl.

"Starla, I'm not sure how much DT told you, but I'm currently separating from my wife, and I have a kid. I'm not looking for anything serious right now." Well, that was one way to ruin a perfectly nice time out. *Still, honesty is the best policy and all that.* Starla was a great girl and the last thing Catra wanted to do was hurt her.

"Yeah, Dee told me, you know what a gossip they are. But if you aren't actively reconciling and we're upfront with each other, I wouldn't mind going on a second date." Starla flashed her a winning smile. She was very warm. Starla was genuine and Catra liked that. It couldn't hurt to get to know her.

"Okay. One more date can't hurt." Catra readily agreed, shoving down a bit of what felt like guilt.

Now

They were almost done eating lunch when Scorpia looked up at Catra tentatively. *b-oh, that look can't be good* . Scorpia was anything but tentative when spending time with Catra.

"Wildcat, have you considered when you are going to hire a divorce lawyer? I know that Glimmer or Bow might have better leads but I can ask around and see"— *Oh that's what this is about. The divorce*.

"I appreciate it but it' s not necessary right now. Ill let you know big gal, ok?"

Scorpia grabbed Catra's hand holding it to the table between them. "Look Catra, it has been almost a year since you moved out of the house. You and Adora deserve closure so you can both properly move on with your life. It is probably affecting the Starla thing we talked about earlier! I know it' s none of my business" Catra could feel her temper rising.

"You're right Scorpia, it *is* none of your business." She snapped. She flinched internally at the hurt look Scorpia sent her. She'd probably have to apologize for that later . Catra lost her bluster, her shoulders caving in. "You're right. And I will get around to it I just I feel like Adora and I are actually getting along for Finn's sake, and I dont want to rock the boat right now."

Scorpia sighed but nodded. Catra looked away to avoid getting caught in a blatant lie. She and Adora werent fighting exactly , but they hadnt had an actual conversation that didnt involve the logistical nightmare that was dropping off and picking up Finn since Catra put down a deposit on her apartment ten months ago. The truth is, something unnamable tugged at her gut when she thought of filing the paperwork, taking that last step to accept that she and Adora were truly over and done with. Scorpia didnt notice the lie though.

"I understand, I know Finn comes first I just don't want you to get hurt if this drags out longer than it already has." Catra rolled her eyes and gave Scorpia a pointed look. *Im already hurting big gal* . Scorpia smiled sheepishly back.

"I know Scorp, I appreciate it. And I appreciate the free lunch even more," she joked. "Do you think I could get another iced cof fee in a to-go cup?"

"Sure. Y ou know, I didn't remember that you like iced cof fee." Scorpia pointed out casually. She flagged her wife down while pointing at Catra's empty mug.

"I didn't before, it' s just something that grew on me." Catra shrugged. Perfuma delivered a to-go and Catra said her goodbyes.

She gave Scorpia a hug and walked back to work, thinking about getting a lawyer. Her stomach churned. She knew things between her and Adora were long gone. She wasn't sure what she was waiting for to actually file for divorce, but she knew one things she wasn't ready yet.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys enjoyed a look into Catra's POV! I know there wasn't a lot of catradora here. Some of the first few chapters will be like that given that they are separated, but we will get more catradora as the fic progresses. As always kudos and comments are super appreciated!

Next week: Adora's POV of the fight that ended it all.

A Constant Ringing

Chapter Summary

Glimmer asks permission.

Adora takes a phone call.

Ms. Hope makes demands.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After handling three meetings and two conference calls, Adora finally found herself in her work office alone. She closed her eyes for a moment, a headache blaring behind her eyes from staring down at her computer screen for far too long. She pressed her fingers to her temples, rubbing and hoping for the headache to subside.

She really didn't have time for the pain, she had an afternoon meeting to prepare for. She was presenting one of their latest products to a new client, so she really had to show up for it. She idly wondered why Frosta couldn't have done the last three meetings so she could get ready for this one.

Her phone rang and she cursed aloud before answering it, tapping her foot on the carpeting in her office.

"Adora Grey speaking." She answered in a brisk short tone, hoping to discourage whoever was on the other end of the line.

She heard a tell-tale sigh in response. "Adora, you really need to look at your caller ID, it is *so* annoying. Sometimes, I think I misdialed and called someone at *my* company." Glimmer squeaked on the other side of the line.

Adora sighs, keeping her mouth away from the speaker in hopes that her best friend won't overhear. Of course, Glimmer called her in the middle of the day. Who else would? *Catra used to send you messages all the time—*

"Glim now isn't a good time, I just really need to focus on"—Glimmer's snort cut out the rest of Adora's well-reasoned explanation.

"Yeah, I know. The universe will collapse on itself if you don't save the day. Look, I'm calling because you're my best friend and I wanna do right by you. I need you to be honest right now."Glimmer's voice held a nervous edge.

Adora kept her eyes closed as she answered. "What is it, Glim?"She kept another exasperated sigh to herself wishing her friend would just tell her whatever it is so she can get back to work.

"So, Bow thinks that we need to do something at our house to make Starla feel welcome, but *I* think we need to get Catra to stop being so *stupid*—"Adora cut Glimmer's rant short. feeling the heat of anger rising in her throat.

"Don't talk about Catra that way!"Adora snapped with her hand back onto the bridge of her nose.

Glimmer remained unphased, continuing on. "Yes I know you love her—love her *too* I'm just worried about you both!"Glimmer exclaimed. Adora's headache felt like a full-on migraine.

Adora hesitated for a moment. She thought of Catra with Starla—vibrant, cute, short, bubbly Starla.

"Glim, if I ask you something will you tell me?"Be honest with me? And—and never tell anyone I asked?"She felt so exposed even just *thinking* about asking the question. She might die of humiliation before she got the words out.

Glimmer's answer was immediate. "Of course, Adora, anything you need." Glimmer said seriously , a curious tinge to her words. Adora's face burned red with her embarrassment. She put a hand to her face, as if hiding would make it better.

"Do you think Starla is more attractive than me?" She spat out the question quickly , ripping it off like a band-aid. She'd pondered the question ad nauseam in the silence of her own house when she was feeling bereft. It couldn't be the reason Catra left but damn if Adora didn't feel insecure.

Glimmer guffawed on the line. "Adora no! You know you're a buff babe!" Glimmer soothed, humor still clear in her voice. "If anything, I think you've gotten even more attractive with all the time you spend at the gym when you don't have Finn." Glimmer tacked on.

Adora scratched the back of her neck at the observation. The gym was one of the only places Adora went where she didn't feel or yearn.

"But Starla is younger , she's *artsy*" Adora said artsy like a curse word "and she's having sex with my wife. I can't help but feel like she has something I don't." Adora whispered into the phone feeling the need to defend her moment of weakness.

Adora would never admit it to another living human being, but she looked at pictures of Catra and Starla on social media. It was so jarring seeing Catra with someone who seemed to be the walking anti-thesis to Adora. Where Adora was tall and muscular, Starla was short and soft, more femme than Adora could ever hope to be. It felt like what Catra truly wanted couldn't be farther from what Adora was.

Glimmer sighed softly. "Adora, Starla is not what's keeping you and Catra apart. I know that you haven't seen them together but it just it isn't some lifelong love you know? Not like what you two had." Glimmer explained softly . Adora winced. *Had.* That stung.

"Glim, I really didn't think this separation would last this long," Adora breathed into the phone as she closed her eyes. "Cat's my home Glim, and I thought I was hers."

Adora's bent her head forward to press against her desk, feeling more hopeless than ever. Her whole life had been falling apart for a while now, but there were moments like this that Adora could swear the roof was collapsing on her head where she stood. Glimmer was silent ~~for~~ once ~~on~~ the other end of the line. She picked up one of her many fountain pens and twirled it around her fingers.

"Honestly, Adora I never thought you two would be apart for this long either." Glimmer's voice was filled not only with sadness but with something worse ~~d~~doubt.

"You don't think we are going to stay together, do you? Or I guess— get back together." Adora asked her closest friend. The silence was deafening.

"I- I don't know and at this point. I don't think encouraging you would be healthy Adora. For you or for her." Glimmer didn't think they would pull through, and Adora could hardly blame her.

"I thought that she needed space, Glim. Everyone said I should leave her alone. That she still loved me, and she would come back home." Adora ran her fingers through her hair exasperated with how badly she misread the situation. "We've been best friends since first-grade Glim! We're married and we have Finn ~~w~~what am I supposed to do, be happy with Catra as a practical stranger?" She knew her voice carried a desperate edge but she couldn't find it within herself to care.

She'd never gone this long without Catra. Yes, she was her wife but ever since she was a kid she had Catra to confide in, to lean on, and that had never been missing in her life. How was she supposed to pick up the pieces of herself when Catra took most of them with her when she left?

"I know Adora—I understand that this is difficult for you. I'm not trying to downplay that." Glimmer explained, trying to be supportive. Adora sighed. No matter how much they talked about it, Glimmer just didn't get it.

"I know Glim. It just feels like it snowballed from a week staying at Scorpia's then a lease and now Starla. It's like I blinked, and my marriage went from fine to non-existent." She complained, fully sinking into her own pity party.

"Was it fine Adora?" Glimmer asked, her voice taking on a challenging tone that Adora knew well. She was being called out on her shit. She slumped over her desk even further.

"It wasn't," Adora admitted. She tugged at her blonde hair. "But the things I thought were small problems and temporary clearly weren't. I wasn't paying attention to Catra. I was a bad partner to her." To a degree, she knew these things. It didn't make her any less alone now.

"Look Adora, I'm sorry I didn't mean for this to get all heavy… although in hindsight maybe this could have waited until after work." Adora rolled her eyes, thankful that Glimmer couldn't see. "I need to know that if we invite Starla to something you will still know you are our girl, and we love you to pieces."

Adora sighed. She appreciated the gesture, but it was unnecessary. "It's fine, I won't take it the wrong way. I want Cat to be happy and if that means being with someone else then I have to adjust to that." She paused to swallow the lump in her throat. "Whether it's Starla or some other person. Clearly, I wasn't giving her what she needed."

Adora felt herself sinking into a sad puddle, a sensation she had become extremely familiar with in the last year. But she meant what she said to Glimmer—she'd stand back and let Catra be happy. She owed her that much after everything.

"What about you?" Adora suddenly heard the voice coming through her phone. Oh, Glimmer was still talking.

"What about me?" Adora replied, confused by what Glimmer was referring to.

"When are you going to get a girlfriend?" Adora gripped the side of her desk, knuckles turning white.

"Glim, we have been over this, I've gone out on dates before"—

Glimmer angrily scoffed. "No Adora, you've gone to bars and flexed your biceps and gotten laid, that's not the same thing." She let out an exasperated sigh. "You aren't going to get over Catra"—

Adora closed her eyes again. "There is no getting over Catra for me, Glim. I don't want to string along some poor woman and leave her high and dry emotionally. My heart isn't mine to give. It never has been." Adora had been Catra's for longer than she knew what to do with. There was nothing after Catra and even if there was, Adora didn't want to try. Anything else would be lesser, she knew it deep in her bones.

Glimmer sighed again, this time in defeat. Adora grins prepared to unleash retribution on her friend. "Besides, at least this way, the girls I date get orgasms out of it." She teased.

Glimmer was flummoxed on the line. "Ew Adora!"

Adora laughed. "You brought it up first!" She countered. Adora could tell Glimmer rolled her eyes when she said goodbye. Adora leaned back into her chair relieved to finally be off the phone.

The conversation weighed heavy in her gut, as most conversations about her marriage did these days. She knew she was to blame for it falling apart, she just wished she knew how to change that.

Then

Adora paced in her bedroom waiting for a work call. Someone—*most likely Kyle*, she thought—messed up one of the books and now as senior manager, she had to deal with the fallout. She scheduled a meeting with Ms. Hope, the Bright Moon branch manager, and any minute now and she was going to get her ass handed to her.

Things had been going well at work, so well in fact, that she was promoted to the youngest senior manager in the company. Now at thirty-two, she felt she really needed to push to keep moving, and covering for Kyle's mess-ups was just one of the unfortunate parts of the job. She thought about how she was going to smooth things over with Ms. Hope. Her gut tugged at her, nausea at the thought of her disappointed tone.

In the middle of her fretting, she missed Catra walking into their bedroom.

"Adora, I really need to talk to you right now." Catra sounded a bit upset, but lately, when wasn't she upset with her? Nothing she did was good enough.

Adora closed her eyes and breathed slowly through her nose, trying to prevent the panic from setting in. She looked down at her phone.

"I know, I hear you, let's just wait after this work call. Something went wrong and I have to be available." She explained smoothly, turning to start pacing again, hoping that Catra would leave her alone for at least the next half hour.

Instead, Catra grabbed her arm, tugging so that she turned to face her. "No Adora this won't keep. We need to talk right *now*." It was clear that Catra had been holding back before—her voice was seething, eyes wild with anger.

Adora's gut clenched as she glanced between the phone in her hand and her wife. "Cat, you know I wouldn't do this if it weren't important.

I have to talk to Ms. Hope about this report Kyle bungled up." She tried again, pleading with her.

She knew Catra wanted to talk about something or another since yesterday. *I think maybe it's about Finn's recital that's coming up, I probably need to block that onto my calendar soon.*

"Adora you aren't listening! I've been trying to talk to you for the last three days and you never have time!" Adora looked up from her phone exasperated. She can feel the tension in her shoulders like she had all week and Catra is not making it better.

"I'll have a moment after this call babe, I just need to take this any minute now." She grabbed Catra's hand squeezing it reassuringly, holding on tightly to her phone with the other.

Catra scoffed snatching her hand back violently. "Okay, you know what? I thought we could talk about this but clearly, there isn't anything to discuss. I'm just going to say it." Catra's words felt like an anvil falling on her head. "I packed a bag and I'm staying with Scorp and Fuma."

Adora froze, something was out of place. *Why plan an overnight stay today?* It was Wednesday, they liked keeping Finn home on school nights.

"What do you mean? I don't remember planning a sleepover and I think Finn has a history test tomorrow." Adora trails off as she really took Catra in, her eyes flashing and angry, body shaking. Catra stared hard at her until it clicks. This isn't a social event Adora forgot to plug into her calendar.

"No. Cat what—why are you doing this?" Her voice sounded far away and pathetic even to her own ears. Adora stared at Catra hoping that she could find an explanation for what was happening. All she finds is red hot anger blazing in Catra's eyes.

"You care more about what is happening at your work than here at home." Catra accused, nostrils flaring. "Ever since you've been supervised by Hope you've been desperate to get her approval, no matter the cost. It's just like with Weaver!"

Adora's eyes widen, and she shakes her head ~~tha~~t simply wasn't true. "Why are you bringing Weaver into this? I just have a work call ~~thi~~s isn't about her!" Adora's voice pitched up as she discussed her long-time caretaker.

"No, Adora it isn't a work call! You were the youngest senior manager and now you want to be the youngest branch manager! For what? You can't tell me it has nothing to do with Weaver." Catra leveled at her, laying it all out at her feet. "Hope taps into that need you have. She sees that you just want someone to think that you're special and to be proud of you. Well, guess what Adora? That's what your family is for. Not some job." She said dismissively, face furled in an deep sneer.

Adora took a deep breath, jaw clenching. "I understand that you're frustrated." ~~A~~dora took in Catra's chest heaving, her hands clenched into tight fists "~~bu~~t you shouldn't attack me. I know what validation I get from home and what I get from the office, and I don't appreciate the accusations you are throwing at me right before I have an important work call that I'm already stressed about!" She tried to keep her voice level but by the end of it, she was yelling.

Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes. "That's the fucking point, Adora. You're so busy with work you don't have time to appreciate *anything* I have to say anymore." Catra's shoulders suddenly slumped over, as if all the fight drained out of her. "I'm done with this Adora." Catra whispered.

Adora's veins turned to ice. She'd never heard Catra sound so heartbroken.

"Catra, no. What can I do to fix ~~th~~is?" She knew she was begging, she wasn't too proud to admit it. Catra stared impassively back, her

eyes boring into Adora's as if willing her to understand something. Frankly, she looked barely able to stand straight. The sight made Adora's heart clench.

"If you need to ask Adora, you clearly haven't been paying attention. I'll call you about picking up Finn from school tomorrow." Catra turned, one hand on the doorknob and the other on her suitcase.

Adora was having an out-of-body experience, this couldn't possibly be happening to her. She noticed the suitcase Catra was grabbing was bulging. She thought Catra meant she was leaving for the night but clearly this wasn't like the nights Adora spent on the couch.

"How~~ho~~w long till you come back home?" Adora's fingers twitched, helpless as she waited for an answer. She had to come back home.

Catra loosened her grip on the doorknob and turned back. Her eyes softened and her jaw relaxed. She looked more like the Catra that Adora knew, a tired and torn version of her.

"I'm not sure Dora. I~~"a~~ sharp ringing breaks through the tension in the room, leaving its own kind of tension in its wake. She cursed every star she was born under as she looked down at her hand where her forgotten phone was. This was her phone call with Ms. Hope. *Fucking Ms. Hope.*

She looked desperately between the phone and Catra feeling stuck in an impossible choice. Catra made the decision for her, turning around and hiding her face.

"Take your phone call, Adora. I'll talk to you tomorrow," she whispered.

Swallowing the lump in her throat, Adora answered her phone as she watched Catra leave their bedroom, luggage in hand.

"Adora Grey speaking."

Now

Adora put down her phone and looked up at her computer. *Shit! The two o'clock meeting!* Adora groaned and wished the day over. She had thirty minutes to prepare. Adora focused on the figures that were relevant to her presentation today.

Thankfully, what she was presenting had plenty of similarities with another presentation she did a few months ago. With that as a baseline, she covered more ground. Within fifteen minutes she knew she could deliver this presentation with little trouble. After all, she was good at her job.

As she put some finishing touches on her notes, she heard a distinct clacking that stopped right in front of her office door. That could only mean one thing. A perfunctory knock sounded at her office door. Before she had a chance to respond that it was alright to come in, Ms. Hope entered her office.

Ms. Hope was the Bright Moon branch manager of Eternia Industries for as long as anyone could remember, a tall, regal, and intimidating woman. Adora stood from behind her desk. She felt small under Ms. Hope's gaze.

"Adora, I see that you have a meeting scheduled soon. Typically, you would already be in the room setting up. Is something the matter?" Ms. Hope inquired, sounding almost bored.

Adora suppressed the urge to roll her eyes. She learned the hard way that Ms. Hope wasn't particularly good with personal issues.

"Nothing is wrong. I'll be ready to present and I'm confident the presentation will go well." She flashed Ms. Hope a smile, attempting to soften her. It didn't really work.

"You know Adora, I will soon be leaving my position here as the Bright Moon branch manager. I'm being promoted to manage a

larger branch out in Eternia.” Ms. Hope put one finger on Adora’s desk and then looked at it as if inspecting for dust.

“I didn’t know that. Congratulations.” Adora offered with a small smile. There were rumors to that effect for the last few months, but this was the first time Adora heard it confirmed.

Hope kept talking as if Adora hadn’t spoken. “I was hoping to recommend you to be my replacement, but you seemed a bit distant from your work recently. I would hate to recommend you for the position and be left disappointed.” Ms. Hope’s lips curled into a sneer.

Adora heard that nagging internal voice that sounded like her foster mother, *You can strive to be better Adora, you have so much potential. Is this the best you could do?* Adora’s response was kneejerk.

“If you recommend me, you won’t be disappointed.” Adora guaranteed, standing tall. She knew she looked the picture of self-confidence, even if she didn’t feel an ounce of it under Hope’s calculating stare.

“That’s what I like to hear from you, Adora.” Ms. Hope left Adora to pick up her mess. She had a meeting to get to.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah, I don’t like Adora much right now either lol.

This chapter establishes their conflict but pieces of it will continue to be fleshed out through the next few chapters.

I always always always appreciate kudos and comments, they are the fuel that help me put my writing together.

I actually had a great writing week, wrote a bunch of new material and finished up some WIP that are now on the editing

slate! Im really excited to share with y'all.

Next week (Catra POV): Catra and Starla go out on a date and Catra and Adora miss one.

I also might have a surprise one shot to post soon 👀

An Overlooked Artist

Chapter Summary

Starla and Catra go to an art museum.

Catra gets stood up.

Catra has a difficult conversation.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I think this is my favorite one," Starla whispered. She could feel Starla's breath on her ear and when she pulled back to look at her, her eyes sparkled. She leaned down and placed a soft kiss on her lips.

They were at the local art museum for the opening of an 'up and coming artist' but the alleged artist was kind of a dud in Catra's estimation. Catra and Starla made fun of the terrible paintings for the last hour, quiet whispers past back and forth in the low display lights.

"I guess that one isn't as bad as the rest." Catra hummed eyes flashing between the painting and her girlfriend. "Want to make the rounds and pick our least favorite?" She murmured conspiratorially as she waggled her eyebrows.

Starla nodded her head gleefully. As they walked around Starla settled her head on Catra's shoulder, holding her hand. A few of the other more snooty guests rolled their eyes at the display.

"When's your next gig?" Catra asked as she moved Starla on to the next painting. This one is of a sunflower, the type of painting college girls put up in their dorm rooms. Starla wrinkled her nose but didn't comment on it.

"Next Saturday . Do you wanna come?" Starla asked, tightening her hold on Catra's hand.

Catra winced. "I would love to, but I have Finn this weekend." She lamented as she pressed her lips together. While she never regretted her time with Finn, she did wish she could go see Starla's show. She'd only been to a few between her work and mom schedule.

"Well things will probably be a little quieter for a few weeks because Jewelstar is pretty busy, but I'll let you know for the next one." She allowed easily, tucking herself more firmly under Catra's arm as they continued to start and stop taking a second view of the exhibit.

"Yeah, of course. I'll clear my schedule. I had a blast last time." Catra told her. Starla felt like someone else when she was on stage. She was always confident and sweet but Catra had never seen her so in her element as she did when she was performing with her band. It was hot, the way she'd smirked down at Catra from the small stage and the way she'd kissed her afterward—

Starla gestured at the painting they happen to be in front of a splotchy blue and yellow monster. "That one is not *that* bad, I guess?" Starla said in a tone so dubious she clearly barely believed the words herself.

Catra squinted at the painting Starla pointed out, leaning further into her forcing her to push back under Catra's weight. She was practically hanging off her girlfriend at this point, just being a little shit.

"I don't know Star , that looks like my kid could have painted it." Starla slapped her arm and giggled, leaning her head on Catra's shoulder, trying to right her. It was odd being the taller one in a relationship, albeit by half an inch. She was used to being the one pushing against a giant dummy trying to squish her , not doing the squishing.

The intrusive thought made Catra stand up straighter, finally taking the excess weight of f of Starla's shoulder. Her girlfriend didn't seem to notice the change in her, instead leaning closer as she dragged her lips gently across her neck.

"You are going to get us kicked out of here," Starla whispered urgently. She might have sounded mad if she wasn't still breathless from her giggle. Catra was going to point out that kissing would probably do more to get them kicked out than art critique, but she wisely chose t stay silent.

They leisurely walked together to the next painting. "Maybe we can come back to a better art exhibit with Finn someday." She suggested.

Catra did her best to not twitch at that. Starla's tone was light and airy, but the implication was clear. It isn't the first time she brought up meeting Finn and Catra assured her it was on the table, just not right away.

"Yeah, that would be nice, Finn has an artistic streak in them. They tend towards performance arts though." She kept her tone even.

"Maybe I can show them my guitar then." Starla smiled like her namesake.

"That sounds nice." She allowed. They kept walking, the silence felt a little more loaded now.

"How'd you know you wanted a kid?" The question caught Catra off-guard. When Starla asked these questions, Starla's twenty-seven felt so much *younger* than Catra's. Catra was Starla's age when she adopted Finn and now over five years later, not one piece of her regrets that decision.

"We just I mean it's" Catra tried to put into words the longing that filled her chest when she decided that she wanted to adopt. "Adoption is complicated. It should be a child-centered process, you

know? You want to make sure you are doing it to provide a home to a kid, not because of your desire to be a parent."

Starla nodded but she didn't see any understanding in her eyes. Catra could tell she wasn't really getting it. Starla was a bit of a free spirit she didn't think she'd ever felt that type of need.

She sighed. "Sometimes you just realize it's time." She decided to say. It was the type of ambiguous platitude that most people accepted when it came to things like motherhood. "Kind of heavy for an art museum." She smiled at her girlfriend and moved closer, trying to distract her girlfriend from follow-up questions.

She tried her best to explain but honestly, she didn't want to have a deep talk about how desperately she wanted to be a mother and how much Finn meant to her. How even if they hadn't wanted her to be their *mama* with all that entailed she would still support them and love them with her whole heart. All those answers were deeply personal and tied intrinsically with the woman she most wanted to avoid thinking about on a date night. She'd thought of her enough.

A large part of why Catra knew she wanted to adopt was based on how shitty she knew being a foster kid had turned out for Adora. It helped her understand that she had to set her ego aside to be whatever it was Finn needed, whether that was a parent or some other support figure. Exposing those parts of her past, the parts that bled so deeply with Adora felt wrong. So she chose not to.

Starla's eyes dimmed, and a look of disappointment flashed through her face. Before Catra could feel bad about it, Starla leaned closer and kissed her. She ran her fingertips through Starla's blonde hair and sighed into the kiss.

"I think we could have a better time in your apartment than in this art museum. We can come back another day." Starla's voice had dropped down sultry and low.

Catra was definitely in for a late night, and she felt herself smirking at the thought. She also felt a pang of guilt but buried it. She had every right to a great end for her date night with her girlfriend.

Then

"Do you want me to give you another few minutes?" Catra hated the way the waitress sounded embarrassed asking Catra this question for the third time in a row. She swayed from side to side unsure how to proceed, clenching the little notebook she used to jot notes.

She took pity on the poor girl. "Can I get a glass of wine and a few minutes for my order?" She tried to keep the frustration out of her voice, but it was hard given what was happening.

Catra was stood up—*again*. By her wife. She sat at her and Adora's favorite restaurant, ignoring the increasing pitying looks that she received from the waitstaff who knew them. This was so fucking embarrassing.

Mystacor was a nice restaurant that they discovered while in college. Adora brought her here for the first time for their first anniversary. Back when they were in school, they could only afford to come once or twice a year at most. At one point during their marriage, Adora would bring her at least once a month, it had become a staple in a robust rotation of date night places.

Catra couldn't have imagined Adora canceling on one of their Mystacor dates—she was never even late. Always on time, dressed to the nines and smiling as if she was the luckiest person in the room. They would talk for hours, sometimes sharing a bottle of wine, sometimes not, and on special nights they would take off their shoes and walk on the small lakeshore by the restaurant and count their stars. Not the case anymore.

"Is there anything I can get you Catra?" The manager, Casta, had come out this time to add insult to injury. Catra sunk further into her

seat, not wanting to be further humiliated in front of a woman she knew practically since she moved to Bright Moon all those years ago.

"Can I just get our usual to go? And some extra fries for Finn." She asked, not feeling like looking at the menu and trying something new. She just wanted to get out of here and lick her wounds in peace.

Casta gave her shoulder a gentle squeeze. "You got it, the fries and the wine are on me this time." She smiled at Catra warmly, but Catra still felt cold. *You know you've reached a new level of pathetic when you make people sad enough to give you free food.* She nodded her acknowledgment and watched Casta disappear towards the back of the restaurant.

She called Adora's phone again, mentally sending out murderous vibes in hopes that she would finally answer. It seemed to work, Adora picked up on the fifth ring.

"Adora Grey speaking." Her voice comes through crystal clear but tired. *Great, she didn't even bother to look at her caller D*. Catra gripped the side of her table and prayed for patience.

"Adora it's your *wife* calling from Mystacor, *wondering* where you've been for the last hour?" She kept her voice dead even in hopes of not calling attention to her phone call. She had enough embarrassment without causing a scene.

She rolled her eyes as she heard a string of cursing from the other side of the line. "Shit Cat! I'm so sorry I got caught up on a project Ms. Hope assigned last minute, you know how it's been lately I—" Catra imagined Adora's blonde hair ruffled as she ran her hands through it, her blue eyes wide in alarm. It would make for a handsome picture if Catra wasnt steaming mad right now.

"Adora I cant *believe* you. This isnt the first time you've stood me up like this, do you even care?" Catra whispered urgently into her phone, eyes darting to anyone who might overhear. She shouldnt be

asking her this over the phone but it felt like she never got to see her or talk to her.

"Cat how could you even ask me that? Of course I care, I honestly lost track of time. I would never do this to you on purpose." Her voice was thick with tears and pleading how it always got when Adorea realized she fucked up.

Catra sighed running her fingers through her hair. She left her hand there, resting her head on her palm.

"I know Adora, I know , can you just tell me if you can make it here sometime soon or should I just pick up Finn from Glim and Bow's?" She avoided eye contact with the waitress that'd been passing by the table every five minutes. The silence on the other end told her everything she needed to know. "Look I'm going to grab Finn and go home. I really dont feel like being out anymore anyway ."

Catra was glad she already asked Casta to make a to-go bag, suspecting that once again Adora would fail to follow through.

"I'm sorry Cat. I love you. Ill make it up to you, I promise." Catra could barely keep in her snort. *Promise* . Adora's promises used to mean the world to her. She wished they still did, but she cant say she believed in them anymore.

"Stay safe. See you at home." Catra sighed and hung up.

The waitress magically appeared with the check and to-go bags. *Evesdropping for some gossip to spread to the kitchen staff* , Catra mused. Her conversation with Adora would probably end up in Castas's ears by the end of the night. With a curt thank you, she made her way to her car checking out mentally as she made plans to get her kid and go home.

She looked down at her carefully crafted outfit, designed specifically with Adora in mind. She'd taken her time with it, thinking that maybe there would be a chance to reconnect tonight. She scoffed to herself

angrily. Instead, she'd probably run a bath and have some *alone* time. Lord knows the last time her wife touched her. All her problems these days seemed to revolve around Adora.

Adora could make time for her. She made time for Finn, she made time for work, she made time to see Sparkles and Arrow Boy. But, she just never had time for her nowadays. Catra was the bottom rung on a huge list of priorities that Adora had. Honestly, sometimes she felt like she didn't even make it on the ladder.

Something had to give. She would try to sit Adora down—*for the third time this month* she groused—and she would get to the bottom of it. If Adora had fallen out of love or didn't want to be together anymore she could just say so. Catra didn't want to keep Adora for the sake of staying together—she wanted Adora to be happy and in love. But what she wouldn't allow Adora to do was humiliate and jerk Catra around. She refused to be some sad hanger-on who was too in love with her wife to see what was right in front of her.

She didn't care that she loved Adora since she was seven, didn't care that they had Finn—the best kid in the world—to co-parent, didn't care that everyone would probably take golden girl Adora's side. If Adora didn't make her a priority, she would leave. Even if she broke her own heart in the process.

Now

The next day, Catra woke up to Starla's hand tracing gentle lines on her back. She turned around and cuddled up with her. Starla was warm and curvy, making her a great pillow and even better cuddler.

"Good morning," Catra grumbled quietly, burrowing her head in the pillows. She was not a morning person.

"Morning." Starla's reply was equally subdued, although her voice rang out clearer. Catra peeked out from her pillow mound for a moment, trying to adjust her eyes to the brightness of the morning.

I have to get up so I can pick up Finn, Adora has a weekend client meeting, so I have to go save my rugrat from their well-meaning aunt and uncle." Catra rolled her eyes theatrically at her reference to Glimmer and Bow.

"We have dinner with them soon, right?" Starla asked, pressing her forehead to Catra's shoulder.

"Yeah, they invited us over to their house next weekend." She was honestly surprised when Bow reached out with the invite. Glimmer and Catra had grown distant during the divorce, which she still found upsetting. She hoped this could be a chance to patch things up between them.

She sat up in her bed and stretched, shaking off the last remnants of sleep from her body. Getting out of bed was difficult in the morning, but she finally managed it. She was rummaging through her closet when she caught Starla staring at her, eyes alert.

"You look like you've been up for a while," Catra quirked an eyebrow at Starla, expecting her to laugh it off.

Instead, Starla looked at her hesitantly as if contemplating something. Her expression suddenly cleared, and she stood and took Catra's hand.

"Cat. I know we said we are going slow—and I respect that, I do!—but I want to meet Finn soon. Okay?" Starla smiled as bright as her namesake, willing Catra to agree.

Catra pressed her lips together. "You mentioned Finn yesterday too, Star. Mind telling me a little more about what's going on?" She asked. It felt like they kept talking around Finn and she wasn't sure if they were on the same page about them anymore.

"We've been together for a while, and I think we need to start feeling out how we fit into each other's lives more fully. For you, obviously, a

big part of that is Finn. I think it's important for us to explore that." Starla explained as she sat down, leaning against the headboard.

"Okay , I hear that Starla. But Finn isn't some puzzle piece that we have to fit somewhere between us, they are my child. A kid who just lost the only piece of stability that they knew. I'm still not ready for you to meet them yet."It was the truth, even if it was a hard one. "I'll start bringing up the conversation with Adora so that when I am ready, itll just be a matter of setting up a time and place."Catra felt she was being more than fair.

Starla pursed her lips, holding Catra's stare. "Sometimes it feels like youll never be ready for me to meet Finn."She admitted as she stood and walked toward Catra. She wrapped her arms around Starla, placing her chin on her shoulder.

"Finn is my biggest priority when it comes to introducing them to someone. They have experienced a lot of heartache at a really young age~~lo~~sing their birth family and now Adora and I separated ~~it'~~ s a lot for anyone. It's as much about how they feel as it is about how I feel."She explained gently , not wanting Starla to feel rejected. "I need to talk with them, and we need to agree that it' s what's best. It isn't just between you and me, Star . That's part of what being a mom is for me."She'd never hidden this from Starla, and she honestly didn't understand what the rush was.

"I understand, and I didn't mean to make it seem like I don't care about Finn's feelings on the matter. You just talk about them so much that it feels like I already know them. I really want to get to know them."She murmured back into Catra' s neck.

Catra smiled. "And I'm glad that you want to meet my munchkin. I happen to think they are pretty cool."She rubs her hand down Starla's back consolingly. "Star , I'm sure itll happen soon."

Catra couldn't help but feel a twinge of guilt. Her reassurances felt hollow~~s~~he couldn't even begin to think of how she was going to bring this up with Finn.

Chapter End Notes

This isn't my favorite chapter TBH but I felt it was a necessary one. I wasn't messing around when I tagged this slow burn lol

The good news is that I no longer have to work absurd hours at work (at least for the foreseeable future) so I'll have more time to edit and have the next few chapters ready soon!

As always kudos/comments are my lifeblood and 1000% why I post on AO3. Thank you all for your feedback and support.

Edit: I forgot to add the "next week" bit because my brain is functioning at like 30% capacity and I thought I deleted chapter five and I almost had a heart attack but I FOUND IT WHEEW.

Next Week: Adora goes to the gym and runs into Scorpia. In the past, Catra and Adora go to a work event.

A Discarded Concern

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to the gym.

Adora and Catra go to a work event.

Adora talks with Mara.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora was so busy counting out Bow's reps she almost missed when he started speaking. "You know, you don't have to go to a bar to pick up a girl. You could probably pick one up here at the gym!" Bow wiggled his eyebrows at Adora as he finished his set on the bench press.

Adora groaned, switching places with him. She tensed her legs and arched her back, taking a deep breath before moving.

"Bow not you too! Did Glimmer put you up to this? I told her I'm not looking to date anyone right now." She hissed. *Or ever really*. She glared up at her friend, which took effort given that she was also lifting the barbell up.

"Adora relax, it was a joke. You know I respect you and your choices." Bow gave her an open smile and a hand to lift her off the bench. He paused, as if a new thought occurred to him. "Besides we could never come back to this gym if you ghosted a bunch of girls after sleeping with them."

Adora rolled her eyes. She did not *ghost* anyone, thank you very much. "Can't ghost someone if you never get their number." Adora dutifully pointed out. It was a winning argument and she was sticking

to it. Bow shrugged his hands. "Enough about my wreck of a life. How are you, Bow?" She asked as they re-racked their plates. He stuck out his bottom lip, lost in thought.

"I'm good. Nervous about the kids. They have standardized testing this week." He explained with a tight smile. Bow always got antsy around testing season ever since he became a teacher.

"Ugh, I hate when Finnie has to take those tests." She sympathized, adjusting the band of her sports bra. They walked toward the dumbells they planned on using.

"I know! Imagine having twenty-five of them! I always have a few that don't do well with testing no matter how hard they try. It breaks my heart seeing them so nervous and upset." Bow's eyes were suspiciously shiny as he talked about his elementary school students.

"I don't know how you teach third grade. I love Finn to bits, but I don't think I could handle taking care of that many kids at once." Adora grimaced at just the thought of that many grabby hands and curious minds. It would be enough to drive anyone up the wall.

Bow laughed easily. "Well, I can't imagine being stuck in a competitive corporate environment, so I guess it works out for both of us then." Bow put his hood up as he walked in front of her. Adora wasn't sure how one man could have so many crop-top hoodies. She shook her head, picking up a set of dumbbells that looked heavy enough for her overhead press.

"Fair enough. Are you and Glimmer good?" She asked as she came to the top of the rep.

Bow gave her a shy smile. "Yeah, never better. I mean. We're thinking about having a kid." He whispered the last part with a slight bounce on the ball of his feet. Adora gaped at him a huge smile overtaking her face.

"Bow! That's amazing! I'm so happy for you both." She couldn't help herself—she dropped her dumbbells carefully and pulled him into a tight sweaty hug. No one was more deserving in her mind than Glimmer and Bow of having a child.

"We haven't really told anyone, but we're doing our research right now, seeing what options we have." He whispered into her shoulder, hugging her tightly back.

"Well, if you need anything I'd be happy to help in any way I can. You and Glim were a godsend when we were figuring out how to be moms, I'd love to return the favor." She could feel tears welling up in her eyes. She knew her friends were going to be amazing parents.

When Bow pulls back, he's also teary. "I know Adora, thanks." He smiled gratefully as he let her go.

The rest of their workout happened in companionable silence, one of the great things about her friendship with Bow. She didn't feel the need to fill the silence with him, she could just *be*. Every once in a while, she would think about Bow's news and they would end up grinning at each other goofily.

As they got on the treadmills for a cool-down run, Adora spotted Scorpia coming in to start her workout. The only one of her friends who she felt was more distant after her separation was Scorpia.

Scorpia was always protective of Catra, ever since they became close freshman year of college. In fact, Scorpia helped Adora plan out her proposal and pick out a ring for Catra because she knew her best, after Adora of course. *Well, I guess she might be the person who knows Catra the best now period.* The thought made her cringe.

Bow waved her down from his treadmill and she perked up when she saw him. She casually walked over with her gym bag over one broad shoulder.

"Hey , Scorp! How are you doing? What are you working out today?" Bow spit the questions out in rapid succession big smile on his face. Clearly, he hadn't seen Scorpia in a bit.

"It' s leg day! It' s my favorite type of workout really gets me going." She said agreeably, digging a small towel out of her gym bag.

From the brief peek Adora got of the bag, she carried an assortment of bands, foam rollers, and what looked like enough protein powder to kill a horse. Scorpia sounded friendly enough, maybe Adora imagined the distance?

"Hi, Scorpia." Adora tried, a tentative smile on her face. Scorpia must have not noticed her before because her mood changed immediately. Her smile grew polite and cold instead of friendly as she took a step back and zipped up her bag.

"Hi, Adora." She continued to make small talk with Bow and ignored Adora completely. She felt a slow rage bubbling under her skin at being so completely disregarded by someone who was supposed to be her friend. Scorpia said her goodbyes and left to the locker room to change.

After thinking about it for a moment, Adora charged after her, ignoring Bow calling out her name. When she got into the locker room, she was alone with Scorpia. *Good.*

"What's your problem with me?" Adora asked, chest heavy from quickly walking behind Scorpia' s towering footsteps. Scorpia looked up startled, not expecting Adora to burst in.

"I don't have a problem with you." Scorpia' s eyes flashed, she stared at the ground as she spits out the words. Even she couldn't be convinced of that if her tone of voice was any indication.

"Really? Because this isn't the first time you flat-out ignore me as if we haven't been friends for at least a decade. I know you're on Catra's side, but you don't have to treat me like this!" She pushed

closer, getting into Scorpia's space. Irritation flickered in and out of Scorpia's gaze as she looked up to meet Adora's.

"Leave Catra out of it, I'm not picking sides. I just can't be around you right now," Scorpia stated stiffly, folding her arms across her broad chest, biceps bulging. It was a threat if Adora ever saw one, but she was just mad enough that getting beat up by Scorpia seemed like a great way to release her anger.

"So if this isn't about sides then what's it about Scorpia?" She challenged crossing her own arms.

Scorpia's eyes looked sad. "You hurt my wildcat Adora and you promised me you wouldn't." Adora scoffed, *I can't believe this.*

"Catra left *me* Scorpia, what do you mean *she* is hurting? She's having a blast with her girlfriend, and she probably wouldn't give me the time of day if it weren't for the fact that we have a kid together." She snapped, tired of being made out as the bad guy in this situation. As if she was the only one who had fucked up.

"You really still don't understand what's happening to your marriage, do you?" Scorpia sneered, shaking her head in disbelief.

That riled her up. Adora clenched her jaw, glaring at the taller woman. "It's not like Catra will tell me anything besides the time she is picking up Finn!" She complained, poking a finger into Scorpia's shoulder. Scorpia bumped her back creating some space between them. The locker room felt hotter.

She was tired of feeling guilty and like she wasn't enough for her wife. *I can't believe I'm seriously considering punching Scorpia in the locker room right now.* She knew it was a terrible idea, but she was just itching for a confrontation. Deep down, she knew what she really wanted was a confrontation with Catra, but this was close enough.

Scorpia took another step back and shoved her gym bag into her locker. The slam of the locker door echoed between them.

"Maybe, instead of waiting for someone to come around and fix your marriage for you or tell you what's wrong, you should think about how you were treating Catra when you lost her." Scorpia's tone was sharp, and it pierced Adora's anger like a knife.

Adora struggled to make eye contact, suddenly deeply ashamed, both by the topic of conversation and her outburst. "I didn't ever do anything to intentionally hurt her. You have to know that right?" She whispered as she looked up at the tall woman, pleading with her eyes.

Scorpia was solemn, placing a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder. "I know but that doesn't make you blameless, Adora." Scorpia squeezed her shoulder once and walked away, not bothering to look back. It isn't like Adora had a response for her.

She was right after all.

Then:

"What does your wife do for a living Adora?" The Vice-President of Eternia Industries asked. Adora tightened the arm she had around Catra's waist, holding her close.

"Oh, she works in design!" Adora let out a forced chuckle. She felt Catra stiffen beside her, sending her a questioning glance that she ignored. She'd smooth this out with Catra later.

"That's lovely! You know my wife also has an eye for design, although all she does with that particular talent is spend money, not make money." The man had the audacity to actually slap his knee as he said it too. Adora gritted her teeth at the garish joke.

"Well, I'm glad to see that you're doing well." Adora offered diplomatically, hoping he would just leave her alone. Catra tensed further beneath Adora's hand, coiled like a snake ready to strike, but

was thankfully silent until the man strolled away to chitchat with some of his other employees.

"What was that Adora? *Design*?" Catra hissed into her ear as Adora steered her to a less populated part of the ballroom.

"He hates tattoos Catra—he thinks they're the epitome of unprofessionalism, and he is my boss's boss's boss! What would you have me do?" Adora whispered urgently back.

"Adora, you have multiple big ass tattoos done by me, your wife, who *is not a designer*." Catra pointed out. Adora huf fed, her breath blowing a misplaced hair out from in front of her eyes. Catra was unreasonably annoyed in her opinion. Who cared what the VP knew about Adora's personal life? Besides, it was a white lie at best.

"I mean technically you design tattoos so it's not exactly a lie." She pointed out.

Catra looked unimpressed with Adora's logic. "That's not the point Adora. What if he was a homophobe—what were you going to do, pretend I was your *sister*? I'm not sure I have Mara's complexion." She snarked while crossing her arms. Adora sighed then pressed her lips together. All she wanted was to get through this company event unscathed but clearly, that wasnt in the cards for her tonight.

"Obviously not Cat. This is important to me, and I'd really appreciate it if you played along. It's not that big of a deal." She pled with her wife, hoping she would just let this one thing go.

"Okay , how about this. Ill play along and be whatever trophy wife it is you actually want if you name one of the last twenty tattoos I've done or posted onto my social media." She challenged, had on her hip as she started at Adora expectantly .

Adora's eyes widened and her back tensed. *Oh fuck Ihaven't looked at any of my social media in eons—Ihave no time! Shit!*

She tried to think back to the last time she talked to Catra about what tattoos she was working on and drew a blank. Adora panicked as her wife continued to stare at her, looking gorgeous and deadly in a tight black dress. *Come on Adora use your brain. Think! You have to know at least one of Catra's latest projects, she must have told you at some point*.

The silence dragged on until Catra looked at Adora defiantly with a short "huh, that's what I thought," and left to the bathroom.

The rest of the night was an absolute bust. Catra stayed quiet, only speaking when spoken with. She was totally checked out and Adora was busy smoothing things over and trying to rub shoulders with the right people. She didn't have time to deal with her upset wife.

By the time they got home and coordinated who was picking Finn up from Scorpia and Perfuma's house the next morning, Adora was exhausted and in a terrible mood. Lately, it felt like everything to do with Catra blew up in her face.

When she got to their bedroom, Catra was already in bed, facing away from the door. Adora could tell she hadn't fallen asleep from how tense her frame was. She didn't want to keep fighting tonight. She just wanted to curl around Catra and hold her close, be with her.

Adora laid in the bed and reached her arm out, about to touch Catra. She took a deep breath.

"I'm doing this for us Cat. If I'm branch manager, we will want for nothing, and Finn will be set up. I just didn't want something stupid getting in the way of that." She saw Catra's shoulders flinch and Adora realized how her words could have been interpreted. "Not that your career is stupid!" *The only stupid thing here is me for putting my foot in my mouth the whole damn night*.

Adora waited for Catra to say something, but there was only silence. She moved to touch Catra but thought better of it. Clearly, Catra

didn't want her here with the way she refused to turn around to even *look* at her. She blinked away the tears welling in her eyes.

"I'll make it up to you Cat, I promise." She winced at how pathetically small her voice sounded at her last-ditch effort. Catra still didn't turn around. There might as well have been an ocean between them instead of six inches of mattress.

Adora sighed and slipped out of the bed. That was the first night Adora slept in the guestroom. She cried herself to sleep that night.

Now:

Adora dropped her waterbottle in the sink and wiped some of the sweat off her face. After confronting Scorpia she all but bolted home, barely stopping to say bye to Bow.

Her phone started ringing and she looked at the screen. It was her sister. *Ugh*. She really wanted a shower right now and to avoid the call, but given how infrequent her sister's phone calls were, it might be important.

"Hiya Mara." She sighed as she answered the phone.

"Wow don't sound so excited to hear from me, your only sister. I didn't call for you anyways, I just want to check on my adorable nibling," Mara sassed Adora like she always does.

Adora softly chuckled. "Well, you're going to have to call Finn's Mama if you want to hear from them because they are with Catra today." A pause on the line.

Mara sighed.

"Adora ..." Mara trailed. Adora knew that voice, her sister wanted to impart some life lesson or another. Adora really did not have the bandwidth for that.

"Look, I already got a lecture today about how I've irreparably damaged my marriage I don't need another one right now. It's~~it~~ s a lot." Adora's voice choked up and she cursed herself for getting emotional, knowing there was no way she could get off the phone quickly now.

"I know Dor. I know." She hummed sympathetically. "Is Catra still going out with that girl?" Mara asked cautiously.

Adora closed her eyes, she really didn't want to think about that. It felt like all anyone wanted to talk about was how well Catra was doing without her, while she was still sitting there, a fucking mess.

"Yes, she is, just like the last time you asked." She couldn't help but sound annoyed. She put the water bottle on the drying rack and started looking for something to do while she endured this call with Mara. She finally settled on wiping down the counter.

"Ok listen, you need to get back to basics. Think about how you used to resolve conflict with Catra, you both have had plenty of scrapes." Mara stated reasonably.

Adora rolled her eyes. "This isn't some fight on the playground like when we were kids Mar. This is my marriage." She disagreed. Sure she and Catra had fights over the years but she'd never felt like she couldn't talk to her like one wrong word would blow up the only thing they had left~~the~~ir co-parenting relationship. ~~*e*~~*Her marriage was over in everything but name anyway.*

"Those two things might not be as dif ferent as you think." Mara offered. She hated when Mara used that knowing tone like she wouldn't clue Adora into some universal truth because Adora had to figure it out herself. "Your relationship with Catra is rich and storied. Don't be afraid to let what you've learned in the past help you now."

"Mar, I promise we can talk about this another time" ~~she~~ already regrets letting those words come out of her mouth ~~b~~but I just got back from the gym, and I desperately need a shower. I'll call you

again when Im in the right headspace to talk about it." *Probably never.*

"Okay , then we dont have to talk about it any longer . I only want you, Catra, and Finn to be happy, regardless of what that might look like." Adora didnt know what happiness would look like apart, but if she were honest with herself, she didnt know what happiness looked like for them together either. It was all a mess.

"So, anything else going on in your life? Notable news?" Mara tried to change the subject. They chatted for a bit and Adora got caught up on the latest ongoings in town. Mara grabbed lunch with Catra's parents recently, and they were doing well.

"Are you coming to visit me soon?" She teased. Adora rubbed the back of her neck, shifting her weight, thankful Mara couldnt see.

"I dont know Mar , you know I hate going back to Thaymor." She hedged. She heard Mara sigh on the line.

"Adora, W eaver is dead. She isnt here anymore to hurt you anymore." She said a bit impatiently .

"I know but all the memories are there. Shes buried there. And you know what happened after she died. I dont know how you can stand it." Thaymor held good memories, but it also held everything Adora would rather forget. Everything Adora loved in Thaymor came with her to Bright Moon, save for Mara and Catra's parents.

"I mean I was older when we got placed with her . And she wasnt obsessed with me the way she was with her perfect Adora." Mara' s voice was mocking and angry, but not directed at her. Adora suppressed an unpleasant shiver at the words. She needed to change the topic of conversation away from Weaver.

"I might be up for that promotion as branch manager ." She told her sister. It was the opportunity she had been working towards for at least the last two years. *Why does it feel so empty?*

"I'm really proud of you kid, I know you worked hard for this." Mara was supportive as ever.

"I mean I'm happy I'm up for it, but with everything going on I can't help but feel like it's pointless? I like my job and I want to be recognized but it doesn't mean as much anymore." She explained. She hadn't even told any of her friends that she was one of the top candidates for the branch manager position.

"You don't know who is going to get the promotion and you don't know how things with Catra will shake out. No use worrying about the new job until you know if it is even on the table for you." That was trademark no-nonsense Mara advice. "Besides, I thought you didn't want to talk about Catra anymore?"

She was doing her secretive smile, Adora just knew it. She sighed at her sister's antics.

"I'm going to clean up Mar , it was good to hear from you. I love you." She really did love Mara. She was grateful to have her, especially nowadays.

"I love you too. One of these weekends you have Finn, you should bring them to town, and we can spend some quality time together ." Mara's voice brokered no compromise.

Adora told Mara she would think about it and hung up. *After the day I've had,* Adora resolved, *I'm going to soak in the tub until I turn into a prune.*

A bath would do nothing for her heart, but at least the rest of her muscles might stop being so sore. As she trudged into her bathroom, she knew what would stay sore was her head, with Scorpia's words circling on an infinite loop.

Chapter End Notes

This was the last of the flashbacks exploring why our girls separated (or as I call them, the owie flashbacks) so soon we will see some ✨progress✨. Or at least, some less painful flashbacks lol.

As always, love hearing your thoughts, kudos and comments super appreciated!Im sooooo exxited for the nexkfew chapters they have some of my favorite scenes and I cant wait to share :)

NexkW eek: Catra and Starla go to dinner with GlimBow. In the past, GlimBow takes care of Finn so the new moms and can have a night off.

Also, shamless plug- I posted a space heist AU one shot last week for the SPOP Creative FlexSpring 2022 T ag challenge! Feel free to check it out!

A Commemorative Wine

Chapter Summary

Catra and Starla go on a dinner date.

Catra needs a break.

Catra and Starla kiss goodnight.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra drove carefully as they passed through the deer crossing zone, tapping her thumb almost frenetically against the steering wheel. She threw Starla a reassuring smile, but she's kind of dying on the inside. Catra could not be more nervous about this dinner if she tried.

"Babe, you look a little strung out. What's wrong?" Starla asked, placing a hand on Catra's knee. Catra covered the hand with her own, squeezing it, taking comfort in Starla's warmth.

"I'm fine! Just want tonight to go well is all." She worried that Glimmer would say something rude to Starla and cause a scene. She worried that *she* might say something to Glimmer and cause a scene. Catra and Glimmer always caused fireworks, the question was whether it was going to be the good or bad kind.

"I'm sure it'll be fine~~you~~. You've been friends with Bow and Glimmer forever, right?" She asked, a look of curiosity overtaking her face. Admittedly, Catra hadn't spoken much about Glimmer and Bow to Starla, especially given how close their relationship was~~or~~ used to be, she supposed.

"Yeah, of course, it's just the first time we hang with them in a small group, I want you to be comfortable." She didn't want the messy edges of her last relationship blowing in and scaring Starla away.

Starla flashed her most charming smile. "I know how to work a dinner party just fine babe. You just watch me."

Catra rolled her eyes squeezing Starla's hand again. They pulled up to the beautiful sprawling residence Bow and Glimmer moved into a few years back. Starla let out a low whistle as she took in the view.

"Damn, this is some house they have." Her eyes prowled over the wrap-around porch and side entrances.

"Yeah, Glimmer is kind of a rich girl. Her parents have always been well off. She works with her mom in the family company and now they have all this." Catra gestured out to the house. "She's one of those folks that says she's 'comfortable' or whatever."

Starla chortled at that before making her way out of the car. Catra took the lead, taking Starla to the main entrance. She knocked on the door, holding the bottle of wine she brought tightly in anticipation. Bow must've been waiting behind the door because it immediately sprung open.

"Catra! Thank you so much for coming over for dinner we are so happy to hang out. We've been looking forward to seeing Starla again!" It all sounded like one big overhyped sentence, Bow's voice increasing in pitch until he finally took a deep breath. Bow was bringing extra pep today it seemed.

"Starla, Cat. Pleasure as always." Glimmer was a few feet back almost peeking out of the hallway, way more reserved than her husband.

"It's great to see you both again. I'm looking forward to dinner." Starla said politely, the picture of a perfect guest. Catra didn't let go of her hand.

"Let' s head over to the dining room. I made some roasted potatoes and pork loin with roasted peppers."Bow probably made enough to feed an army if Catra had to guess from the nervous twitch of his leg.

"W e brought wine."Catra handed to bottle of f to Glimmer, who thawed as she read the label, a slow smile crossing her face.

"Y ou brought me my favorite Malbec?"She asked, locking eyes with Catra for the first time that night.

"I sure did."She af firmed, glad she made the right choice. Glimmer and Catra were wine buddies through and through. It seemed like the best way to signal a truce early in the meal.

"Y ou are alright, Cat."She hummed her approval as she considered the wine for a moment longer holding it out to get a better look at it. "I'll go get the glasses, you all settle in and make yourselves at home."

They all sat down, all the plates were arranged on one side of the huge dining room table that could easily seat ten. Catra knew for a fact that they actually hated the ornate table but it was an heirloom passed down from Angella's side of the family. She rubbed her fingers against the underside of the wood, finding the movement soothing as she relaxed into her chair .

"So, what' s going on with you, Starla?"Bow asked attentively as he piled food onto his plate, passing the roasted potatoes down.

"Nothing much, I actually got some recording space booked for later this summer. My band is trying to put out a short EP, well see what comes of it."She waved it of f as if it were nothing. Bow leaned in closer and even Glimmer edged forward, eyes sparkling with interest. Out of their friend group, Catra was the most artistically minded, and her job was nothing like Starla's.

"That' s so cool! I knew that you were a musician but that' s just something else!"Bow' s enthused voice carries over the large space.

As the night went on it, Bow became more visibly charmed by Starla, leaning in close and asking the right questions. Glimmer remained mostly aloof but generally polite, concentrating more on her meal than any of the conversation flowing at the table.

Glimmer drank at least two glasses of wine as she ate, which seemed to loosen her lips. "Do you remember the first night we drank this wine, Cat?" Glimmer needled, leaning forward as she ran a finger over the label, eyes a bit glassy.

She narrowed her eyes in warning, "Yeah Glim. We've been drinking this for ages." Catra gritted through her teeth. She remembered clearly ~~it~~ had been a new find they tried at a dinner Glimmer and Bow hosted to celebrate her engagement with Adora.

"Wasn't that a great night?" Glimmer goaded, a smirk on her lips and fire in her eyes. Glimmer felt like burning something down, but Catra wasn't going to let it be their nice night out. Her utensils clattered as she put them down sharply, all while looking at Glimmer with a glare. Starla and Bow might not have picked up on what Glimmer was implying but Catra sure did.

"You know, I think I left one of Finn's toys last time I dropped them off. Glimmer can you help me look for it?" The look she sent Glimmer made it clear that she wasn't really asking.

"Sure Cat." She said agreeably . Bow threw himself forcefully back into the conversation with Starla, cautiously eyeing them as they walked out of the dining room. He was smart enough not to intervene. Catra let Glimmer walk out first and followed her through the kitchen to the back porch.

"What the fuck was that Glimmer?" She complained, turning on her heels to lash out at Glimmer.

"You just act like nothing's happening and it pisses me off Catra. As if you haven't ignored me and Bow for months! As if we aren't all

walking on eggshells around you and Adora.”She listed of f, waving her arms in the air.

“I’m trying to live my life Glimmer . I’m not going to apologize for that.” She huffed, glaring openly now that their significant others weren’t there to witness it. “You have to stop acting like I’m somehow throwing a temper tantrum because I decided to end my marriage. You can’t say you support me, then say shit like that Glimmer .”

She visibly deflated, running a hand over her face. “I’ve been doing my best Catra, we invited you and her over and we’re making nice. I don’t know what more you want from me.”Glimmer crossed her arms and pressed her lips together. “I just want my friend back.”

“It doesn’t feel that way Glim. Stop being so fucking fake and passive-aggressive about it!”She snapped. “I know you Glimmer . I know what your friendship looks like and that in there all night? That’s not it.”

Glimmer’s eyes soften. “I’m sorry . Really. I’m not trying to be a bitch. It just feels like since you decided to break up, I have to pick sides and I don’t want to.”She crossed her arms over her chest, looking smaller than her normal tiny frame.

“You don’t have to give up either of us Glimmer . What Adora and I are doing now isn’t great, but it’ s working.”She insisted. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“*You* say it’s working but I think it’s only working for *you*. And I get it, you need to look out for yourself and Adora isn’t your concern anymore”~~tho~~se words stung like hell ~~–~~ ~~b~~ut Cat sometimes I~~ –~~ fly off the handle. And I’m sorry for that.”

“I’ll accept your apology if you stop being a bitch.”Catra said bluntly , eyeing her friend. Glimmer snorted at that, a short hard laugh that caught her by surprise.

"Okay , I deserve that. I just level with me for a second Catra." Glimmer's face turned serious as she searched Catra's gaze. "Things with Adora. They're done for good for you?"

Catra swallowed the knot in her throat. She could never be done with Adora. She was her other half, her best friend, for so long that there were pieces of Adora all along Catra's mind and her heart.

"I think our relationship is as done as it can ever be. I can't even imagine what piecing it together would look like at this point and I'm tired of trying."She admitted in a whisper . Everything was an angry snarled mess and even though it hurt, it would probably hurt worse to dive back into it.

Glimmer nodded to herself and puts a hand on Catra's arm. "Okay then, I am one hundred percent in your corner, and I promise I'm going to be a pain in your ass like I've always been but not about your marriage."She gave Catra a soft conspiratorial smile, the type they only shared between them.

"Deal."She agreed readily . Glimmer's smile dropped for a moment and she puts a hand up as if to pause their conversation.

"I'm going to say one thing though and you might not like it, but I can't stop being fake and passive aggressive' until I say it."She looked over to Catra, who nodded, confused as to what Glimmer might say. "Things with Adora might be over , but your happy ending isn't with Starla either , Cat. Obviously, she's welcome anytime and maybe Ill be proven wrong, but I had to get that off my chest."

She eyed her friend for a moment. "Okay , that's fine. I can accept that you feel that way."Catra was dying to ask why Glimmer thought that, but she held her tongue. Knowing would just give her doubts more fodder. Glimmer visibly relaxed at that.

"And for the record, I support you doing what makes you happy , regardless of what that looks like. What I don't support is you being so distant from us."Glimmer complained in a way that was familiar

and comforting. "To be honest, it kind of feels like Bow and I are kids in the divorce half the time."

Catra snorted at the characterization. "I don't remember signing either of your adoption papers. And I would remember, it was a lot of papers for Finn." She cracked, happy to joke with her friend again.

"Bow and I are thinking of having a baby." She blurted out and Catra let out a small squeal that she would deny until the day she died.

"Glimmer that's fantastic. You're going to be a wonderful mom." Catra's cheeks hurt from how hard she was smiling. She couldn't be happier for her friends.

"I'm so worried that I am going to ruin it all somehow." Glimmer voiced aloud, a nervous look in her eye. The sentiment tugged at her heartstrings. Adora felt the same way when they had Finn.

"You aren't. You and Bow are solid, and you're the best aunt and uncle to Finn." She assured her, smiling brightly. "Honestly, I'm surprised that you haven't done it sooner."

Glimmer pressed her lips together, looking in the direction of the dining room. "We had a lot to work through. Bow had a lot of complicated feelings about it because we can't conceive naturally. It made him feel...less than." She sighed sadly, eyes still on the porch door.

"Oh Bow. I had no idea." Catra whispered. "He will be every inch an amazing father no matter what."

"I know that! It just took longer for him to come around to it." Glimmer smiled. "But he feels confident now and we're ready."

"Well, I'm glad that could work through that." A guilty feeling tugged at Catra's gut. She hadn't realized her friends were going through such a tough time.

"We're looking for donors right now." Glimmer whispered, both excitement and fear shining in her eyes. "This might actually be my last bottle of wine in a while."

Catra snorted, pulling Glimmer into a hug. "Somehow, I think you will be able to squeeze in another before you get yourself knocked up." Catra teased. Glimmer shoved Catra away laughing lightly. "Thanks for telling me Gimmer. I really am so happy for you."

"Of course, Cat. You are one of my best friends." She paused for a beat. "And you won't be getting out of babysitting duty." Glimmer threatened.

"Wouldn't miss it for the world." She promised.

Catra picked up one of the dozens of Finn's toys that littered the patio, ready to rejoin dinner, content to have mended at least one bridge tonight.

Then

The house was an absolute mess. It seemed like every piece of furniture had been bubble-wrapped and anything remotely sharp was not only outside of Finn's reach but also Catra's. There were little shoes and socks all over the living room and if she didn't get a moment of quiet, she would lose her mind. She beelined for the living room when she heard the doorbell. Behind it were her saviors: Glimmer and Bow.

"Thank the stars you guys are here." She practically pounced on Bow giving him a hug. She'd never been so happy to see other adults.

"You doing alright there Cat?" Bow asked, a nervous edge to his voice. She knew she probably looked a mess, but that didn't matter. Bow and Glimmer were her family, they could cope with her being a bedraggled mess.

"If I murder Adora and go to jail you both are in charge of Finn, okay?" Catra clarified. There was no one she trusted more with her kid. She just adopted the rugrat, she didn't want them placed back into the foster system if she snapped. She was mostly joking. *Mostly.* Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"It can't be that bad Catra." Bow soothed, approaching Catra slowly as if she were a wild animal. She kind of felt it sometimes in the last few months if she were honest with herself.

Catra was sleepy. Cranky. Tired. She was sure there were more words for it, but sleep deprivation had reduced her vocabulary substantially.

"Bow I am about to tear my damn hair out if this woman quotes one more parenting book at me. I read the books with her! We went to the trauma classes, the adoption classes, therapy! We need to actually parent Finn, not debate it like this is a science problem." She seethed. She loved Adora to pieces but sometimes she was just paralyzed by indecision.

"Look, I have no idea what being a parent is like. But I know you and Adora. You just need some space to reconnect! You've been around the clock worrying about Finn since the moment they got here three months ago." Bow gave Catra a wide smile and patted her shoulder. "And that's why we're here. Now give us the baby." He demanded as he made grabby hands.

Glimmer elbowed her husband. "I promise we aren't trying to kidnap Finn we're just really excited about having them over." She explained with an apologetic smile.

"Dor - Glimmer and Bow are here." Catra raised her voice slightly so Adora could hear her from the other room. She padded into the room holding a sleepy Finn, both their blonde hairs sticking up in different directions.

Catra knew she was just complaining about her wife but seeing her and Finn together never failed to make her heart clench. Adora held the two-year-old tightly to her chest as she issued instructions, determination blazing in her eyes.

"Okay so, you need to make sure that there isn't anything dangerous that they could reach." Adora's voice pitched up as she continued to explain, "and you know they haven't been eating too many different food types so we are trying to just put a new food on the plate with safe foods and letting them try at their own pace. Don't pressure them." She warned.

"Dor, we've been coming over like twice a week since Finn came home, we know enough to take them for three hours. They will be back for bedtime, promise." Glimmer was using her confident business voice, probably trying to key into Adora's corporate brain. "We have your number, but we will only call if there is an emergency. I'll send a text update with a photo every hour on the hour."

"We got this," Bow added. He put his hands out for Finn again. Finn eyed him distrustfully at first, burrowing into Adora's shoulder.

"Finnie honey, Bow wants to take you to get ice cream and see his fish tank," Catra told her kid. They hadn't called her mom yet, but it didn't bother her—she was just happy to see them adjusting well to their new environment. Finn visibly perked at the idea and looked at Bow's smiling face again. They reach out and Bow carefully settled them on his hip. Glimmer grabbed the go-bag and they were set.

"Bye Finnie! Be good." Adora called out. Finn waved cheerfully and nuzzled into Bow's arms as they walked out the door. Adora scoffed as she closed it. "What a little traitor. I can't believe they traded us in for some fishies and ice cream." Adora pouted.

Catra snorted at her wife as she rolled her eyes. "I definitely can believe that. They are a little con artist." Catra teased fondly. Adora turned to face Catra, her gaze intense. She felt Adora's arm come around her tightly almost squeezing the air out of her lungs. Catra

held her back just as tight. It felt like coming home, even though they'd been in their house all day.

"Hey. I'm so sorry Cat. I know I've been driving you up the wall about Finn." Adora mumbled into Catra's dirty sweatshirt. "I just—I don't want to be like her you know? I never want to hurt Finn."

Her voice cracked and Catra's heart dropped into her stomach. She hadn't realized Adora was even thinking about that. She gripped Adora tighter still as she sniffled.

"Oh Dor is that what's going on? You would never treat Finn like Weaver treated you." She soothed rubbing circles on her back like she did to Finn. "It doesn't mean we're going to do everything perfectly though." Catra cautioned.

Adora let out a shuddering breath. "I know it's just hard. I can't help but feel like I'll ruin it all by accidentally hurting them like she hurt me." She whimpered. Catra held her even closer if that was at all possible.

"Adora, what Weaver did to you was on purpose. She made you feel like you had to meet impossible standards all the time. Let me ask you this." Catra switched gears. "Is there anything Finn could do that would make you withhold your love?"

"No! Absolutely not!" The answer was swift and fierce.

She smiled into Adora's shoulder. "That's what makes you different babe. I know you love Finn to pieces, and you'd protect them with everything you have." Catra believed that to her bones. Adora's sniffles quieted.

"I already miss them. Can you believe that?" Adora laughed to herself tearfully. "We've been desperate for a break and now that we have it, all I can think about is how I can't wait for Glimmer to send a picture of that tiny face."

"Me too," Catra admitted. The house felt empty without Finn in it. They were her family, plain and simple. "Hey—we're alone for the first time since Finn came home," Catra noted.

Adora tilted her head in interest. "What do you want to do about it?" She asked softly pulling back so she could look Catra in the eyes. Catra leaned forward giving her wife a lingering kiss. She then dropped her head onto Adora's shoulder, pressing herself close so that there was no space between them again.

"Want to order takeout and pass out on the couch right after?" Catra proposed, body too spent to do anything remotely sexy.

Adora positively beamed. "Oh god, I thought you'd never ask." Catra got the takeout menus and set out to snuggle her wife until their order came in.

Now

"Did you enjoy yourself?" Catra asked as she drove back to her apartment, way more relaxed than earlier in the evening. They'd stayed late so that Catra could be sure she was sober enough to drive and laughed all the way through the rest of dinner and dessert.

"Yeah, I really like Bow and Glimmer. I can't believe that Glimmer really sang all through college and I'm just finding out! Goes to show how hard it is to get to know people in a group setting." Starla chatted. After Catra and Glimmer cleared the air, the night went fantastic, better than she could've hoped. "I'm so glad we're going to do karaoke with her! I love karaoke but people never want to go with me." Starla complained with a cute pout.

"That's because you have the voice of an angel and music is what you do for a living." Catra pointed out. "You intimidate them all with your rockstar skills."

"Well, you're going to have to sing when we go with Glimmer and Bow." Starla grinned as Catra groaned.

"Why did it take so long for us to have a one-on-one hang with them anyway?" Catra glued her eyes back to the road. Starla always had a knack for asking questions Catra didn't want to answer.

"I'm not sure, really. Glimmer and Bow are always busy with work, and I usually bring Finn when I come to see them." Catra didn't want to ruin the night by bringing up Adora. Starla grew silent at the mention of Finn.

"Oh. Well, I hope that we can make time to see them again. Maybe with Finn?" Starla added cautiously. She couldn't help the twitch of annoyance she felt at Starla bringing this up again, but she brushed it under the rug.

"Yeah. That would be nice." Catra allowed. She parked the car and turned to Starla. She gave her a quick kiss on her lips before trailing a few on her cheeks and temple.

"I'll see you later next week, right?" Catra confirmed.

Starla nodded, fiddling with her keys. "Yeah. Thanks for taking me out tonight." Starla gave her another kiss, this one slower, leaving Catra a bit breathless.

"Of course, Star. Anytime." Catra smiled brightly, waiting till Starla pulled out of the parking lot to walk up the stairs.

Up in her apartment, Catra thought about what Glimmer said. It was the first time someone told her that they thought Starla wasn't a good match. Catra shrugged it off. She could figure it out on her own.

Chapter End Notes

Do I have a specific Malbec in mind? Yes, I do lol. (Answer is on Twitter 😬)

I cannot emphasize enough how much I love Catra and Glimmer's friendship in anything. And they are friends again!

As always, please drop some kudos/comments if the spirit moves you, it definitely makes my week to hear from you guys!

Next week: Adora goes out to a bar and in the past, Catra and Adora go to prom.

Also, because I love hearing from you all, I made a Twitter! Y'all can follow me @RosesFlower1. Not sure what all Ill be posting but definitely alerts when I post, maybe some polls of what I should write next, and more Catradora discussions.

A Hurried Exit

Chapter Summary

Adora goes out and finds something unexpected.

Adora and Catra go to prom.

Adora talks to Mara.

Chapter Notes

HEY! If you thought it was weird that you didn't get a notification from me last week it WAS weird because I posted and AO3 decided to not send notifications 😭

So if this applies to you, fair reader, make sure to go read Ch. 6 before you read this one!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She loved holding Finn's hand when they walked places together, it was one of the few things they hadn't grown out of yet. They bound up the steps of Glimmer's house where she was waiting, arms crossed over her chest. She had a smile for Finn but a concerned look reserved for Adora.

Adora leaned down so that Finn was at eye level with her. "I'll come to get you tomorrow bud, okay?" She gave Finn a quick hug. They nodded and bounded into the house without looking back, already searching for Bow.

"You're being an idiot right now. Honestly." Glimmer didn't give her anger, which was a real change of pace. No, instead, Adora got disappointment. *From Glimmer*. "It's not too late to stay in with us and hang out."

Adora shook her head. "I know you don't get it, but I need to let off some steam. Thank you for looking after Finn." The gym was not cutting it this week. She knew her friends had opinions about the times she went out to find a warm body for the night, but her friends hadn't been on the cusp of divorce so they could *shove it*.

"I'll always be here for you and Finn. I'm all for you going out, I just don't think you're doing this for the right reasons Dor." Glimmer stated plaintively, twisting one of her bracelets around on her wrist as she bit her lip worriedly.

She'd only gone out looking for someone to sleep with a few times, the first time being the weekend she found out about Starla. She just felt so angry and betrayed.

Some part of her wanted to feel like she wasn't being left behind by Catra and the vengeful part of her brain thought sleeping with someone would make it better. She regretted it as soon as Catra caught on—*which of course she did, just my luck* ~~a~~nd assumed she brought some woman home with Finn there.

"I'm tired of feeling like I can't do anything right. I just want to go out and forget for a while." Adora explained rubbing the back of her neck. She wanted to feel desired, liked. She wanted to feel like she was enough or honestly, she would settle for just not being too much. Sleeping with these women seemed to be one of her only sources of validation these days, which spoke volumes as to the sad state of Adora's life.

"Goodnight Dor. I hope you know what you're doing." Glimmer waited for Adora to leave before quietly closing the front door. Adora drove back home, plan made for how her night was going to end.

She picked out a shirt she knew brought out her arms and eyes before heading to one of the more popular gay bars in Bright Moon. She'd been plenty successful there before, so it seemed as good a place as any to go tonight.

She walked in, surveying the room. The bar was a little more trendy than Adora liked with its loud music and showy decor. When it came to a night on the town, she preferred a dive bar in Thaymor over the glitz and glam of midtown Bright Moon. The lights were dim, the dancefloor was packed, and the beer special was an IPA.

She walked to the bar, settling on getting a drink before deciding if she wanted to try her hand at dancing. As she tried to flag down the bartender, she felt someone touch her shoulder.

"Hey , you come here often?" Another blonde saddled up to Adora almost as soon as she got to the bar. She fluttered her eyelashes and leaned closer than a stranger should. The line was old and tired but Adora wasn't looking to be wooed and she was sure the woman staring at her from neck to waist wasn't into wooing anyways.

"Not really , what's good here?" Adora asked, trying to make conversation. The blonde's eyes brightened, as she offered to buy Adora a drink.

Twenty minutes later Adora is in the middle of letting the blonde grip her arm as she subtly flexes— *okay, yeah, she gets where Glimmer and Bow are coming from when they say she is a fuckboy* —when she heard a familiar squeaky laugh.

She turned to see Catra across the room in a booth with Starla, head thrown back, presumably laughing at something Starla said. Adora's whole world stood still. *Wow, she's so beautiful when she's happy*. Catra had an open grin that lit up her whole face, she was wearing a pair of ripped leggings that Adora knew well.

Adora took another sip of her drink trying to gain composure and failing miserably. She tried to think back to the last time she heard Catra laugh like that and came up blank. *Has it really been that long?* She knew things were bad between them, she accepted that— but had she really made Catra so miserable?

The pieces fell into place for Adora as she stared at Catra holding Starla's hand, happy as could be. Until that moment, she didn't fully understand what everyone told her about her marriage, but now it was staring her in the face. She just wished it hadn't taken seeing Catra looking so vibrant with someone else for the realization to drop on her like lead.

She couldn't sit there with Catra so close. The last thing she needed was for Catra to spot her—she needed to get away.

Adora made her voice low and desperate, looking back at the blonde she was entertaining. "Do you want to get out of here?" Adora all but begged. The woman she was talking with smirked, thinking Adora was desperate *for her* but really, she was desperate to be out of Catra's line of sight. She nodded her head enthusiastically, grabbing Adora's hand.

Adora all but dragged the woman out of the bar. She felt bad because she knew she wouldn't focus on her tonight. Not now that she saw a glimpse of the woman she lost what felt like forever ago.

Then

Adora thought she was going to be permanently blinded by the flash. She tried her best not to be stiff but it was hard with the camera going off nonstop.

"Let me snap one more picture!" Catra's mom was obsessed, she made Catra and Adora do a million different poses in their prom get up. It felt especially weird since they were only friends, there was no need for all the rigmarole.

"Mama no we're already going to be late!" Catra continued as she switched languages, now firing off in rapid Spanish. Adora didn't speak a word of Spanish, but she saw Catra's mom pull a sly face as she said something that made Catra's dad cackle and Catra blush beet red.

"What did your mom just say to you?" Adora wondered aloud. Catra's dad laughed harder at that.

Catra turned to Adora looking panicked. "Nothing! She didn't say anything! Let's just go to this dumb place."

They left in Adora's pickup truck, an old thing that really had no business being on the road. Adora's palms were sweaty on the steering wheel as she tried to not steal glances at Catra. Adora already knew she was gay, but she did not know *how* gay until she saw Catra in a *suit*.

She felt her mouth dry, and her heart tried to beat its way out of her chest and straight into Catra's hands. *Having unrequited feelings for your best friend is truly the worst.* They finally arrived and once inside, she had to admit it was all kind of drab.

The high school gym looked the same even with the decorations and you could pick out the gym sock smell wafting in from the football team's locker room. *Boys are gross.* She glanced over at Catra and knew she was thinking the same thing.

They talked to some of their friends, lots of them commenting on "how cute" they looked together, which made Adora blush and also worry that they had the wrong impression. If *Catra* got the wrong impression or right impression really that Adora liked her and rejected Adora tonight, she'd just die. It was the only reasonable solution.

"Do you want to dance?" Catra asked as she picked lint off the cuff of her dress shirt, completely casual. Adora choked on her drink, looking down at Catra with wide eyes.

"Uh you want to to dance with me?" She sputtered. Adora felt like her eyes were going to bulge out of her head. Catra rolled her eyes, looking out at the dance floor.

"I mean yeah, why not?" Catra said accompanied by a blasé shrug. "You're my date for this thing, who else would I dance with?" Catra asked rhetorically as she held her hand out to Adora.

Adora thought about swaying in Catra's arms, feeling her warmth, and looking into her eyes on the sticky gym floor. *This is a terrible idea.*

"Sure! It'll be fun!" Adora said cheerfully as she grabbed Catra's hand and marched onto the dance floor just as a new song came on.

"Whoa there! Slow down dummy, where's the fire?" Catra pulled Adora in and put one hand on her waist and held her other hand. Adora's skin felt like it was on fire, and she was sure her heart was going to give out on her. She worried that Catra would find her sweaty palms gross and unappealing.

But Catra didn't tease her, just gently led her through the steps, smiling at her while they danced. Why had they never danced together before? *Probably because there's no platonic reason to hold your best friend this way outside of prom.* She felt like she was floating above all of her classmates in place where it was only her and Catra.

The song ended and Catra dropped her arms, signaling the end of the dance. She'd give anything to stay wrapped up in them. It gave her an idea. Adora leaned forward.

"Wanna drive out to the lake now?" She offered as they walked back to the punch bowl. "I think we saw everything there is to see here."

Catra's eyes lit up. One of their favorite summer activities was to go out to one of the larger lakes in town. Recently Adora owning a car recent~~the~~y occasionally snuck out at night to go swimming and hang out there at night. It'd been too cold to go recently but tonight shouldn't be that bad.

"Yes yes! Let's go!" Now Catra was the one dragging Adora out the gym door.

Within half an hour they were sitting in the bed of Adora's truck under some blankets Adora kept in her car for occasions such as this. Catra had taken off her suit jacket to keep it from getting wrinkled. Instead, Adora was greeted by the sight of Catra with her dress shirt rolled up to her forearms with the top few buttons undone. Adora knew she'd hold onto that image for a while.

"I'm so glad I got to go to prom with you, dummy," Catra said fondly. She was laying her head on Adora as they cuddled up for warmth. Adora's breath hitched as she tightened her arms around her best friend.

"Yeah? You're happy you went with me?" She said it in a mostly teasing voice, but her thoughts were anything but. *Do you like me too? Do you want to be with me?* Adora might die of happiness.

Catra hummed. "Yeah. I mean think how dumb it would be to go with some girl you're dating, and you break up by the end of freshman year of college. What do you do with all the dumb pictures our parents took?" Catra chuckled into Adora's shoulder. "It's better that it's us because we're always going to have each other." Catra finished, leaning closer to Adora.

Adora felt her stomach drop. *Oh, this is the our-prom-pictures-will-never-get-old level of the friend zone. Wow, achievement unlocked.* But then Adora felt warm all over again.

She stared at Catra affectionately. "Yeah Cat. We're always going to have each other, no matter what. I can promise you that." Adora kept her voice soft, afraid to break the magic of the moment by speaking too loudly. Catra was such a big part of her life, her closest friend and confidant, not to mention the most beautiful girl in the world, Adora was sure of it.

Catra nestled even in closer, and they looked up at the sky for a while, settling into a comfortable silence. She mentally thanked Mara for helping her get this old beat-up truck as she pulled Catra closer.

It didn't matter if she never got to know what kissing Catra felt like. She had her friendship, and that was more special than all the kisses in the world.

They spent the rest of the night till curfew talking about what they were going to do at Bright Moon University together. How they were going to be roommates, go to parties, ace their classes, and take on the world together. Adora couldn't wait.

Even though she was still in high school, she knew hearing Catra's laugh while whispering on the bed of her pickup truck and looking at the stars was going to be something she'd always remembered. *Best prom night ever.*

Now

Adora came home shortly after leaving the bar feeling dirty and guilty. She didn't feel guilty about the blonde, it was how stupid she'd been. She could feel Catra's laugh echoing in her head. As she climbed the stairs to her bedroom she dialed her phone to the only person she could stand to bother this late at night.

"Adora? Why are you calling me at ~~st~~ars, almost midnight? Are you okay? Finn okay?" Mara's voice goes from sleepy to frantic as she kept shouting out questions.

"Everything's fine, Mar ." Adora tried to get the words out without crying but a sob broke through anyway. She'd been holding it in by a thread since she left the bar.

"Adora! You're crying! What's going on?" Mara's voice became more alarmed when she heard Adora's choked-out words.

"I swear it's not an emergency it— s about Catra." She heard silence on the line and shuffling.

"Oh. Oh, okay well I'm here for you if you want to tell me what happened?" She coaxed gently , another question hidden in her words.

"I went to a club to sleep with someone." Adora started bluntly as she fidgeted with the edge of her sheets. "And I was chatting up this girl when I saw her Mar . Catra was there with her girlfriend." Mara cursed under her breath.

"Oh, shit Dor . What'd she do when she saw you?" Mara asked breathlessly.

"She didn't. I hightailed out of there with the girl before she could see me." Adora admitted to her cowardice. She ran her fingers through her hair tugging at the ends a bit.

"Did you sleep with her? The girl I mean." Mara's voice held no judgment. Adora pressed her lips together .

"No, I couldn't do it. All I could think about was Catra." They ended up making out at the woman's apartment but then Adora pumped the breaks, apologizing profusely as she did so.

"So, is it that you saw Catra and her girl together for the first time in person that has you feeling this way?" Mara probed, taking another shot in the dark. Adora shook her head even though her sister couldn't see.

"No. Mar you should have seen her . She looked so happy you know? Happier than I remember seeing her in a long time. She was laughing and smiling so wide." Adora felt like her heart was cleaved in two. Her fingers shook, and she wasn't sure if Mara could understand her words around her sniffles and sobs. "You know that I can't remember the last time I made her laugh. Catra's laugh used to be like, the soundtrack of my life."

"Oh, Adora. I'm sorry ."Mara sounded helpless on the other line. Adora couldn't blame her , she felt helpless sitting on her bed with a mountain of pain feeling like it was crushing her chest.

"I get it now . I really do. I've been stupid and I prioritized the wrong things. I'm an asshole because I didn't pay any attention to the woman I was supposed to be sharing my life with."Adora stated them like facts because that's what they were. "I didn't support Catra and I took her for granted."She'd really fucked up *bad*.

"Okay , Adora you don't need to self-flagellate like this."Mara huffed out a bit of a defensive tone as if she could protect Adora from herself.

"It's the truth Mar."Adora thought about the awful last year of her life. "I've been looking at this all wrong. This whole separation with Catra I mean."

"What do you mean Dor . You aren't making any sense."Mara sounded confused and frustrated on the line.

"I've been thinking a lot about my marriage with Catra, and I~~'~~ have to accept the fact that it's gone."Adora's chest tightened, and she felt new tears burning her eyes. "But Mara, I can't not have Cat in my life. This isn't enough. What we're doing now I mean."

"What options do you really have Adora?"Mara sounded bewildered, still trying to understand Adora's train of thought.

"It's like you said before Mar, last time we talked. Catra and I, we have a past that's bigger than our marriage. I've always had Catra in my life~~th~~at's what's most important."Adora took in a shuddering breath. "I want to be friends again."

Mara let out a startled laugh, jolting Adora.

"Dor 'I think that's admirable, but do you really think you can be just friends after everything?With Catra?Y our *wife*?"Mara asked

skeptically. "Also, you really just took one look at her laughing, and suddenly you want to actually deal with your issues instead of avoiding them?

"I think *because* of everything Mar. Catra isn't just my wife. She never has been. She's always my best friend. I lost sight of that." She sighed. Even though this night turned out to be an emotional rollercoaster, she'd never been surer of anything in her life. "Besides, Catra clearly loves Starla." The words burned coming out of her mouth. "I can be fine with that. Or I guess I can learn to be fine with it. I can support her, and things can be platonic between us." Adora rubbed one of her temples with her free hand. "I think I was coming around to realizing how bad I screwed up or at least I hope I was. This just put it into clear focus in a way nothing else had."

She'd gotten speeches from Glimmer and Mara, called out by Scorpia at the gym, and who knew how many other slaps in the face that should have woken her up. They just hadn't. But seeing Catra look like the woman Adora loved, look like Adora remembered in her fondest memories it left no room for delusion about the disrepair in her marriage. Or the cause of it.

"What about your feelings Adora? Do you think you can have platonic feelings for Catra again?" Adora laughed at Mara's question. It sounded like another sob.

"I'm not sure that I've ever had platonic feelings for Catra. Maybe I did when we were kids, but it's always been her Mar. I don't think I'll ever stop loving Catra. I don't know how." Adora admitted in a whisper. "But I *do* know how to be Catra's friend. It wouldn't be the first time I'm friends with Catra while in love with her. There was a time when Catra's friendship was one of the most important things in my life that's what matters Mar. I can do that again."

"Adora I'm not sure that's really healthy. You can't just pretend and go back to what you were doing in college." Mara cautioned. Adora paced across her room, hand clenched in a fist.

"And what I'm doing now is healthy? Mara, I'm miserable. This isn't some attempt to get her back or obsess over her. I'm ready to let go of what's making us dysfunctional. I fail to see how finding common ground and friendship with Catra again could be anything but a good thing." Adora's energy was flagging, she felt wrung out. "Mar, I'm tired. I'm going to sleep."

"Okay kid. Can you please drink water and call me in the morning? I want to make sure you are okay." Her tone dripped with worry in a way only a big sister was capable of.

"Yes, Mar. I love you. Thanks for listening to me." Although she was exhausted, she felt more centered than when she first arrived home.

"I'll always answer Adora. And just so you know, the next time you don't have to be on the edge of an emotional breakdown to let your feelings out." Mara stated pointedly.

Adora could feel the glare she was sending her from Thaymor.

"I'll take that under advisement." Adora hedged. She wasn't sure if she ever wanted to discuss this again, although she had to admit to herself that she felt better after talking with Mara.

"Sleep tight, twerp." Mara's voice was full of affection. Adora snorted as the line fell dead. Adora stripped out of that old dress shirt, now feeling almost ashamed that she tugged it on earlier in the night.

She chugged a glass of cold water, washed her face and teeth, and then slumped into her bed. As she lay there, she could still hear Catra's laugh ringing in her ears.

I need to make her laugh like that again. At least one more time.

That night, Adora dreamt of the stars as seen from the bed of her old pickup truck in her sleepy hometown. She hadn't slept that well in ages.

Chapter End Notes

Adora needed a kick and she got one this chapter. I think of this as the real turning point in this fic. From here, things will have a different vibe overall (less sad hopefully lol)

I love the prom flashback (top 3 flashback imo) I hope you did too!

I always appreciate any comments/kudos yall throw my way! Especially since last week was pretty quiet given that the AO3 notification didn't send out.

Next week: Catra gets an unexpected client referral and in the past, she gives Adora her first tattoo.

I'll be tweeting out when I update my fics on Twitter, so follow me in case AO3 decides it hates me once again 🙃
@RosesFlower1

A P rmanent Design

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a new tattoo client.

Catra gives her first tattoo.

Finn has a hard time sleeping.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra ignored the way her bag dug into her side as she power walked to her destination. She bit back a groan. She hated mornings like these when she didnt have time to get cof fee. She would hopefully have time to stop by Perfuma's place for a pick-me-up, but she needed to stop by the shop first.

"Hey Catra! I have someone req esting you specifically , do you have time on your schedule for an intake meeting? Looks like itll be a pretty big piece." She'd barely put her bag down when Lonnie hollered at her about the new client. She took a deep breath through her nose.

I guess that' s a good thing, probably means our hstagram account is doing better. It was weird. Usually, clients emailed first ~~m~~ost initial consultations could be handled without meeting face to face. *Oh well.* If a client was willing to pay for her time, so be it.

"Y eah, I got it!" She walked past the reception desk, DT giving her a bored wave as their eyes never wavered from their phone. Catra rolled her eyes and continued through the back hallway where she knew Lonnie would set up the client. The shop wasnt all that big, only a few small back rooms for meetings, a bathroom, and a larger room where they had their tattoo chairs. Catra loved it though ~~th~~ey

covered the place from top to bottom in art and she had her own space where she could sketch to her heart's content.

"Hi, I'm Catra you requested to work with me?" The client, she presumed, sat across from her in one of their small meeting rooms. He had a broad smile and a large mustache that made her instantly wary of him.

"Yes! I am Sebastian! I've been searching far and wide for a tattoo artist to create my amazing ship in her full glory and no one other will do." He exclaimed, puffing up his chest as he put his fist on the table. He was wearing a cravat of all things.

She raised an eyebrow at him. "Is that so?" She asked amusedly. She could already tell she was going to have a hard time not making fun of this guy.

Catra proceeded to quiz him on what he wanted and how he wanted it done. *This guy would want a naval tattoo*. The client seemed very familiar with her work, and knew what he wanted, even though he was kind of annoying, so overall it could have been worse.

"So, Sebastian, where'd you see my work? How'd you hear of Horde Tattoos?" Catra asked the routine questions on her intake sheet. Sebastian's eyes lit up immediately, as he twirled his mustache.

"Well, on the Horde's Tattoos Instagram account I saw that magnificent ship you did recently, and I knew that you were destined to mark my body with Daughter's Dragon Three." Catra suppressed the urge to roll her eyes at her overzealous client "but I first saw your work on someone at the gym."

Catra perked up with interest, leaning forward in her seat. It was always fun when a client saw one of her tattoos in person and decided to come in for one. She started to jot down some more notes as she asked him more questions.

"Do you remember the tattoo?" She'd done a few naval-themed tattoos before. She tried to guess which one would bring a guy like Sebastian to her doorstep.

"Yes, I could never forget it! It was magnificent! A beautiful sword with a jewel-encrusted on the hilt and some strange writing on the blade. It was on the back of a blonde warrior. Although, I only have eyes for my dearest Mermista." Catra tried to keep her face neutral as her heart thudded in her chest. "I asked the woman where she got such a fine tattoo and she gushed about your work and insisted I had to come here."

Catra felt her eyebrow twitch. *Of fucking course, it's Adora's sword tattoo.* Of all the things she wanted to think of today, Adora and the tattoos she'd marked her with were not on the list, especially after she ran into her at that bar.

"And when did you hear about us?" She honestly didn't know why she asked. Adora probably talked to this clown ages ago if she was giving Catra a glowing review.

"Last week! I'm very serious about getting Daughter's Dragon Three you see, so I had to follow up on such a good lead." He explained folding his arm over his chest.

Catra stared at Sebastian agape. She couldn't believe it. At one time, Adora had been the biggest supporter of her work, but it had been a long time since that was true. Why would she have discussed this with anyone so recently? Least of all a stranger?

"Are you sure you talked to her last week? Not a few months ago?" Catra clarified, shifting over the decorative plant that served as a centerpiece of the table.

She felt a spike of jealousy and disbelief course through her at the thought of Adora. She couldn't square away the image of Adora talking fondly of her work when she had the glimpse of her taking some girl home fresh on her mind. She'd only caught a glimpse of

Adora at the bar that night, but Catra would know her anywhere. Had that girl touched Adora, placing her fingertips on the very tattoos that Catra left on her body? Maybe she asked about them, would that jar Adora out of whatever moment she was having with her? Did she think of— She quickly put the thought of Adora's night out and the way it made her stomach roll out of her mind.

"Yes, my lady, quite positive." He nodded definitively, tapping his temple. "I have a steel trap, I do!"

Catra schooled her expression but it was difficult. This unexpected gesture through her for a loop.

"Okay then, let's draw up some sketches. Follow me." She shook her head, ignoring the relentless thoughts of Adora that bubbled up, and tried to go on with her day.

Then

"You know you can't be mad at me if this comes out bad, you're volunteering." Catra side-eyed her fiancé who was currently sitting in her tattoo chair face down. She apprenticed for a few months and was finally ready to do her first big project. Adora wouldn't hear about her tattooing anyone else.

"Cat, the whole reason you pushed off starting your apprenticeship was to move with me to Alwyn for my MBA program," Adora repeated for what must have been the hundredth time. "The least I can do to support you is be your guinea pig." She placed a soft kiss on Catra's hand. "Besides, I think if anyone else got to have your first big tattoo I would die of jealousy."

Catra rolled her eyes fondly. "Okay dummy, you win. Just don't say I didn't warn you if it sucks." She deflected. Catra hid it, but she was nervous as hell about fucking up Adora's unmarred skin. She was confident in her abilities but this was her *everything*. If she fucked up Adora's tattoo there would be no hiding from it.

Especially now that they were getting married. She looked down at the ring Adora had gotten her, a dopey smile flickering over her face. It still hadn't fully sunk in, Adora had only proposed a few weeks ago after she graduated from her Master's and they moved back to Bright Moon. She wasn't particularly sappy but the idea of marrying Adora had her floating on a cloud.

"Okay , you're sure this is what you want?" She leveled her fiancee with a hard stare. Adora propped herself up on the chair, responding with an arched brow and a look that screamed *are you serious right now?* They'd gone back and forth on the design for months until it was perfect, so Adora's sword piece should be a success. *Should be.*

"Let me know if you need a break, okay?" Catra kissed Adora's nose and took pleasure in the bashful look that crossed Adora's face.

"Sure. I'm ready to start whenever you are." Adora tossed Catra a challenging look, her face leaning against the headrest of the tattoo chair. Catra could see her foot already tapping out a rhythm. It was going to be hard to get Adora to sit still for this.

Catra placed her hands on Adora's back slowly moving them down, reveling in her shudder. Not exactly the most professional thing she'd done today, but whatever. Adora stopped tapping her foot.

"Okay princess, sit tight." The buzz of the machine kicked in and Catra focused on the lines on Adora's back. Time flew by as Catra concentrated on her craft, taking extra care to monitor Adora's reaction.

"Can I peek?" Adora teased through clenched teeth. She closed her eyes, scrunching them together as she let out a sharp breath through her nose, discomfort evident.

"Nope. You're just going to have to trust me Dora." Catra replied sweetly.

"I always trust you, Cat." She didn't bother opening her eyes. Although Adora's voice was strained with pain it came out sure.

Ultimately, it took over six hours and Adora would probably need a second session to fill out some of the colors after the swelling went down, but it was finally done. Catra thought it looked pretty good if she said so herself. She turned her machine off, the shop sounding particularly quiet without the constant buzz.

"It's done." Adora looked up at her, relief seeping into her features. She smiled and leaned down to give her a chaste kiss.

"Yeah, princess." Adora's responding smile is blinding. "Close your eyes for a minute."

She pouted for a moment but dutifully closed her eyes, her face slack compared to the pinched expression she bore while Catra worked. She carefully set up a mirror so Adora could see the results. Butterflies flew up to her gut and into her throat, making it hard to speak.

"Alright, you can open your eyes Dora." She whispered softly. Adora did as asked and stared into the mirror, her expression unreadable. The silence dragged on until Catra couldn't take it anymore.

"Do you like it?" Catra couldn't help but stand on the balls of her feet, anxious for Adora's reaction. Adora continued to stare at the mirror in disbelief, immediately bursting into tears. *Oh, fuck. She hates it and it's permanent and she's going to take the ring back and—*

"Cat this is absolutely amazing." Adora sniffled still, but she was also beaming back at Catra now. *Huh?*

She stared at Adora's tear-stained face. "You like it?" Catra processed aloud, not trusting the words.

Adora nodded aggressively like an eager puppy. "Oh yes yes! I just got emotional. I mean, you've been working so hard to do this and

follow your dream and Im so proud I it all welled up."Adora flashed her the dorkiest smile she'd ever seen. *Damn, I am marrying the biggest sap on the planet.* The thought warmed her to the tips of her toes.

"Well, Im glad you like it, dummy . We still have to go over how to care for it while it heals, don't think you're getting out of that."She teased as she started gently spreading a lotion on Adora's back before covering her up.

She flashed Catra a smirk. "Somehow , I think that my fiancé will be willing to take care of it for me."Catra was bombarded with mental images of rubbing lotion into a bare Adora's back in a more private location. *Well, she certainly isn't wrong.*

Adora must have read where her mind was going because her smirk grew. "You know Cat"Adora's voice got lower as she whispered in Catra's ear "you never forget your first."Adora then made a ridiculous face and Catra groaned aloud, hands in her head.

"How long have you been holding that in, Grey?"Catra asked although she was kind of afraid of the answer.

"Too long,"Adora admitted unabashedly . "I've been waiting for this setup for ages."She flashed her cheesiest smile again.

I can't wait to marry this idiot.

Now

By the time Catra got to her apartment she was exhausted, barely able to keep her eyes open. Sebastian kept changing his mind about what he wanted his ship to look like until she finally told him to think about it and to reach out to schedule another meeting to discuss the design. She'd be pissed if he hadn't put down a huge deposit.

After that, she had back-to-back sessions, then raced to pick up Finn from school, helped her kid with their homework, fed them, and finally managed to put them to sleep. She felt like collapsing now that she didn't have to mind her rugrat. *I'm so glad the weekend is only a day away.* She had a few weekend sessions sometimes, but she never scheduled them when she had Finn.

She felt her phone buzz, so she looked at her notifications. Her heart lurched. A text from Adora. She opened it immediately, scrunching her eyes at the brightness of the screen.

Hey, when you bring Finn over would you mind sticking around for a bit? I want to talk to you about something.

Catra furrowed her brow. She wasn't quite sure what to make of that text. She already felt off-balance from how Adora was apparently providing *referrals* to her tattoo shop. Catra was honest enough, at least with herself, to know that she was also affected by seeing Adora at the bar the other night.

Catra couldn't help how outright shitty she felt, seeing that girl hanging off Adora's every word, preening under her attention. She knew what that felt like to have Adora's singular focus was an overwhelming thing. Her blue eyes would really focus and she got that little tilt of her chin when she was deep in thought. It was hard to think of Adora as anything but hers, even though she knew it was hypocritical to feel jealous.

She bit her lip as she thought about how to reply.

Sure. Is everything ok? Is it about Finn?

It was probably a logistical thing with Finn. That's what it usually was at any rate. She tried not to think about how depressing that was, even if they never got back together. She'd deal with whatever issue it was and pretend she hadn't seen Adora at the bar and everything would be normal. Or whatever normal was now.

Everything's fine! It isn't about Finn, just easier to talk about in person. Don't worry about it, I just wanted to make sure you had time to talk on Sunday.

Catra snorted derisively at that last text. *Easy to say don't worry about it, a whole other thing to do it.* Catra laid down and added Adora's vague text messages to the mountain of stress that was her week. Almost against her will, her eyelids drooped and her limbs grew heavy.

Some noise woke her up. She hadn't even realized that she fell asleep. She lifted her head and looked around her room bleary-eyed, trying to figure out what woke her up at whatever forsaken hour it was. As her eyes adjusted to the darkness, she could make out a little head peeking in by her doorframe.

"Mama, I had a nightmare. Can I stay with you tonight?" She heard the soft voice of her kid tremble as they made the request. Her heart melted at the sight of Finn looking unsure.

Finn's blonde hair was sticking up everywhere and the baby fat on their face was starting to disappear, gangly limbs replacing their once smaller frame. They were no longer the two-year-old child that she didn't know but couldn't wait to learn about.

"Of course, baby. What did you have a nightmare about?" Finn scampered under the covers, laying on their belly next to Catra and nuzzling the pillow. She started to rub between their shoulders soothingly in the way she knew helped after a bad nightmare. Finn always favored Catra after a nightmare, taking to her side of the bed while Adora watched them with fond eyes.

"I don't know, I can't really remember." Finn's eyes darted away as they delivered the line. *Well, that was a lie.* Catra hummed as if she believed them and continued to rub their back. They'd talk when they were ready, it usually took a minute.

Finn's breathing evened out to the point where she thought they'd fallen back to sleep when she heard them shift more intentionally. Their blue eyes opened, and they averted their gaze as they asked their question.

"Are you ever going to come back home, mama?" *Shit, that's what this is about.* Catra shouldn't be surprised. They'd taken the separation hard.

The conversation where she told Finn that she was moving out temporarily while Adora sat stock still next to her was by far the worst moment of her life. Finn burst into tears and thought they were being left behind by Adora and Catra. It had taken hours to calm them down enough to accept the assurances that they would still have both their moms.

Finn was still looking up at her, blue eyes looking like they glowed in the dark. Stars, she didn't know how to answer that question. Right now, she felt the answer was clearly no, she didn't think she would ever move back with Adora and Finn, but she couldn't say that without talking to Adora about it.

"Does this have something to do with your dream bud?" she prompted, hoping to get a better idea of where her kid's head was at.

"I overheard auntie Glimmer telling mom she should get a girlfriend," Finn admitted. They tugged on their hair a little in frustration. "But why would she get a girlfriend when she has you? It's not right mama!"

Finn was all righteous indignation on her behalf. They cuddled in closer as if comforting her from the idea of Adora finding someone else.

The next time I see Sparkles, I am going to fucking murder her. I don't care that we just made up. Glimmer wouldn't know discretion if someone beat her over the head with it. Another thought crossed her mind: *what if that blonde at the bar is Adora's girlfriend?*

She felt so much right then: anger at Glimmer for being the idiot she knew, misplaced betrayal at the idea of Adora getting a serious partner, but most of all, guilty that she had Starla and was actively hiding her from Finn. All of the emotions coiled together uncomfortably in her gut. She took a deep breath to steady herself.

"What does that have to do with what you dreamed baby?" Finn looked so small rubbing their face into the pillow for comfort.

"Mom married someone else and then she wouldn't let me see you." Catra grabbed Finn and hugged them tight to her chest. Once Finn latched on to Adora and Catra, they always worried about being abandoned. It broke Catra's heart to know that she was the cause of that fear right now.

"Oh baby , no. That's not going to happen." She reassured quietly . "Even if mom did get married to another person—" she felt her stomach clench at the thought *we will work on that later Catra* "you'd still be my kid. Always. No matter what Finn, you're stuck with me forever."

"Promise?" They asked quietly , eyes still intent on their mother. Catra nuzzled them close placing a soft kiss on their head.

"Promise Finnie." Catra gently tickled Finn's ribs causing them to giggle. They snuggled closer. Catra took a deep breath.

"Also, if your mom or I decide that we do want to have other partners that's something that we'll deal with when the time comes, but it'll be ok Finn." Finn side-eyed her wearily , a 100% Catra move. *Stars, she loves this kid.* "Finn, no matter what your mom and I will always, always, put you first. There's no way that anything happening or not happening between us would keep either of us from you. Your mom and I have known each other our whole lives and we'll always be able to work together when it comes to you, kid."

Finn seemed reassured, nodding against Catra's chest. As she watched her child's breathing slow, she willed her words to be true.

Chapter End Notes

We've seen a bit of Adora's job now we've seen Catra's!Also, I always love a soft moment between Catra and Finn. I know exactly zero things about the mechanics of tattooing except for the time I took two folks to get tattoos so pardon any inaccuracies.

You have no idea how close I've come to writing a comedic one-shot detailing the horrors of Seahawk's tattoo journey with Catra lol. Literally like the "If this gets one like" meme at this point lol.

As always, kudos and comments are incredibly appreciated. Also, follow me on Twitter @RosesFlower1 for updates and other random queer/SPOP things.

Next Week: Adora asks Catra if she'd like to be friends and in the past, Adora and Catra watch a movie together.

Also if you are a fan of the Mask and Mistakes Universe (Superhero AU) maybeeeee a one-shot will drop next week? Get ready to cry is all Im going to say about that lol.

A Sincere Movie

Chapter Summary

Adora has a proposition for Catra.

Adora and Catra almost watch a movie.

Adora, Catra, and Finn finally watch a movie.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora cleaned the house at least three times as she waited for Catra and Finn. Her gut was nothing but a mountain of butterflies. She paced as she thought about what she was planning, hands twitching to her side as she just looked for *something* to do. Anything to put her mind off what came next.

When Catra dropped off Finn today, Adora was set on making her first overtures into friendship. She already texted Catra and told her she wanted to talk last night, so there was no backing out now. *Come on Adora, you can do it, just make some small talk to start. It's just Catra.* Surely, she couldn't do anything to make Catra hate more than she probably already did. *Right?*

She checked the trash bag in the kitchen and realized she'd already taken it out. She didn't think the living room had ever been this spotless, even when they first moved in all those years ago. All of Finn's toys and books are safely stored in their respective cubbies and shelves. She'd set up the projector in case she was successful in getting what she wanted. *Might be wishful thinking, but better to be prepared.* She looked down at her own clothes, checking to see if she'd dirtied herself up while cleaning the house. Nothing looked worse for wear, her shorts and shirt looked clean but also casual.

She continued to putter about uselessly for a few more minutes, ignoring what felt like rocks in her stomach when she heard Catra's car pull up into the driveway.

Catra knocked on the door and Adora opened it, her hand slipping momentarily on the doorknob. The first thing she saw was Finn as they ran up and hugged her. Adora gave them a big kiss on the cheek and pulled them close~~she~~ missed them so much the last few days. She always did when they were gone.

She looked past Finn at Catra who was effortlessly gorgeous as always. Today she wore leggings and a comfy sweater that swallowed her frame. It wasn't an odd look for Catra in the spring, but it was a bit dressed down compared to what Catra usually wore when she dropped Finn off on the weekends.

"Hi!" The squeaky greeting was too excited and bright to be normal. Adora winced at the high-pitched sound that had the misfortune of passing from her lips. *Wow, have I always been this bad at speaking with people?* Catra looked up from her phone, seemingly amused if not a bit cautious. *That's good at least?*

"Hello to you too," Catra replied gingerly , pocketing her phone and really looking at Adora for the first time. Adora's hand reached without permission to rub the back of her neck nervously. Catra tracked the movement with suspicion. Adora looked down at Finn who still had her wrapped up in a hug. She stepped out of her half-crouch turning back to Finn.

"Finnie, why don't you unpack, and we can think about what we want to do this afternoon huh?" Adora suggested as she gently nudged them into the house. They nodded and lugged their bag up the stairs, taking the steps two at a time as they stomped up.

"Okay , so what do you want to talk about?" Catra leaned on the doorframe, almost inside the house but not quiet. Adora took a deep breath.

"Us."Catra' s eyes widened, immediately taken aback. "Not like~~no~~t our marriage but you know"~~A~~dora' s whole vocabulary~~ev~~very word she ever learned or thought she knew~~ev~~aporated from her brain. She groaned putting her head in her hands. "As you know , I am the absolute worst at words."Then to herself, she whispered, "I dont know how I thought this might go over well."

She sent Catra a helpless look from between her fingers, although she didnt know what she hoped for . Catra didnt owe her anything. To her surprise, Catra giggled~~or~~ , Adora guessed, just straight-up laughed at her. It seemed to thaw something between them.

"Okay , why dont you try again, and Ill forget whatever the hell that was."Catra of fered humor echoing in her voice as she crossed her arms. Adora puffed up her chest, determined.

"Okay ." *You can do this Ad ey . Use small words.* "Catra, Id like to be friends. Do you wanna hang out with Finn and me for ice cream and a movie this afternoon?"Adora said it all in one breath, her nerves betraying her yet again. She just wanted so badly to have this piece of Catra again, even if she didnt deserve it.

Catra stared at her with wide eyes and mouth slightly open. Adora isnt sure if the movie and ice cream are winning of fers on their own, so she kept pressing.

"Look~~I k~~now where we stand. W e arent getting back together"— Adora swallowed the pain she felt at saying those words ~~bu~~t I miss my best friend."She couldnt help the tenderness and longing that slipped into the end of her sentence. SHe missed all of Catra but this part, the part she had since she was in first grade, was the part she simply could not live without. She could deal with everything else.

Adora smiled at Catra, willing her to understand. Hoping against all hope that some part of Catra still missed her friendship.

"I don't get where this is coming from Adora." Catra placed a hand on her hip. "Were you a victim of an alien invasion? Because we haven't been friends in a long time." She snarked, narrowing her eyes on Adora.

Adora hesitated for a moment, briefly considering bringing up that she saw Catra the other day at the bar. She quickly dismissed the thought—there was no way she could explain anything that happened that night without it being too much. Besides, she didn't want Catra thinking that she'd been looking for her or that Adora was even there at all.

As Adora struggled to collect her thoughts, Catra wilted under her gaze, growing smaller. The hand that was on her hip went across her body as she used it to hold herself together. Adora's heart clenched at the sight. It reminded Adora of what Catra looked like right before she left their home for good.

"I owe you an apology for the way I treated you. I should've started with that." The words came as easy as breathing now. She tried to pack them with as much sincerity as possible.

She eyed her with mistrust, pressing her lips together as she considered Adora. "I'm listening," Catra said slowly leaning back from the heavy conversation.

Adora took a moment to really look at her best friend with the afternoon sun kissing her curls. As beautiful as Catra looked, Adora was struck by the way she was holding back, wary of Adora. Her chest ached with the desire to fix this. She stopped thinking and just spoke from her heart.

"I'm sorry I hurt you. There's no excuse for it. I was inattentive in the worst way, and I made our marriage miserable. It's my fault we're like this." She looked at the distance between them, the uneasiness that hung in the air between them. Catra's eyes widen at her apology, her jaw dropping slightly. "I know it's too little and far too late at this point.

But you deserve to know that and I'm taking responsibility for it now . Like I should have done a while ago."

Adora's chest tightened as she waited for Catra's response. She knew Catra deserved a thousand different apologies from her, but she didn't want to bring up specific instances if Catra didn't want to talk about it. She just hoped this would be enough.

Catra stared agape for a few moments before her jaw snapped shut. "This isn't an attempt to get back together is it?" Catra asked her stare trained on Adora, searching her every expression.

Adora's eyes widened as she shook her head fervently. "Not at all I— I respect what you have with Starla, and I don't want to get in the way of your happiness."It was difficult to say, but nonetheless true. If seeing Catra at the bar did anything it solidified in her mind that Catra's path to happiness was with Starla, not Adora.

She stared at Adora for another few moments and she relaxed, seemingly believing her. Catra looked up the stairs landing, eyes searching. She dropped her voice as she spoke, leaning a little closer so Adora could hear her.

"Finn had a bad nightmare yesterday . They dreamt that you remarried and they weren't allowed to see me anymore."Catra whispered low the way she always did when they talked about Finn but they were wandering about. Adora leaned forward, concern pinching her brow, feeling whiplash at the abrupt conversation change.

"Where could they possibly have gotten that idea from?" She asked quizzically . Adora held back a snort at the idea that she would ever remarry. *You could've told them that there isn't a snowball's chance in hell I'd ever marry anyone else.* She felt herself freeze up, taking a step back. That was not a friendly thought. Adora would have to lock it away somewhere.

"Finn overheard auntie *Glimmer* saying that you needed a girlfriend." Catra's voice was near a growl when it curled around Glimmer's name, eyes flashing in annoyance.

Adora groaned closing her eyes as she rubbed one of her temples. "I'm sorry Ill give her the little ears conversation again. And Ill guilt her for giving Finn a nightmare."She assured. "Whatd you tell Finn?"

Catra averted her gaze, looking at the door frame instead. "I told them that neither of us would keep them from seeing the other. That wed always find common ground when it came to them. That they came first for us."Catra supplied. She looked up searching Adora' s expression for approval. She relaxed a fraction.

"And that' s all true. Id never keep them from you, Cat."She said earnestly.

"I know that Dor ."Catra sounded sure on that point at least.

Adora eyed Catra, knowing a diversion tactic when she saw one. "Catra. W e were lifelong friends before we were ever together romantically. At the very least itll be good for Finn, especially if theyre having these worries."She pointed out.

"I—dont know if that' s a good idea, Adora."She remained unconvinced, biting her bottom lip as she shifted her weight from side to side.

Adora gave Catra a searching look, one of her hands carefully but intentionally moving towards Catra's.

"Dont you miss me?"Adora whispered the vulnerable question. It hung between them for a moment before she rushed to clarify. "Our friendship Cat."

Something about the question made Catra' s walls drop for a moment and Adora could plainly see the sadness sketched into her eyes.

"Of course, I miss being your friend." The words felt bittersweet to Adora. She wouldn't know what she'd do with herself if Catra didn't miss their friendship, but it hurt as a reminder that it was all that was on the table for them.

"We don't have to hang out just us two. It can just be some things with Finn and our friends." She wanted to hang out with Catra alone and be best friends again, but she was willing to take anything Catra would give her.

Adora grabbed her hand like she did when they were two kids at the playground, the most platonic handhold imaginable. Her hands were always smaller, more delicate than Adora's even though she used them all day to draw. It still made her heart flutter when she felt Catra's hand underneath her own.

"You can't tell me you like carefully coordinating all of our social activities apart?" Adora raised an eyebrow, challenging her.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Avoiding you kind of sucks." She finally admitted.

"I promise this is a purely platonic request from my end. I've really thought about what's happened this last year and the way things are ~~it~~ doesn't feel right. I think this would." Adora squeezed Catra's hand gently. "You've always been my friend Cat. I want a chance to prove I can be a good friend to you too."

Catra stood at the doorframe indecision covering her features. She searched Adora's gaze for something. Adora tried to be as open as she could, hoping that whatever tug of war Catra was having with herself ended in them being more than whatever they'd been to each other lately. She must find whatever it was because her shoulders relaxed.

"Alright, what movie are we watching?" Catra asked, finally stepping inside their home.

Adora’s heart took flight.

Then

“What movie are we watching?” Catra’s eyes practically glowed at night, the shades of blue and hazel glittering in the low light coming from the TV and through the bedroom window.

“Not a horror movie!” Adora protested, knowing she couldn’t trust Catra to pick anything different. At thirteen, they were finally old enough to watch them now, but horror movies made Adora have nightmares for weeks. She’d end up calling Catra in the middle of the night to soothe them and it was getting embarrassing to still need that comfort. They were finishing up middle school and it was not cool to be scared of movies, no matter how many haunted dolls were in them.

“But it’s almost my birthday! It has to be a scary movie this late in October!” Catra argued back, giggling from under the covers.

“Adora! Sharon is here for you!” Catra’s mom called from the first floor. Adora felt herself stiffen in disappointment.

Catra groaned, fisting the blanket under her grasp. “Ugh, that old hag won’t let you live Dor. It’s Friday! Why’s she picking you up so early?” She complained as she helped Adora look for her shoes.

“She’s not that bad. She cares about Mara and me.” Adora protested weakly. She didn’t have many other options and the few that she might consider would either take her away from Catra or separate her from Mara, both unacceptable notions. Adora could deal with Weaver.

“I don’t like her Dor, she doesn’t treat you right.” Catra insisted, eyes angry.

"She treats me fine."Adora dismissed as she picked her bag of f the floor. "Besides we dont have anyone else."She whispered, hating how vulnerable she felt jst then.

Suddenly two arms were grabbing her by the shoulders, and she felt Catra's eyes piercing into her very soul. Looking at Catra like this had started to make Adora's heart beat fast although she had no idea why. Catra was always like this, fierce and strong. So brave that it sometimes worried Adora~~b~~ut she knew she'd be there to keep Catra out of too much trouble.

"Y ou have me, Adora. You and Mara will always have me and my family."Catra promised as she pulled Adora into a qick hug before letting her go."W e can help you."

"Y ou guys do enough for us as it is."Adora felt the waves of old guilt crashing over her as she thought of jst how much kindness she constantly received in this house when she had absolutely *nothing* to give back. She tried doing chores or being otherwise helpful but they never let her, shooing her with a warm smile. THe only thing they ever asked her for was to look out for Catra which was silly. Adora would look out for Catra forever, no matter what.

"W e would do more. If you need it, you and Mara could come live with us. We could be like sisters."The idea of living with Catra' s family was amaizng but the word sister left a bad taste in Adora' s mouth.

She shook her head at the thought. "I dont think I want to be your sister Cat,"Adora said with a scrunched-up nose.

Catra rolled her eyes, shoving her playfully. "I dont either , dummy. But Im jst saying we would take you in."Catra reminded her as if she hadnt jst mentioned it.

"Okay Cat, I appreciate it but W eaver's not that bad. Mara and I are fine."She reassured her best friend who still stared at her with a disbelieving furrowed brow.

Adora picked up her things and headed down the stairs. Her stomach clenched with anxiety, try as she might to relax

"Adora, there you are. What took you so long?" Weaver tsked, looking down at her watch. Adora stiffened at the critical tone.

"Sorry I was picking up my stuff, ma'am." Adora tugged on her backpack strap holding it close.

"No matter child, let's go." Weaver tugged on Adora's arm. She glanced over her shoulder.

"Bye!" She called out to Catra and her folks. She couldn't hear if they responded because she was already walking briskly, Weaver's hold on her arm tightening as they went. Weaver's hand reminded her of a blood pressure cuff if it was meant to cut off your circulation entirely. She ignored the pain in her arm, knowing that telling her it hurt would only make it worse.

"Adora I've told you many times do not hang around with Catra and her *kind*. It'll only lead to heartbreak. You need to be studious so you can get a scholarship. It's the only way you'll be able to go to school and be successful." Weaver droned on as Adora dutifully listened keeping a wince off her face. "When we get home, you're going to be practicing for the high school entrance exam."

"Yes ma'am." She didn't bother telling Weaver that it was late at night on a Friday or that she didn't have to start preparing for that exam until well into next year. She couldn't find the words under the weight of Weaver's eyes, her hands, of the expectation placed on her.

She'd much rather be watching a movie with Catra.

Now

"Hey Finnie, get down here when you're done!" Adora called out. She heard a door slam before Finn trampled down the stairs.

"Is it time to say bye?" Finn asked Catra, big blue eyes shining. Before Catra could respond, they threw themselves into her arms, giving her a big hug. She squeezed them back, a grin overtaking her face for a moment.

"Actually , bud, we wanted to talk about something." Catra gave Finn a gentle smile as they sat down on the couch next to Catra. Adora moved to sit on their other side. "How would you feel about watching a movie together?" Catra asked them.

Finn tilted their head to the side. "We always watch movies together mama." Finn pointed out with a no-nonsense tone. They looked at Catra like she might have hit her head. Adora could tell that Catra was straining to keep her eyes from rolling. Adora had to keep herself from laughing at the exchange.

"I meant us three, kid. Right now ." Catra clarified. She tried to keep her face neutral, not trying to influence Finn one way or the other.

"Can I pick the movie?" They asked, their voice serious. Adora snorted at that, unable to keep quiet any longer .

"If you want. We can't have mom picking we know how awful her taste in movies is." Catra said in a faux-whisper as she tossed a performative glance Adora's way.

"Hey! I have great taste in movies!" She pretended to be indignant but really she missed Catra and Finn ganging up on her.

Finn giggled but then got quiet, eyeing Catra with excitement. "Are you coming back home then?" They asked, almost bouncing in their seat. Adora's breath caught in her throat. She should have expected Finn to ask this but she really hadn't thought passed getting Catra to agree to the movie.

Catra gave them an even stare back. "No bud." She said firmly but full of patience. "Mom and I thought it might be fun to do some things for the three of us because we're both still your moms and we love

you very much. Would you still want to watch the movie? Even if it doesn't mean that I'm moving back?"

Finn eyed Catra then turned to look at Adora. Their gaze briefly flickered behind them at the projector.

"Okay." Finn accepted rather easily.

Adora got out of her seat clapping her hands together, relief flooding her. "What are we watching then since I'm not allowed to make decisions?" She asked. Catra and Finn looked at each other, then both turned to Adora at the same time.

"Moana." Catra and Finn both deadpanned at the same time before bursting into laughs. Finn's class recently watched the film and now Finn was on a rewatch binge. Adora hoped it wouldn't be too long before something else caught their interest, although she admitted it could be a lot worse.

"It's freaky how you both do that." Adora gave an exaggerated shudder. "I'm going to grab the ice cream."

Adora sat in the kitchen for a minute collecting herself, taking a few deep breaths as she stared at the pattern on the countertop. This was exactly what she wanted but it made her head spin to see the three of them clicking so well the instant they let themselves coexist together. It was like putting on a pair of well-loved jeans that always fit right.

She got back in with the ice cream to find Catra in her old spot on the couch, the living room projector already set up. Adora handed her a mug filled to the brim with chocolate ice cream.

"Thanks." She gripped it easily, mixing the ice cream with the spoon that Adora placed in the mug.

"No problem." She waved her off, sitting down on her side of the sectional. Finn snatched their ice cream without delay placing

themselves smackdab between them.

"Okay let' s get to watching the movie."They cheered and pressed play. Adora stayed safely on Finn's side, making sure to never accidentally graze Catra.

It felt the same but very different. Usually, whenever they watched movies as a family, they were all sprawled over each other. Catra's feet inevitably ended up in Adora's hands as she gently rubbed them, warming them up and relieving the tension she usually felt after a long day of being on her feet for some parts of her tattoo sessions. Other times, Adora would be blanketed by her wife, feeling Catra press small kisses to her collarbone as she nuzzled in and Finn sat closer to the projector on the ground.

Now, Finn was sprawled as they always were, but Catra and Adora were collected, huddled into their respective corners. It was a strange mix of pain at noticing the dif ferences, but euphoria at having Catra there at all.

Every now and then they would laugh at something in the movie and catch each other's eyes over Finn's head. She felt herself get pulled into the film until she heard a soft snore coming from her lap.

"They always fall asleep."She noted fondly as she took in their slack expression, mouth slightly agape. She felt warm all over looking at them. Adora carefully lifted Finn up into her arms gently putting them to sleep in their room.

Putting Finn down without waking them was becoming harder every day but by some miracle, she managed it now. Catra followed along, watching Finn with soft eyes. She placed a soft kiss on their forehead before following Adora back downstairs.

"I cant lift them anymore when they're dead weight like that,"Catra said as she collected her bag, the longing clear as day on her face.

"They're growing up so fast."Adora echoed, knowing exactly where Catra's thoughts were for once. They held each other's stare for a moment. "Thanks for staying,"Adora whispered, suddenly feeling shy now that Finn wasn't there to buffer.

"It was nice. I think we could do something like this again."Catra offered tentatively.

Adora grinned. "Sounds good. I'll let you know about picking up Finn this week."Adora responded, taking a step back and putting her hands in her pockets. She clenched them there to resist the urge to pull Catra into a hug. *Don't be too much Adora and maybe things can be okay.*

"Bye Adora."Catra waved, as she walked towards the door.

"Bye,"Adora called after her. As locked the front door, she realized Catra never said if she accepted her apology. She thought about it and shrugged to herself. Time would tell if she'd be so lucky.

It didn't matter today, because it was the first time in a long time that saying bye to Catra didn't hurt and she was going to hold onto that instead. Everything else could wait.

Chapter End Notes

> They're on the road to mending something!Did this go how you thought it would? I know we didn't get too much Catra insight rest assured that we will learn a lot more about how she is feeling in the next few Catra POV chapters. We are about 2 to 3 chapters away from what I consider the third (and last) act in this fic and I'm very excited to know how y'all will feel about it :)
>
> Also, I think this is the first of the pre-college flashbacks!Let me know if you enjoyed that :)
>
> As always, kudos and comments are appreciated!Also, come hang out with me on

Twitter!

Next Week: Catra's in for an unpleasant conversation that will force her to make a decision about her marriage. In the past, she talks about filing for divorce.

Also if you are a fan of the Mask and Mistakes Universe (Superhero AU) Catra's origin story is going to drop this weekend :D

The Unsigned Papers

Chapter Summary

Starla's done.

Catra isn't ready for a relationship.

Catra isn't picking up Finn.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She sat on her couch, checking her phone every few minutes. Starla promised she'd come by today but Catra hadn't seen her much this week and it started to feel like she was avoiding Catra. She sighed and grabbed a blanket off the couch and snuggled in, determined to wait for her girlfriend.

She also wanted to tell Starla about watching that movie with Adora and Finn yesterday~~it~~ felt like something they should discuss in person. She hadn't even wrapped her own head around it. Adora apologized and wanted to be *friends* of all things. It had been so long since she'd seen Adora look so honest and apologetic.

She didn't know if she could forgive Adora for everything that happened between them but knew she couldn't hold on to her anger. It wasn't going to help anyone, and frankly, it was exhausting.

Anger aside, she also didn't know if they could actually be real friends again. There was so much to be worried about: how Finn would react, what her friends would see, if friendship was even a good option for them. But she was tired of being cold with Adora, it didn't come naturally to her.

Adora had given her that sheepish smile that convinced Catra of everything~~s~~kipping class, going to prom, moving to Elberon, taking a chance and becoming a tattoo artist. It had been too much to hope she'd be able to say no.

She can't say she regretted her decision. She got more time with Finn and by the time she left things with Adora already felt better. Maybe that had always been their mistake~~m~~aybe they were better as friends. Adora sure seemed to think so. Catra was startled at the knock on her door. She shook her head and got out from under her blanket, meandering over. Starla looked gorgeous as always and Catra moved to kiss her. She returned her kiss but broke it off sooner than she'd like given how long it'd been since they last saw each other.

"Hey Star , I missed you."She pulled the shorter woman into a hug. Starla held her back tightly for a few moments before taking a step back. She looked tired, her eyes a little glassy in a way that made Catra suspect she stayed up late the night before.

"I missed you too Cat. Do you know what you want to watch?"She walked into the apartment and made herself comfortable on the couch Catra was just sitting on. Catra grabbed the remote and joined her.

"Not really anything works."She handed the remote over to Starla, watching her scroll. She pulled her arm around Starla. "Mostly just want to spend time with you."

Starla hummed her acknowledgement as she perused the TV show options and put something on, cuddling into Catra's side. Although they were physically close, Catra felt like something was off about Starla. It was in the jut of her lips, the tense set of her shoulders, the tightening at the corners of her eyes. Something was definitely bothering her.

Catra eyed her girlfriend for the fourth time in as many minutes, trying to catch her gaze. Starla steadfastly avoided it. The plan had

been to stay in with some takeout and a TV, but Catra felt a bit unbalanced as she sat cuddling Starla.

"Did your sister manage to get that rental she was looking at?" Catra tried to coax Starla out of her bad mood with a conversation about her family. For a moment, it seemed to work as Starla brightened.

"Yeah, she'd been hunting it down for ages! She really liked the apartment building, and the management seems competent if not a little overly friendly." She scrunched her nose, presumably at the thought of speaking to management other than to turn over rental payments or request they fix the plumbing.

"That's good then." Catra smiled, hoping that Starla might keep talking. Instead, she deflated laying her head on Catra's chest.

"Anything new with you?" Starla asked, her tone subdued again. Catra furrowed her brow, thinking of the time she spent with Adora and Finn yesterday. It probably wasn't the best time to bring this up, but she wasn't going to hide it from Starla outright either.

"Yeah, actually. When I dropped off Finn, we watched a movie with Adora." Catra mentioned tentatively as she ran her hand down Starla's arm. Starla pulled back slightly to look at Catra's face, her eyebrows furrowed together.

"Yesterday?" There was something pointed in Starla's voice Catra couldn't place but it definitely wasn't good. Catra bit her bottom lip, trying to pick her next words carefully.

"Yeah. It wasn't planned or anything. It was a spontaneous thing. We thought it might be better for Finn if we're on friendlier terms." Catra explained. She'd been caught off guard when Adora had made the offer, she expected Starla would be too.

"Friendly?" Her voice sounds like an angry echo of Catra's. She looked down at Starla, a little surprised by just how upset she

looked. She didn't think she'd be thrilled but it wasn't like she did anything *wrong*.

"Yeah. Nothing crazy, just spending some time with Finn." Catra downplayed. To be honest, that was all Catra really expected to come from a friendship with Adora.

Starla suddenly crushed Catra into a hug, startling her with the way her arms desperately clung to Catra. She put her arm around Starla, feeling the tension in her back, holding her back just as tight although she wasn't sure why. She felt a pit in her stomach as she burrowed her face in the shorter girl's curls.

"I don't think this is working out Catra." Starla quietly mumbled into her shirt. She then turned her body away, putting some distance between them. Catra gaped at her—this was the last thing she was expecting when Starla asked to come over.

"What do you mean Starla? What's not working out?" She asked around the knot in her throat. She must be misunderstanding, there was no way Starla's breaking up with her.

"This. Us. Together." She looked away as she said it, tears glistening on her eyelashes. Catra stared and then stared some more.

"Where is this coming from? Is this because of the movie?" Catra asked disbelievingly. It was baffling. She thought things had been going well. They had their issues, but what couple didn't? *Apparently not going as well as I hoped if I'm getting dumped in my living room.*

Starla fixed her with a hard stare.

"Did you *once* think about how I might feel about that Catra? That you spent time with your wife? Mother of your child? The woman who you haven't even filed divorce papers with?" Starla asked as she looked at her, voice sharp and eyes sad. Catra felt a flash of guilt as she realized that Starla didn't cross her mind once the whole time she was with Finn and Adora. She must see something on

Catra's face because she shakes her head. "Don't answer that. It isn't about the movie anyways. I've thought about this before I got here."

"Then what's it about?" Catra asked still at a loss as the truth started sinking in. Starla had been *planning* on breaking up with her.

Starla let out a frustrated huff.

"We just want different things. I've had a great time getting to know you and being intimate with you, but you hold yourself back from me." Catra was about to interrupt with— *No, I've been myself with you*—but was silenced but Starla's stern gaze. "Let me just get this out and then we can talk about it okay?"

Catra nodded and waited, taking a sharp breath through her nose. Starla took a deep breath in turn.

"You were honest with me when we met. You said that you were going through a hard time with your separation, and you didn't want something serious right away. I respected that." She explained holding Catra's gaze. *Okay, that doesn't sound terrible*. "I wanted to be patient, but our relationship isn't giving me what I need anymore." *Ouch*. Starla grabbed her hand, squeezing it gently.

"I was fine with it before because it felt like things were moving in the right direction but then I realized that wasn't true." Catra was really having a hard time not interrupting at this point. Starla started counting off on her fingers, an annoyed edge to her voice. "You won't tell me about your past and I haven't met your parents *or* Finn. I was fine with waiting, but we've been dating for six months and there's no sign of any of that changing. Ever."

Starla seemed to deflate, her anger leaving her as she grew smaller. Catra waited, sensing she still had more to say.

"But even without all that, I knew this wasn't going anywhere because of that night we ran into Adora at the bar. I saw your face

when you noticed her and I've never seen you look at me like that." Starla started to sniffle. "When you recognized her, it was like no one else was in that room. Including me."

Catra stared at Starla incredulously. *That's not true, I don't look at Adora like that anymore. At least I hope not?*

She and Starla were having a great time on their date until she caught a glimpse of Adora's broad back, another blonde clinging to her side. She wore one of Catra's favorite shirts on her. Even though she knew Adora was seeing other people, it felt like something broke inside her chest. The date hadn't finished well after that.

Starla waited for Catra to process before delivering the killing blow.

"I can't keep falling in love with someone who is clearly in love with someone else," Starla whispered through her tears.

That made Catra's heartache. She knew quite a bit about being in love with someone who didn't reciprocate, and it sucked.

"I don't- I'm not-" Catra tried to deny, but she felt stripped bare in the face of Starla's deep sadness. "I'm not hung up on Adora like that." She finally managed to say. Starla eyed her wearily.

"We can disagree on the reason why Cat, but whether it's about Adora or not, you aren't ready to give me more." She looked at Catra, her eyes daring her to deny that. Catra floundered for a moment. She knew she wasn't ready to be more serious yet but she also didn't feel ready to let go of Starla.

"You don't think there's any way that we could work this out?" Catra asked timidly, a hail mary if there ever was one. Starla shook her head, looking away from her.

"No Cat, this isn't something we can fix." She said evenly. Catra took in a shuddering breath, nodding as it all sunk in.

"I'm sorry if I wasn't giving you enough of me. If I hurt you. I never wanted to do that to you Star." Catra felt her eyes well with tears. If she couldn't be what Starla needed, she'd have to find a way to accept that. "You're an amazing girl. You've been a bright spot in my life these last few months. But this isn't about how I feel. I want you to be fulfilled and happy, even if that isn't with me." Catra whispered, feeling like a shit heel. Starla smiled sadly both hands interlacing with Catra's.

"I know, and I think you're amazing too. I just don't think it's right between us." She shrugged, leaning her head forward and resting it against Catra's. Catra knew she wasn't ready to love someone else yet, but she'd moved forward anyway, hoping that she was wrong. And now it blew up in her face.

"I'm sorry for wasting your time." Catra apologized again lingering in Starla's orbit. She didn't want to say goodbye yet. Starla shook her head inching backward to look her dead in the eyes.

"The time we spent together was valuable to me Catra. I hope it was to you too." Starla squeezed her hand as she stood up from the couch.

"Of course, it was. You taught me so much Star about who I am and who I want to be." Catra meant it—she hoped Starla believed that if nothing else. Starla quietly picked up the few things she had left for staying overnight. Catra waited for her by the door, trying to hold back tears.

"I guess this is goodbye then." Starla shifted her weight from side to side. Catra placed a gentle kiss on Starla's forehead. Her eyelashes fluttered shut for a moment.

"Goodbye Star," Catra whispered softly. Starla didn't say anything else as she made her way out of Catra's apartment and out of her life.

Then

"So, when are you going to get those divorce papers rolling?" Lonnie threw carelessly over her shoulder while Catra sketched. The lead of Catra's pencil snapped as she looked up from her drawing.

DT perked up, ready to dig into gossip at all hours of the day.

"Oh yes when *is* tall, blonde, and handsome going to be on the market again officially? You know, just professional curiosity." DT asked with a chuckle as they leaned over the reception desk, head resting on their hand.

"I don't know, I haven't thought about it," Catra grumbled as she looked out the shop's window at the pedestrians passing by. She had thought of it but even hearing the word divorce made her stomach clench. "I'm not sure that we need to do that right now."

Lonnie pursed her lips and walked closer to Catra.

"Be honest with yourself. You've been moved out of your own house for over three months. If Adora hasn't come around and showed you she's willing to change then she isn't going to." Lonnie shrugged, a sympathetic look on her face. "Best cut your losses before it hurts any worse."

"I don't think it can hurt any worse," Catra mumbled to herself. Her heart felt like a jagged thing, every beat painful as if it pulsed sadness through her instead of blood. She collected herself. "I just don't see why everyone is so interested in the paperwork anyway. Mind your damn business." She retorted with no edge. Lonnie rolled her eyes stoping just short of where Catra was sitting with her sketchbook. She leaned forward, catching Catra's gaze.

"It's not just paperwork, if it was, then you wouldn't be putting it off. Or look so green in the face whenever it comes up." Lonnie noted as she eyed her critically. Catra jutted her chin forward, about to reply when Lonnie put up her hand, halting her words. "Look Cat, you can

pretend all you want but that piece of paper means something to you. If it didn't, you'd have no problem getting rid of it."

Catra deflated at that, averting her gaze.

"I just don't feel ready ..." She admitted in a whisper. "I'm not sure if I'll ever be ready to let go of Adora."

"Oh, honey..." DT tutted sympathetically with a raised brow. "Who could blame you?"

Lonnie side eyed DT but kept her focus on Catra.

"You don't have to be ready right now, but someday you will. You both need closure." Lonnie advised, her tone veering away from her usual dryness into something more warm and soft.

"Yeah, I know. I'll get there." Catra tried to not let her doubt cloud her voice. She cleared her throat and eyed her two coworkers. "I just want to work—I don't know why I have to put up with the two of you butting into my love life."

"Lack thereof, darling." DT supplied helpfully as they moved to the small merch section and fidgetted with a few t shirts. Catra rolled her eyes.

"I'm pretty sure this is workplace harassment." Catra intoned, turning back to her drawing. DT snapped her fingers as if they had an idea.

"I know just the thing Catra dear... You need to let me set you up with someone. I'm a matchmaker at heart you know." DT put their hand to their chest as if about to recite a Shakespearean sonnet. Catra snorted.

"The only thing you know how to match-make is trouble." Lonnie glared at DT shoving their shoulder as she walked around them.

"Oooh I do like that, but not this time." DT turned to Catra, setting down one of the shop's merch shirts. "I really think I know your

dream girl.”

DT grabbed their phone and started to scroll, probably looking for a picture of this mystery girl.

“I can assure you that you don’t.” Catra could just imagine the type of people DT hung out with and she was not interested in that. She had enough on her plate without adding any other drama to it.

“I’ll wear you down soon enough and you’ll be singing my praises once you meet her.” DT’s eyes gleamed with mischief. Lonnie shook her head and walked away, clearly giving up whatever small effort she put into reasoning with DT.

“Don’t hold your breath DT,” Catra warned flatly.

“I have my ways, darling.” They finally walked back to the reception desk still typing furiously on their phone.

Catra could barely stomach the idea of getting a divorce, she definitely didn’t have time for a whole other relationship to ruin.

Now

Catra’s eyes were swollen, and her throat felt scratchy from crying. Starla left a few hours ago. *Starla left*. Even though Catra knew she didn’t love Starla, she cared for her deeply. She wanted to be serious with Starla eventually. Or at least she wanted to feel whole enough to have the choice to give her heart away fully.

What really bothered her was the guilt. Deep inside, she knew she wasn’t giving Starla her all, but she still let Starla think that maybe they could be. That was wrong on her part. She didn’t even want to think about all the things Starla said about her feelings for Adora.

In the dark of her room, she could admit to herself that she wasn’t as over her wife as she wanted to be. Catra clenched her fists around

her pillow shoving her head under it. It'd been a year , what would make her feel better? T ime clearly hadn't done the j ob. How could she reclaim the part of her she left with Adora?

She let herself have another fantastic cry. The kind where her eyes could barely open, and she felt like she could drink three liters of water. *I have a lot of experience with these crying sessions lately* she thought ruefully.

She checked her phone and realized the time. *Shit.* She was supposed to pick up Finn in twenty minutes and there was no way she was letting them see her like this.

Catra contemplated asking Scorpia to pick Finn up but quickly discarded that option. Trying to set up an impromptu sleepover would probably just lead to a lot of questions she didn't want to deal with right now. The best thing would be for Finn to stay with Adora. She hoped Adora wouldn't have any issues keeping Finn so last minute.

She resolved to call, taking a deep breath and pressing on Adora's contact. It barely finished the first ring before Adora answered.

"Catra? Is that you?" Adora sounded surprised. *Which fair .* She was supposed to be driving over to her house any minute now. She got straight to the point.

"Can I pick up Finn in a few days? Something came up and I really can't get them right now ." She internally cringed at how wet and gross her voice sounded. "I know this is last minute and I'm sorry about that." She hoped Adora would say yes and leave it alone.

"Cat, what's wrong? Are you sick? Do you need me to get you anything?" Adora' s voice kept getting higher pitched with each question, her concern obvious. *Clearly, I'm not okay , dummy.* She didn't say that. Instead, she lied.

"No, Im fine. The only thing I need is for you to keep Finn for at least one more day."Catra circled back to what was important, gently tugging on her bedsheet for something to do.

"Of course, anything you need."Adora reigned in her voice. She was about to hang up to continue wallowing when she heard a soft, "I mean it Catra."

"Huh?"Maybe the crying waterlogged her brain, but she didnt understand what Adora was saying.

"I know that things have been tense between us for a while now"—*and if that isn't the understatement of the century* ~~b~~ut we're trying to be friends right?If you need something, I want you to know you can count on me. I mean it. Whatever it might be."Adora paused on the line, clearly waiting for some type of response that Catra was wholly unprepared to give.

"I dont know what to say right now , Ive had a shit day , and I feel overwhelmed. I want to be alone."Her voice carried an edge to it as she shut whatever conversation Adora was hoping to have down. She didnt mean to be so honest, but there it was. Adora cleared her throat.

"Y ou dont have to say anything. Ill take care of Finn as long as necessary. Let me know when you want to get them."She assured, her tone no less worried than before. She could almost imagine her pacing, worrying her bottom lip as she spoke. "I hope you have a goodnight, Cat."

The line went dead with a soft sigh. Catra stared unseeingly at her ceiling. With Starla gone and Adora closer than she'd been since they separated, she was adrift. She needed some control over her life.

"Starla was right when she said I wasnt all in because of Adora," Catra said the words aloud in her empty apartment, truly acknowledging them for the first time. Catra shook her head, turning

into her pillow. Catra couldnt get sucked back up in Adora, not after everything.

Catra picked up her phone again and started a web search for a divorce attorney.

Chapter End Notes

I know that I promised things would be less sad but also this breakup was a while coming and necessary. I thought Id been telegraphing some issues between Starla and Catra for a while now so I dont think this was totally out of the blue? Let me know what you think regarding the breakup and what this might mean for our girls.

This marks the halfway point at least in terms of chapters! I think the word count for the second half will be a bit higher so not a true midpoint but I think the breakup definitely marks a big shift in the story. We are officially diving into the second half of this folks!

As always comments and kudos are the lifeblood that inspires me to write. Hang out with me on Twitter.

Also, in case you missed it and follow my Superhero AU, I posted Catras origin story last week.

Next Week: Adora and Finn get more quality time as Adora worries about Catra. In the recent past, Adora stands up to Ms. Hope.

An Unanswered Phone

Chapter Summary

Adora and Finn go to the aquarium.

Adora draws some boundaries.

Catra picks up Finn.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora looked down at her phone after hanging up with Catra. She peered into the living room, where Finn was. They were packed and ready to go to Mama's, laying on the couch and reading patiently as they waited. Now Adora had to scramble to adjust her plans given that she was suddenly keeping her rambunctious eight-year-old for the weekend. It was unexpected, but she could adjust.

"Hey bud" She called as she walked over to them. Their head popped up off the couch as they eyed their mom.

"Yeah" They returned curiously , closing their book and settling it on their lap.

"Mama can't pick you up today . She had to do something and she thought it would be more fun if we stayed together and then you got to be with her later when she had more time. Alright" She smiled at Finn, sitting next to them as she

"When is mama going to get me" They asked. They didn't exactly look upset, more confused by it. Adora could relate to that.

"I'm not sure bud." She hedged, putting her hand on Finn's shoulder . "But she made sure to tell me that she loved you and she missed

you. She's sad she can't pick you up."

It wasn't a lie really, Catra knew that it was true as sure as she knew she felt the same thing when she was apart from Finn. They looked down at the carpet for a moment, shoulders slumped as they took in the news.

"Okay. Can I call mama later?" Finn's voice trembled a little and they set the book aside, placing it on the white couch. Adora pulled them close hugging them to her chest.

"Of course, you can always call mama the same way you can call me when you are with her," Adora confirmed. It wasn't odd for Finn to want a phone call with one of them while out with the other, although it was growing less frequent as they adjusted to the back and forth of living in two homes.

Their face seemed to clear with that assurance and they leaned in for a brief moment before they remembered that they were big and independent. They shook their little head and stood up, picking up their book as they did so.

"I'm going to play in the backyard then." They announced with their usual spunk. Adora the tension in her shoulders drop as Finn bounded towards the backdoor through the narrow hallway connecting the living room and yard.

She stayed seated for a moment before she too got and walked over to the kitchen, fiddling with her phone.

She had to move a few work calls, but ever since she'd become more available on the days she had Finn, she found it easier to ask for what she wanted and change her schedule. She picked up her phone and took a moment to call her assistant.

"Hey, Jewelstar? I'm sorry to bother you so late." Adora apologized pressing her lips together. She probably should have waited to call in the morning. Before she could continue Jewelstar interrupted her.

"Oh! Hey, boss is this pressing? I kind of have a family thing I'm taking care of." He sounded a bit strained and she could hear shuffling in the background.

"I have a family thing to take care of too, Jewel. I need you to push any phone calls I have for the weekend. It's no rush, but if you don't think you can take care of it tomorrow, I'll call someone else to coordinate it. Family comes first." She wasn't going to make her team work if she wasn't working.

"Yeah, I can take care of it tomorrow morning I'm just busy right now." He agreed readily, voice still strained. Adora furrowed her brow.

"Is everything alright?" Adora asked, concerned. She leaned against the counter as she listened intently.

"Yeah, my kid sister just needs me." He sighed and Adora could imagine him running his fingers through his light hair.

"Well, I hope she's okay." She offered, not quite sure what else to say.

"She will be. I'll get that taken care of for you later, alright? Bye, boss! Have a good night and see you tomorrow!" He rushed his words a bit clearly preoccupied.

"Bye Jewel." She heard Jewelstar hang up halfway through her goodbye. She bit her lip as she looked down at her phone. She shot him a quick text *If you need tomorrow off let me know it's no trouble.* A few hours later she received a reply: *No issues boss! See you tomorrow.*

Friday work went smoothly, and she picked up Finn, ready to tackle the weekend together. Thankfully, the only set plan she knew she couldn't cancel was Saturday brunch with Glimmer and Bow, who were always happy to have Finn join them.

She only got a raised eyebrow from Glimmer when she said she was keeping Finn this weekend, but she gave her a look that said the schedule change was not up for discussion. Adora had no idea why the schedule changed anyways, there was nothing to tell.

Adora worried about Catra. She never, not once, bailed on picking up Finn. If anything, she mentioned that if Adora was too busy at work, she wouldnt mind having more time with Finn.

She would tell me if there was something going on with her, right? Adora was racking her brain for reasons why Catra could have been crying that Thursday night. She was drawing a blank. *Goes to show what little Iknow about what' s happening in Catra's life.*

It was driving her crazy , not knowing. More than ever, she was sure that she wanted to befriend Catra again. She just needed to take it slow and be respectful. She could do this. *Baby steps.*

"Mom, mom, mom!Can we go to the aquarium today?I wanted mama to take me this weekend."Finn loved the aquarium, which was funny given their name.

"Yeah bud, we can go today, and you can ask your mama about going again some other time."Adora tried to smooth down the riotous blonde hair on their head but mostly failed.

Finn cheered and ran for the stairs to get ready. She would have to thank Catra's parents for getting the three of them annual passes. They beat the glut of people that showed up after lunch and took their usual route around exhibits.

"Look!Mom!"Finn pointed excitedly at the employee helping the kids pet the stingrays. Finn looked up at Adora, eyes shining as they practically bounce in place.

"What are you waiting for?Dont you have sea puppies to pet?" Adora teased, her eyes crinkling as she smile. Finn didnt bother responding, taking off to make the small line to touch the stingrays.

"It's great to see Finn at the aquarium." Adora looked up and recognized Netossa as one of the marine biologists who work for the aquarium and always helped answer Finn's questions.

"They really love it here. I'm glad to bring them when I have the time." She smiled at her acquaintance.

"I'm sure we can make a marine biologist out of them yet. I'm going to go talk and see if I can show them something new." Adora snorted crossing her arms across her chest.

"Good luck finding an inch of this place this kid doesn't know." She couldn't help the fond way she looked at Finn any more than she could help bragging about them.

"Oh, and tell your wife I say hi," Netossa said as an afterthought. She walked away before Adora could think of a response. To her horror, she felt tears well up in her eyes. She blinked them away quickly. Doing Finn's favorite family activities without Catra never failed to leave Adora feeling hollow, even if she did love spending time with her kid.

A trip to the aquarium was a resounding success in Finn's book if two things happened: they got to pet the stingrays and saw their aquarium buddy, an old nerd shark they dubbed Swift Wind. Finn swore he was the fastest shark in the tank although Adora could almost guarantee he was the slowest. They got lucky this trip and hit both of Finn's highlights, spotting Swift Wind languidly swimming across one of the aquarium tunnels.

After seeing the jellyfish exhibit for the third time, Adora was finally able to bribe Finn into leaving the aquarium with ice cream. *Maybe bribery isn't good parenting but a girl's got to do what a girl's got to do.*

They did a final lap around the main tank while they finished their cones and by the end, Finn was sleepy enough that they actually let

Adora carry them to the car. It'd been a long time since Finn let her carry them, they were old enough now that they got embarrassed.

Soon, they're going to be too big for me to carry like this, Adora thought sadly. She burrowed her face in her kid's hair as she walked to the car. They weren't particularly heavy, but their limbs hung awkwardly given how long they were. *I'm just going to have to train more at the gym to delay that as much as possible*.

She remembered how small Finn was as a two-year-old when they got adopted, all unruly blonde hair and bright blue eyes. She couldn't believe how big they'd gotten.

Finn nuzzled into Adora's arms, and she melted cradling them close to her chest. Although she was concerned about Catra, she was also glad she got to spend quality time with Finn.

Then

Adora loved the backyard in her house, especially now that Finn could use it to play. They were running carefree, setting up an imaginary game that Adora couldn't even begin to understand.

They were explaining something animatedly when her phone started ringing, the ringtone she programmed specifically for work calls. Finn's eyes turned sad. They stopped moving their arms and quieted down, their head tilting toward the phone. They let out a big sigh.

"I have to pick up and go with Auntie Glimmer and Uncle Bow." They sounded like they were reciting the words~~.~~ Adora's words. The forlorn look on Finn's face squeezed her heart to pieces.

"No, no, I'll take this call and that'll be that." Finn eyed her suspiciously, looking so much like Catra for a moment. "Go play, I promise we're staying here, okay?"

Finn nodded and slowly turned back to what they were doing, their playing more subdued. Adora picked up the phone and walked back onto the porch, out of hearing distance.

"Adora Grey speaking," Adora answered, already knowing who it would be.

"Adora, I need you to come in. Now." Ms. Hope's voice held no greeting and brokered no argument. She winced at the demanding tone and then Adora looked around at Finn trapezing in their backyard.

"It's Saturday and I'm taking care of my kid. I can't make it in today," Adora stated plainly, keeping her eyes on the one thing that mattered. She knew she sounded confident, but her hand trembled on her phone. "Whatever it is can wait till Monday. I'll take care of it then."

"It can't wait Adora. Arrange for childcare or bring your child with you, it's irrelevant to me. But we need to deal with this contract dispute now." Hope pushed back, her voice bordering on anger. Finn was still playing but she could see them looking at her from the corner of her eye.

"No. I know for a fact that the client doesn't have their board meeting until Tuesday, we have time to fix this on Monday. I won't go." Adora clenched her eyes shut, feeling her palms sweat. She wasn't going to lose sight of what really mattered. Not again.

"If you do this, I might not be able to recommend you for branch manager." The threat in Ms. Hope's voice was crystal clear. Adora pressed her lips together, holding back a whimper. She took a deep breath through her nose to compose herself.

"That's going to have to be okay because my kid comes first for me. If you think that makes me unqualified to be Bright Moon's branch manager, then so be it." She said resolutely. She could feel the blood rushing to her head.

"These attachments are only going to slow your success, Adora. I thought you were different. A career woman." The criticism would've made her crumble before, but the last few months had taught her that there were worse people to disappoint than Ms. Hope.

"Well, you thought wrong. Have a nice weekend." She hung up, praying that she wouldn't get a callback. When the phone didn't immediately ring, she let out a sigh of relief.

Finn eyed her as she got off the phone, evaluating their mom. Adora put the phone on silent and slid it into her back pocket. Finn lit up and ran at her.

"Mom, you have to learn the rules now! Don't worry I'll show you!" They launched into an animated explanation, waving their arms around as they ran and yelled instructions. Adora chased after them, not really paying attention to what she was meant to be doing.

Finn's smile was worth whatever backlash would come on Monday morning.

Now

Adora's phone rang as she hustled Finn into the house. Her heart all but stopped when she looked at the caller ID.

"Cat?" Adora tried to keep her nerves in check as she answered the phone.

"It's me." There was a stilted silence on the line. Catra's voice sounded tired, like she hadn't slept since they last spoke on Thursday. "Can I pick up Finn today?" She asked.

Adora breathed a sigh of relief, glad she would see Catra in a few hours. She knew it wasn't her place, but a part of her needed to see her with her own eyes, to make sure she was actually alright.

"Yes, they'll be thrilled to see you." Adora bit her lip, unsure if she gave too much away. There was that awkward silence again.

"Do you think I could keep them for the whole week? I've just missed so much time I—" Catra rambled nervously . Adora nodded even though Catra couldn't see it.

"Yeah of course, just let me pick them up for dinner a few nights or something, otherwise I'll miss them too much." She leaned against the kitchen counter. Maybe some of those dinners would include Catra, but she'd worry about that later .

"Oh. Okay . Great. Thank you, Adora." She could hear Catra' s relieved voice at the end of the line as she agreed to those terms. She could hear the low thrum of an engine in the background. "I'm actually a few minutes from your place, could I drop by now?" Catra's voice sounded hopeful.

Adora nodded even though she knew Catra couldn't see.

"You're always welcome here Cat. See you in a few ." She hung up quickly after that. She turned around to look at Finn sitting on the floor by the couch, entertaining themselves with their toys.

"Hey Finn, your mama is going to come to get you soon, why don't you get ready?" She suggested as she put her hands on her thighs, crouching over slightly to be closer to eye level with Finn.

"I already packed just in case." They jutted their chin out proudly a small smirk on their lips. Adora raised an eyebrow at the cocksure expression.

"Hmm. Even the reading assignment Ms. Juliet gave you on Friday?" She wondered aloud, giving Finn a significant look. Their eyes widened and they bolted up to their room to collect their missing things.

Adora barely had time to see their blonde head disappear through the door frame when the doorbell rang. She opened the door and Catra was leaning against the door frame. It would seem casual if it wasn't for the tense set of her shoulders. She was dressed down in a pair of gym shorts and a t-shirt, which was more Adora's go-to attire than Catra's. She spotted a stain on the shirt collar before she looked up to Catra's face.

"Hi Dor . Where's our kid?" Adora' s heart fluttered at the use of *our kid*. She cleared her throat which suddenly felt very dry and briefly pondered what normal people did to keep their hands busy.

"They forgot to pack something for a school project, so they're getting it together now." Catra rolled her eyes fondly , no doubt remembering the countless times Finn had forgotten something for school.

"How' s Starla doing?" Adora decided to make small talk. If she wanted to be friends with Catra she couldn't be overtly hostile to her girlfriend. She was A-okay with her wife having a girlfriend. Her friend-wife. Yep.

Catra made sudden eye contact with Adora, and she was surprised by the pained look there. Adora scratched at the back of her neck. *Was it something I said?*

"Ah, we aren't together anymore." Catra broke eye contact, wrapping an arm around herself—something she did when she needed comfort. She looked so very small. *Fuck, Adora, you're the worst at small talk.*

"What happened?" Adora her eyes widened as she took a step back. She couldn't believe what she was hearing. They looked so happy together the last time Adora saw them. Catra shrugged a shoulder looking anywhere but directly at her.

"Ultimately , Starla and I wanted different things." Catra gripped the tip of her pinky tightly in her other hand as she averted her gaze.

"She just saw it before I did."

Adora stared back at Catra, dumbstruck. If she had to guess, she would've thought Catra broke up with Starla. She couldn't imagine circumstances that would make someone voluntarily choose to leave Catra. *Although* she thought ruefully, *I guess in a way that's what I did. I pushed her away*.

Adora cleared her throat and her thoughts.

"Well, I'm sorry to hear that. From what I saw, she made you happy." *Maybe this had to do with why she couldn't pick up Finn?* She wasn't even happy at the news that Catra was single again because it clearly affected her negatively. *She must really love Starla.*

Catra looked at her like she wasn't sure what she should say. Adora clenched her fists. *Screw baby steps.* Catra needed comfort and Adora couldn't stop herself. The offer bubbled out of her then and there.

"Do you and Finn want to walk around the park for a bit before you go?" Catra looked up at Adora cautiously her teeth worrying her bottom lip.

"Is this about being friends?" She asked her tone probing, probably wondering if Adora was serious about wanting friendship or if she was trying to take advantage of a vulnerable moment. If this was a test, Adora would pass it. She never wanted to hurt Catra again.

"Yes. You look like you could use one." Adora offered with a smile. "It's just a walk around the park. The sun will do you some good."

Adora had taken many walks around that same park when they had recently broken up. It never helped with the crushing guilt and sadness in her gut but it made her feel just a little more functional. More human.

Catra eyed her for a long moment, the silence stretching between them until it felt as if all the air had been sucked out of the room. Right as Adora was about to cave, maybe take back her invitation since it was clearly too much, the silence broke in the worst way.

"I contacted a divorce attorney this week," Catra said abruptly. She looked surprised by her own words. Adora's heart seized in her chest—*you knew this was coming Adora you knew it was coming just* ~~sh~~she let out a soft exhale. "I think we need closure. To know what this" Catra gestured between them ~~"~~really is. I don't want there to be a misunderstanding between us."

Adora blinked rapidly, trying to cope with the bomb Catra threw at her feet.

"Alright. You hired a divorce attorney." Adora's voice sounded hollow to her own ears as she processed what Catra said. Silence hung thick between them again. "I ~~—~~guess I'll start looking for somebody too."

She didn't want a divorce but she couldn't keep Catra caged with her. That wasn't what she wanted either. Catra swayed side to side as if still nervous. Clear she had something else to say. Adora stared at her pressing her lips together. *What more can she possibly have to tell me?*

"Do you still want to be friends?" Catra's question was tentative, eyes downcast as if expecting Adora to turn her away. Adora took a moment to look away, the whiplash from the last few minutes becoming too much. After taking a few careful breaths she looked back at Catra looking vulnerable and soft, like one sharp word from Adora would break her.

Adora's heart thumped loudly in her ears as she stared at her wife. So Catra didn't want her romantically ~~that~~ that was nothing new. But Catra wanted Adora in her life. That had to count for something. She shook her head at the thought. Actually, that counted for everything.

Adora grabbed her hand, willing her to look up. Her eyes looked so beautiful in the dimming afternoon sun.

"Y es. You're my best friend Cat. Always."She said, her voice coming out clearer and stronger than it had this whole conversation. Adora knew that to be true since she was seven years old. Catra gave her an unsure smile, leading Adora to tug on her hand gently. "Now , do you want to go to the park?"

Catra looked away from Adora for a moment looking out the window to the balmy beginnings of summer.

"The park sounds really great right about now ."She replied as she took her hand back, clasping them together in front of her. Adora perked up, although she tried to be mindful of Catra's somber mood.

"Then let' s get Finn and get going, we're losing daylight."She teased, finding it easier than she thought to keep a smile on her face.

"Finn!How do you feel about the park?"Adora hollered up the stairs. A blonde head peeked down from the banister.

"A w yeah!This is the best day ever!"Finn ran down, taking a moment to place a kiss on Catra's cheek before running for their shoes.

Chapter End Notes

> So they're both going to have divorce attorneys, but hey , they're taking a walk in the park together so there's that? I think y'all can see where this is all going, can't you?More importantly , we saw Adora stand up to Hope and spend some time with Finn! IDK I think this chapter wasn't that angsty . Do y'all agree?
>
> I would have posted this earlier BUT I decided to add that scene at the beginning of Adora and Finn talking about Catra not picking her up. Felt like it was important to include Finn there.

As always, comments and kudos are my lifeblood. Also, hang out with me on Twitter.

Also, I have been VERY BUSY THIS WEEK! If you haven't seen them, I posted two responses to the SPOP Creative Flex Summer Pride prompts. If you are interested in some fluff (yes I wrote fluff, not angst in disguise, pinkie promise) and watching Adora be a whole dork, you can check out Spoonfuls of Sugar. If you want to read an Adora coming out snippet that also doubles as a sneak peek into one of my next multi-chapter fics, check out You Are Enough. Or you can check out both that is also cool!

Next Week: Scorpia helps Catra unpack all of the developments in her life. In the past, Scorpia picks up the pieces the night Catra leaves Adora.

A Tearful Tea

Chapter Summary

Scorpia asks some questions.

Catra leaves Adora.

Catra, Perfuma, and Scorpia have dinner together.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia gripped her chin in her hand, her index finger coming to rest close to her nose. Catra twitched in her seat, leaning backward as if that would protect her from the annoyance that rolled off Scorpia in waves.

"Okay , so within a week, you broke up with your girlfriend." Scorpia sounded as close to outraged as she'd ever heard her . They were hanging outside on the porch as the sun set, enjoying the nice outdoor weather. At least, until Scorpia got on this line of questioning.

"Starla dumped me." Catra corrected, sitting on one of her hands. Scorpia rolled her eyes as she leaned back in her patio chair.

"Okay , fine, fair. So, you the relationship ended, and around that time you started cuddling with your *estranged wife*?" Scorpia crossed her arms and turned her body to look at Catra more fully. Perfuma walked through the backdoor and froze, looking between the two friends. Catra mirrored Scorpia's position, teeth bared.

"W e did *not* cuddle! And my child was there!" Catra yelled indignantly, shoving a finger into Scorpia's space. Perfuma backed away slowly, putting one foot back into the house.

"I'll get started on some tea." She threw over her shoulder as she quickly closed the door. *Thanks, Emma, leave me to get crucified by your wife, I don't mind.* This was supposed to be a nice child-free dinner with her two favorite friends but instead, Scorpia was interrogating her.

"Okay wildcat then what happened. I'm confused. I've put a lot of energy into shunning Adora. We almost got into it in the locker room the other day you know?" She huffed chest heaving slightly as she raised a hand in confusion.

"You what? Almost fought Adora in a locker room?" She asked, puzzled. *You know, that sounds kind of hot*—"Never mind, never mind I don't want to know!" Catra took a deep breath.

"Nothing weird happened. Even before Starla and I broke up, Adora reached out about being on friendlier terms. When I picked up Finn that Sunday I stayed for a few hours and the three of us walked around the park near the house. Then I grabbed Finn and went to my apartment. The week before we watched a movie with our kid." She listed off, using her foot to rock her chair.

Catra stared down Scorpia for this part. "And most importantly, I did not cuddle or touch Adora Grey in any way. At all. Finn and a whole lot of space was between us the whole time. Both times we saw each other."

Scorpia still eyed her skeptically. "You and Adora don't need to touch each other to be inappropriate. Stars know I learned that lesson in college." She muttered the last part under her breath.

Catra was red to her hairline. She cannot believe the shit Scorpia was holding against her right now. *It was college!*

"What're you really concerned about big gal?" She asked softly, leaning sideways to get a closer look at her friend. She knew Scorpia was feeling something big. She usually tried to channel her inner Perfuma and was as non-judgmental as possible when listening to

Catra's problems. Scorpia sighed heavily running a hand through her hair.

"I just worry that you're going to get your heart broken all over again wildcat. The only people who saw you *that day* were Perfuma and me. Frankly, you were a mess." She said lowly , eyes filled with pity. Catra winced at that, looking out towards the back fence to avoid Scorpia's concerned stare. She really did owe them for taking her in at one of her lowest lows.

"We aren't getting back together Scorp. Adora made that very clear . Honestly, it was probably the best talk we have had since we separated." She rolled her eyes. "Which, you know , low bar, but still." Scorpia didn't say anything, just eyed her , so Catra continued. "I think we can be platonic friends. It' s been a year since we separated."

"You're sure about this?" Scorpia questions. "I mean, you know I'll support you no matter what Cat."

"Look, I won't pretend that I don't miss Adora as a wife, but I miss Adora as a friend too. Adora was honest about how she wanted to be just friends. I think it' s a good thing for us." She says resolutely .

She's had some time to think of it and Catra's come around to the idea of being friends with Adora. Adora was right when she said that she and Catra had so much more than just romance between them ~~it was~~ a lifetime of friendship, love, connection. Family . Adora was her family long before she was ever her wife. She could walk the line and get the best of both worlds: have Adora's friendship and protect her own heart.

"She's my family Scorp. Her and Finn. That's what I miss the most." She admitted aloud as she held her friend's eyes. Scorpia nodded, patting Catra's knee.

She then pressed her lips together and cleared her throat, thinking of her words. She didn't seem fully convinced but moved on. "What'd

you tell Finn? They must have thought it was weird right?" She asked, voice softer now. Finn was over the moon watching a movie with both his moms for the first time in a year.

"Finn was fine. We asked them if they wanted to do some things together the three of us and explained that it didn't mean we were getting back together." She explained, looking down at her hands in her lap. Catra worried about what a change in dynamic would imply to Finn, but it was something they could monitor.

"The three of you just had family time and everything was fine?" Scorpia almost seemed to be saying it to herself. Catra looked away, eyes caught on the blooms Perfuma had resting along the edges of the porch.

"I mean yeah. We just sat and existed near each other. And the week after, at the park, we just walked around and watched Finn. It was nice. I missed doing things together as a family." It felt a bit weak to admit, but she knew she could be vulnerable with Scorpia. Scorpia's eyes softened at that.

There was one moment she omitted from her retelling. At the park when Finn ran after a ball that they threw way too far, Adora looked at her intensely, blue eyes boring into her split ones.

"Cat, Starla doesn't know what she's missing out on." Her smile turned awkward and sad. *"Trust me, I'd know."*

Catra felt her chest tighten at the words, beholden to Adora's electric stare. Then Finn burst back between their mothers, ball in hand, and the moment was long gone.

"What about Starla?" Scorpia questioned tentatively. Catra blinked lost in her own thoughts for a moment.

"What *about* Starla? She dumped me. She wanted to get serious and felt that I wasn't ready to do that. Didn't really ask me for my

input on the matter."She shrugged. *Mostly because she was right on all counts.*

Scorpia harrumphed.

"How do you feel about it wildcat?"Scorpia searched for words gazing out at the fruit trees lining the side of the yard. "What I mean to say is you dont seem all that torn up about it."

Catra rolled her eyes, putting her head in her hand as she picked out the words that could describe her feelings.

"It' s been over two weeks Scorp, Ive done some processing since then. I cried like a baby the night she broke up with me. I care for her. But I wasnt in love with Starla. I mostly feel guilty that I hurt such a great girl."Catra sighed. "I tried so hard to be upfront, but it blew up in my face anyway."

She did miss Star, but it was like missing a close friend, not a piece of herself. She still caught herself almost sharing pictures or memes or texting her about her day . A part of her could feel the hole Starla left behind but it was a manageable thing. She knew it would close with time. Scorpia hummed her acknowledgment, pressing her lips together.

"That makes sense, I could tell she was way more interested in you than you were in her."Scorpia squinted her eyes as she thought something through. "Also, you two were too similar . Same likes, interests, it was a little too matchy-matchy to be compatible long term, I think."

Catras eyes widened as an indignant sound sprung from her throat.

"Why didnt you say anything before? If you didnt think it would work out that's the kind of thing Id like to know ."She said crossly , eyeing her friend.

"It's your first girlfriend after you separated Catra I wasn't going to bash her! Besides, it was fine, sometimes those things work out. It wasn't anything deal-breaking." She explained with a shrug.

Catra remembered that Glimmer had told her upfront she didn't think Starla and her would last. Maybe she saw the same things Scorpia did. She wondered if she ruined what could have been a great friendship by pursuing something more.

"Do you think it would be a dick move to try to be friends with Starla?" Catra asked. Scorpia would be honest with her .

"I don't know! I think you should give her some space and maybe reach out in a few months, to see how you both feel. One or both of you might end up deciding friendship just doesn't feel right." She pointed out. Catra nodded along getting out of her chair. She took a moment to stretch her legs, stiff from sitting for so long.

"That's a good point. I wasn't planning on reaching out soon. I don't want to upset her." Scorpia snorted as she also got up.

"You sound like you broke up with her wildcat, relax." She slammed her hand on Catra's shoulder as she laughed. Catra rolled her eyes. *This is what I get for trying to be considerate.*

"Speaking of people who you *have* broken up with-" *damn, what a segue Scorp* "-what's next with Adora?" Scorpia looked concerned again. They both stepped inside the house, standing in the living room.

"I mean, we're hanging out sometimes with Finn. I think we're trying to just stay amicable and see how it goes. I'm not expecting much more than that." She chewed on her bottom lip, looking at the couch where she bawled her eyes out almost a year ago. *I don't think I could take the disappointment of being let down by Adora again.*

Then

Her arms shook as she tried to steady the steering wheel. She willed the tears not to fall while speeding towards Scorpia and Perfuma's house. The road signs were blurred by her tears but she knew the way by heart. *Iprobably shouldn't be driving at all, this is a terrible idea.*

Leaving was a terrible idea. She left her heart with Adora, on the floor of their bedroom floor, waiting for Adora to stomp on it while pacing on that stupid work call. She snapped during that fight. She was beyond angry and done with being ignored but now the gravity of what she did was starting to sink in like poison in a well.

She got to her friends' house in record time, knocking on the front door and hoping they weren't too busy to deal with Catra' s mess of a life. Her hands still shook at her side, her whole body racked with sobs. She felt like shit dragging them into this, but she didn't know who else to turn to.

Scorpia opened her door and Catra saw her eyes morph from confused and sleepy to alarmed, taking in Catra's sobbing, shaking, frame and her suitcase propped up on the door.

"Scorp- do you think it'd be okay if I stayed here tonight?" She spoke in starts and stops. It was hard to breathe, let alone talk. Scorpia wrapped her in a quick hug. It only made Catra sob harder , leaning against her best friend as she finally let go.

"Of course wildcat, come on in," Scorpia called for Perfuma as she grabbed Catra's bag and carted her inside. Perfuma didn't question why Catra was there just took one look at her and got her teapot going.

Twenty minutes later, she was wrapped in three blankets with vegetarian stir fry on a plate in front of her and a huge mug of tea. She finally stopped crying enough that she could speak in complete sentences.

Scorpia looked at her like she was a wounded animal. Maybe that was what she was.

"Catra want to tell us why you came here? Not that we don't love having you here we're just—she shared a look with Perfuma "—concerned."

Catra sniffled, trying to find the will to say the words. Once she said them it would be real. Stars, what did she just *do*?

"I left Adora. And I don't think I'm going back." Scorpia and Perfuma both looked shocked. She got that. Everyone saw Adora and her as this perfect couple, childhood friends to college sweethearts, now married and co-parenting. *If only it were that idyllic.*

"What happened Catra?" Perfuma used her most gentle voice, which was saying something. It all started spilling out of her.

"She doesn't love me anymore. She's been standing me up on dates for weeks. Every time I try to reach out to connect with her, it's like she isn't even there." She took a long sip from her tea mug, trying to regain some composure. "She doesn't listen to me, she straight up lied to people at her job about what I do because apparently being a tattoo artist isn't enough or whatever." She felt the tears well up in her eyes again. "I'm tired of being constantly rejected by my own wife."

Scorpia and Perfuma stared at Catra, mouth agape.

"What did Adora have to say about all of that?" Scorpia asked softly. Catra snorted derisively, anger flooding her gut.

"I don't know. I told her I was leaving, but she was too busy answering an *all-important* work call to even care. She didn't even try to stop me, Scorp." Catra's voice trembled with tears, this time unable to keep them from spilling over. *And the waterworks are back*.

Scorpia pulled her into a hug and Perfuma regarded her with warm comforting eyes. She felt like a baby being swaddled under all the blankets.

"I'm sorry this is happening Catra. You're an amazing woman. It's brave of you to demand more from your partner, especially when you have a long history together. You deserve to be loved openly and freely." Perfuma squeezed her shoulder and left to start putting away things in the kitchen.

"Wildcat, I'm sorry I don't know you were going through all of this. I feel like such a terrible friend." She whispered into Catra's shoulder. Scorpia still hadn't let go of Catra.

"Oh big gal, you're the very best of my friends. You couldn't have known because I didn't want anyone to know. I wasn't ready to talk about it." Catra took a deep breath. "It's a lot of pressure. She and I ~~we~~'ve always been in each other's lives. She was always the one constant I could rely on. We promised we'd always have each other."

"You didn't have any obligation to tell anyone, but I'm glad that you are coming to us for help now." Scorpia added letting Catra go. She sunk into the couch, feeling like she'd run a marathon.

"Thank you for taking me in. I honestly didn't plan to leave tonight. I just wanted to talk to her. But she kept shutting me down, like what I was saying didn't even matter." Catra would never forget the frustrated look on Adora's face as she kept looking back at her phone, not bothering to give Catra her full attention. "It just clicked in my head at that point. I can't make her prioritize me and I deserve better."

It was clear that Adora didn't feel the way she used to. Instead of being honest about it she just avoided her, like a coward. It would be just like Adora to avoid talking about her feelings once they were gone, thinking that it would somehow hurt Catra less. Catra knew what Adora's love felt like and it wasn't whatever was happening now.

"Hey , wildcat maybe it isn't so dire. She could come over tomorrow and you guys can talk things out. Okay?" Scorpia gave her a hopeful look. "For now , let's get you settled in the guest room and tomorrow we'll have a big breakfast. You can stay here as long as you need."

Scorpia really was the greatest friend. She set her up with a bed and a few missing toiletries Catra forgot in her packing haze.

Catra tossed and turned for hours in the unfamiliar bed. As she was finally falling asleep, she saw her phone light up. It was a string of text messages from Adora:

At least let me know if you're okay . Or where you even are.

Please come home soon so we can talk.

Goodnight Cat.

No missed calls. Adora hadn't even tried. Catra's eyes immediately welled up again. She wasn't okay and she didn't feel like she would be ever again.

Now

All of Perfuma and Scorpia's house is cozy , but their small dining room is one of Catra's favorites. The table was just big enough to share a meal comfortably but not so large as to feel distant from the person you're breaking bread with. Besides, Catra's always happy to get a first-row seat when Perfuma was cooking.

"Fuma I don't know what you're doing with these potatoes but they taste absolutely magical." Catra speared another fingerling potato and popped it into her mouth. It tasted of parsley and parmesan with a crisp edge and fluffy center. The trio had finally gotten around to sitting for dinner once Perfuma saw that they'd come inside and moved on to more lighthearted conversation.

"Thank you Catra that' s very kind of you to say."She seemed happy with the compliment, piling a few more potatoes onto Catra's plate.

"She' s right honey, you always make the best, most nutritious meals."Scorpia fawned over Perfuma. Perfuma blushed, hiding her smile behind her hand as she stared at her wife.

"How is Flora doing? Where is she?"Catra asked after her favorite niece.

"Oh, I ran into Adora at the grocery store last week and she of fered to take her on a play date with Finn. I think she and Finn are having a movie marathon today."Perfuma supplied. Scorpia immediately scowled at the mention of Adora. Catra rolled her eyes.

"W ell, Im glad Finn and Flora are hanging out. I think it' s been a few weeks since I brought them here."Catra mentioned, looking pointedly across the table at Scorpia. She didnt like this weird unfriendly dynamic between Adora and Scorpia.

Perfuma seemed to dislike it just as much. "I am too! Given that you and Adora are trying to be amicable, I thought it was a good idea to do the same."Perfuma sent her own heavy look at Scorpia. She looked down to the table, refusing to meet her wife's gaze. The silence grew a bit tense.

"I've hired a divorce attorney ."The words slipped out of Catra' s mouth without permission. She hadnt told anyone but Adora that yet. Scorpia's eyes snapped up to Catra.

"Oh Cat, that' s so big."She sighed as she placed a consoling hand on her forearm. She sent her friend a small smile gently pulling her arm from Scorpia's grip.

"I realized that I do need the closure. Especially if Adora and I are going to try to be friends, I need to know thats all itll be."Catra said staunchly. She'd thought it through before she brought it up to Adora. Ultimately, there was no point sitting around and staying married if

the best they could hope for was friendship. Lonnie was right, a piece of her was holding on to that piece of paper because she was too afraid and frankly too in love to let go. That needed to change.

Scorpia nodded her understanding, serving herself a few more vegetables as she spoke. "Well, I'm not sure if being friends with Adora is the best thing for you but I'm happy that you are moving forward with the divorce process. I know that has to be hard. Have you told Adora?" Scorpia asked curiously , spearing asparagus on her fork.

"Yeah, I implied we couldn't really be friends otherwise. She understood." Adora's eyes looked sad momentarily, but she seemed mostly unaffected. Catra thought her heart might beat out of her chest when she said the words divorce attorney aloud.

"Okay , okay. Look I'm sorry I've been difficult. I promise." Scorpia turned to Perfuma "to both of you that I won't be as antagonistic as I've been. I know it's not a good thing for anyone and I'm not trying to make your life harder wildcat."

Catra nodded. "It's okay Scorp. Honestly, I'm a little surprised, you're usually so easygoing. I didn't know you felt like this about Adora." She said concerned. She knew Scorpia and Adora were friends and gym pals. She wasn't trying to make Scorpia choose between them and she hadn't realized how much she resented Adora.

"I don't do well with anger when someone hurts my friends," Scorpia admitted sheepishly, rubbing the back of her neck. Perfuma pressed a kiss to the shaved side of Scorpia's head.

"And we love that about you darling, but healing is the priority , and we need to give Catra space to do that." Perfuma smiled indulgently as she picked up some of the plates. "I'm going to bring desert you two sit tight."

Catra nodded along, smiling as Perfuma explained her expansion plan for the teashop while she ate her lemon meringue pie. She

wondered if this was what healing felt like.

Chapter End Notes

If you have a uterus in the U.S. Im so fucking sorry. Im exhausted and sending love to anyone else whose having a tough time.

This gave us a nice look into where Catra's head is at and some Scorpia bonding/shit-talking time. I tried to draw a balance between her being upset at Adora and still keeping Catra's best interest at heart. Also for me, I think THIS might be the saddest flashback in the whole fic. Let me know what y'all think!

The next chapter is what I consider the LEAST angsty/pining/sad chapter. Good things are coming (at least in this fictional universe lol).

As always kudos and comments make me very happy and I appreciate every single last one of them. Also, come hang out with me on Twitter.

Next week: Catra and Adora hang out with their friends at a barbeque. In the past, Scorpia asks Catra out on a date.

An Olive Branch

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra go to a barbeqe.

Scorpia asks Catra out.

Adora gets a jb of fer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora shouldve known this couldnt go smoothly . She was having lunch with Glimmer and Bow at their favorite diner when she broke the news. The couple was sitting across from her in their usual booth while they all ate and chatted.

"Oh!By the way , you guys can invite Catra to the summer barbeqe party, it wont be an issue if were both there."Adora kept her voice casual, hoping to sweep that under the radar. She brought her sandwich up to her face and took a big bite.

Suddenly, all the cutlery stopped moving and Bow and Glimmer stared at her. She gave them a weak smile around her mouthful of food, slowly returning her sandwich to its plate.

"Adora. After over a year of ensuring you and Catra didnt coincide at *any* social events, youre going to nonchalantly inform us that we can invite Catra over for the summer barbeqe?What' s wrong with you woman!?"Glimmer looked like she could spit fire. *Iprobably should've thought this out more. Or at all. Oops.*

Bow, ever the peacemaker, interrupted by putting his hand on Glimmer's.

"What Glimmer is *trying* to say is that it seems like a sudden change. That's all." Bow sent his wife a look. "So, do you want to tell us what is going on with you Adora?" Now Bow sent her a look as he crossed his arms over his chest. *Great.*

"Alright, so I spoke with Catra and I told her that I think we should try to be friends again. We've hung out a few times with Finn and we thought it'd be a good idea to hang out with our friends together too." She smiled timidly. She waited for a reaction and was not disappointed.

"Adora. Did you *friend zone your wife*?" Glimmer said with her palms flat on the table, aghast. Adora shook her head vigorously as she got more ketchup for her fries.

"No, no! Look Glim, Catra doesn't want to see me romantically anymore and I've accepted that. What I won't accept is not having her in my life at all if she's willing to be friends." Adora sputtered at Glimmer's accusation. Bow nodded along cutting into his chicken once again. *At least someone gets it.*

"Wait, did Catra say those words to you? That she wasn't in love with you anymore?" Bow asked carefully, leaning forward as far as he could with the number of plates sitting between them.

Adora thinks back to the last conversation she had with Catra about their tentative friendship. They discussed whether they should both come to the barbeque. Catra asked Adora multiple questions about how they were going to clarify to everyone ~~es~~pecially Finn ~~th~~at they were only friends.

"She didn't exactly say those words, but I know her. It was heavily implied. She made sure I knew that friendship was the only thing on the table with her." Glimmer looked like she was going to strangle her. Before Glimmer could make good on the threat of murder gleaming in her eyes Adora spoke up. "Besides, she was definitely in love with Starla. Might still be in love with her. She was heartbroken when they broke up."

"You know what? I give up. I don't know how Catra feels so I'm not going to meddle." Glimmer sighed, throwing her hands up in surrender. Bow let out a relieved huff of breath.

"Are *you* okay with being only friends with Catra?" He pipped in with a concerned look in his eyes.

"I mean so far so good? I feel a lot better than when we're estranged." She nodded her head and bit a fry. Although Catra didn't love her anymore, at least now she had hope that they could be friends again. Maybe even good friends.

Glimmer glared at Adora.

"Have you discussed actually moving forward with the divorce then?" Adora looked down. That word, *divorce*, rolled around in her head and made her stomach heavy.

"We did. Catra contacted a divorce attorney. Apparently, I should be expecting some paperwork soon." Adora smiled helplessly. Glimmer and Bow look at each other, some silent communication passing between them.

"Oh Dor. How are you feeling?" Glimmer's voice softened with pity and knowledge. She couldn't really take that right now. Things were better she didn't want to be brought down by thinking of the inevitable.

"Glim I can't~~-she~~ left me, I'm doing the best that I can right now." She gave the evasive nonanswer as she looked down at her plate. A sad tomato slid out of her sandwich. It felt fitting.

"You need to do your best to move on Adora." Glimmer stated seriously, arms crossed over her chest. "It's your life! Catra had a serious relationship, she permanently moved out, and she—apparently~~-m~~ade clear to you that she doesn't love you anymore, right? You have to move forward."

Bow interrupted.

"Glimmer! It' s none of our business." He is staring at Glimmer , saying something else with his eyes probably that Adora was too broken or fragile to hear the things she already knew in her heart. Adora pressed her lip together.

"No Bow , Im tired of everyone walking around on eggshells with Adora and Catra when they're being even more useless than in college!" Glimmer let out a frustrated groan. "Adora deserves to be happy."

Adora had enough of this. She cleared her throat. Both of her friends freeze for a moment, looking almost embarrassed at how they were arguing in front of her.

"I understand that because you're all our friends you've been affected by our relationship, but getting a divorce is up to the two of us and" she swallowed around the lump in her throat "if it were up to me, it wouldn't be happening." She finished in a whisper . "I need to deal with things the way I know how."

Glimmer's eyes softened again and she sneaked a glance back at Bow.

"Dor"…

"I'm okay with being Catra' s friend, I swear I am. Ill sign those papers when I get them." Adora stared down Glimmer , who had the decency to look ashamed.

"I'm only mad because I care Adora. About both of you." Glimmer ran a rough hand through her short bob, it looked like she might pull out her own hair.

"Y ou can be confused all you want Glim. Catra and I are the only ones who need to know where we stand with each other." She

reminded. Everything that needed to be said had been said. Some things just weren't worth bringing up.

Bow broke in, desperately trying to change the subject before Adora and Glimmer got into it further.

"So we can expect both you and Catra at the summer barbeque?" He asked as he fidgeted with her napkin.

Adora flashed Bow a smile.

"I wouldn't miss it. Can't speak to whether Catra will be going but last time we talked she said she wanted to come if it was okay with you." Bow nodded, wrapping a careful arm around Glimmer who seemed to deflate a bit at his touch. The rest of lunch went without a hitch and Adora honestly didn't think much about it afterward.

The morning of the summer barbeque, Adora realized she hadn't thought this through. At this point, she was having trouble convincing herself she had thoughts in her brain at all when she dumbly agreed to go.

She hadn't seen Catra outside of a few hangouts with Finn. The last few weeks had been great, so much better than the last few years had been. She wouldn't say they were close, but they were getting along.

When Adora suggested they both go to the summer barbeque, she thought it'd be good to just see all their friends at once, rip the band-aid off, if you will. Catra agreed.

However, Adora forgot a critical component of a barbeque at Glimmer and Bow's house: there was a pool, which meant swimwear. Now, she had to find a way to survive multiple hours around Catra while wearing a bikini. In front of all their friends. Adora was way too gay for this.

She arrived early because Finn wanted extra time in the pool. She also might have wanted time to prepare—or panic, whatever the case may be. She helped Bow set up and start the grill, and then she got in the pool with Finn.

Adora and Finn roughhoused in the pool, making the whole backyard a splash zone. Many of Adora's friends trickled in and she'd step out of the water to greet them, keeping a sharp eye on Finn while she did so.

They were at it for about an hour when Finn darted out of the pool yelling.

"Mama!" Adora turned around and she swore she felt her heart stop. Her mouth went dry, and she was very wet everywhere else.

Catra was catching their wet kid in her arms, but she must have come from the outdoor bathroom because she was already in her bathing suit. It was a red one Adora had gotten her as a gift for a family beach trip a few years ago.

It was her favorite of Catra's because even though the top was a halter style it had a boob window, and the bottoms made her ass look—*deep breaths Adora deep breaths you cannot think about this right now.*

She swam to the deep end and came back up to breathe facing away from Catra but she could feel Catra's stare on her back. Drowning was a better alternative at this point.

She heard a snort coming from right next to her and she glanced up, startled. Glimmer, who seemed to teleport into the deep end, was next to her .

"I can see being friends is going so *well,* Adora." Glimmer 's sarcasm and accompanying smirk were particularly grating at the moment. Adora sent a vicious glare at Glimmer.

"It is! I just need to .collect myself." She struggled to find the words. Glimmer guffaws at that, her laugh so loud everyone at the party could hear including Catra. Adora could not be redder .

"Well, when you're done *collecting yourself* you might want to go say hi. You know, since you are friends and all that." Glimmer teased, resting her arms spread out of the pool's edge.

Adora glanced back to where Catra had her full attention focused on an exuberant Finn. Catra made eye contact and shot her a questioning look, her brow furrowed in concern. *Right. That's right. They're friends, and friends say hi to each other.* Adora knew that. She could do that.

Before parting Glimmer whispers at Adora. "I mean, no shame girl, I've always thought Catra's fine as hell." Back to glaring at Glimmer it is.

Adora swam back to the shallow end, intent on greeting Catra. She was a few feet away from her when she had a horrifying realization. *How am I supposed to say hi? A handshake's too formal. A hug would probably be too much! Maybe a wave?* — Time was up, she was standing in front of Catra in all her glory.

Adora got an idea. She went in for the hug, and Catra's eyes widened in surprise. But instead of hugging her, Adora threw her over her shoulder and tossed her into the pool, a classic Adora move if there ever was one. She'd spent her whole life rough housing Catra into the pool. Finn laughed, delighted, as Catra sputtered and glared at Adora.

"You really don't change, do you? Can't trust you anywhere near a pool!" Although the words could have been mean they were too fond for Adora to feel anything but warm. Adora shrugged.

"I saw an opportunity and I took it. I won't apologize Cat." Catra rolled her eyes and started swimming, calling Finn over to play with her.

"Somethings truly never change. Do they , Adora?" Glimmer looked at Adora like the cat that ate the canary. Adora glared at Glimmer.

"Shut up." She grumbled, splashing at her .

"Hi, Adora." Perfuma waved serenely at her . Beside her, her hulking wife glared at Adora. Flora dove headfirst into the water to be with Finn, and Catra by extension.

"Hi, Perfuma. Lovely to see you." She then turned to look past Perfuma. "Scorpia." She acknowledged gruf fly. Perfuma sent a sharp glare at Scorpia and dug her elbow into her side.

"Hi, Adora. Can we talk for a moment?" Scorpia asked, her face dropping from her previous glare. Adora eyed her up and down, wondering what her deal was.

"Sure." They both walked towards the fence, away from the other guests. Adora could feel Catra's eyes on them as they walked by the pool.

"Look, I wanted to clear the air and apologize for my attitude. I know you and Catra are trying to be friends again and I dont want to make things more difficult for her." Scorpia crossed her arms staring down at Adora. "But I want to be clear . If you want to be a part of her life, it cant be so that you can treat her like you did when you were together."

The well of guilt that permanently lived in Adora's gut ballooned up, filling the back of her throat.

"Scorpia, you were right with what you said at the gym. I havent taken responsibility for how things ended between Catra and me. I am now." She of fered earnestly. "I want to be something positive in her life, not a source of pain. If being friends doesnt make her happier then Ill take a step back, no question."

Scorpia continued to stare at Adora, searching for something. Suddenly, Adora felt herself being lifted off the ground into a massive hug. She wrapped her arms around Scorpia trying not to wheeze.

"You know, I did miss you while this whole thing has been going on." Scorpia laughs wetly.

"Me too. Friends again?" Adora ventured, smiling at the woman she had been at odds with for the better part of the year.

"Yeah. Sounds good." They walked back and Adora playfully shoved Scorpia's shoulder when she went back to where Perfuma was now speaking with Bow. Adora made her way to the pool where Catra was still watching the children.

"Have you swallowed any pool water looking after these two?" Adora asked as she lowered herself into the water.

"No, they know better than to splash me. Unlike some people." She added dryly. Catra's hair had started to dry from when Adora tossed her into the pool, the ends curlier than before. "What was that with Scorpia?" She asked curiously .

"Your bodyguard just wanted to chat, make sure I was on the up and up." Adora teased. Catra' s eyebrows jumped to her hairline.

"I didn't ask her to." Her face was the picture of concern. Adora waved her off.

"No, no it was good we're on the same page." Adora looked at Catra, suddenly realizing that she might not know that she and Scorpia hadn't been on the best terms. "Um, we hadn't really talked in a while, so we were fixing that."

Catra stared at her for a moment. Adora felt naked. Like Catra could see through her. She wrapped an arm around herself and smiled tentatively. Catra seemed to give herself a short nod and smiled back, finding whatever she was looking for it seemed.

"That' s good. Do you want to figure out some food for us and the two kids?" She asked expectantly .

"Y eah, Ill see what' s happening on the grill and get back to you." She shot Catra finger guns which automatically made her roll her eyes.

"Thanks Dor ."

"Always Cat." The words came easy . Adora walked away towards the barbeque, but not before she glanced back at Catra, Finn, and Flora in the water.

Then

Catra looked like a vision sitting amongst the stacks of books. Adora was so focused on Catra that she didnt notice the broad-shouldered girl sitting across from her.

"Hey , wildcat!" Adora felt rather than heard the silence that came after that sentence. Scorpia, one of the friends Catra made this semester, smiled a little too widely as she looked at Catra. "So. I was wondering if you would go out. With me heh."

All of Adoras body tightened. She felt like she couldnt breathe waiting for Catra's answer. She regretted trying to catch Catra in the library today. She leaned her head against the library shelf she was hiding behind. To her horror, Catra let out a small hum of approval.

"Y eah, sure Scorp. Where do you want to go?" Catra barely sounded surprised by the question, readily accepting Scorpia' s invitation.

"Oh, I hadnt thought that far ahead! Ill let you know." Scorpia bounced on her heels, her voice a touch too loud for the library. Catra smiled at her.

"Sounds good." She agreed, her eyes following Scorpia as the girl stood up and slung her bag over her shoulder.

"Okay well, I have to go but Ill tex t you." Scorpia stammered out, her smile never fading. Adora watched Scorpia walk away floating as if she could walk on water.

The moment Scorpia was out of sight, Adora quietly dropped into the seat nex t to Catra, startling her . Catra accidentally launched a pen at Adora, which she caught easily. She grinned for a moment at her show of athleticism as she twirled the pen between her fingers.

"Oh sorry , I thought you heard me." Adora couldnt stop herself from asking. "So, you're going on a date with Scorpia?"

"Oh, you heard that? How long were you standing there, creep?" Catra raised an eyebrow and leaned forward, whispering the words. Adora grunted as she pulled a book out of her bag.

"It was accidental! Y ou mentioned you'd be in the library , and I wanted to study too so I thought we could study together." She said shyly, looking up at her best friend. Catra meanwhile, was looking at her like she was stupid.

"Dor we have no classes together ." Catra enunciated slowly as if Adora wouldnt understand the words otherwise. Adora rolled her eyes, reaching forward to drop Catra's pen on her notebook.

"Stop being purposefully dif ficult. You know what I mean, studying in the same space." Breathing the same air . Maybe looking at each other occasionally? Anything would be better than nothing. The truth was Adora was missing Catra like a mad woman, they hadnt had a chance to hang out alone in at least two weeks.

"Alright, then let' s study." Catra turned the page on her tex t book, seemingly absorbed once again. Adora reached her hand out and grabbed Catra.

"Not so fast. What about Scorpia?" She insisted, hoping it wouldn't be too obvious. She knew Catra wasn't hers to be jealous of but she was her friend. She could be curious right? Right. Catra shrugged but left her hand in Adora's.

"Eh, It's just a date, no need to get so weird about it." She said nonchalantly like she went out on dates all the time. It made Adora pause. Had Catra been on dates? It had only been two weeks since they saw each other? Surely she would have said something to Adora? She fumbled for a moment before coming up with a response.

"Well I mean, I want to support you. You know, you might need help picking what to wear or something." Adora immediately regretted the offer. There was no way she actually wanted to help Catra get ready for a date with another girl. Catra snorted turning to face Adora more fully. She still had Adora's hand in hers.

"Yeah Adora, when I need help picking out a sports bra and compression shorts, Ill be sure to call you." Her voice dripping with sarcasm. Adora turned red, chagrined at the rather apt assessment. "Scorpia is a nice girl, she's clearly into me, and she asked to spend time together. I've never really been on a date with a woman before and I want to do it." Catra explained matter of factly.

Adora deflated a little at that.

"Yeah, that makes total sense. I'm happy for you Cat." She wanted to be happy for Catra. She'd always support her, she just needed to choke down the knot in her throat. Catra leaned forward her gaze suddenly searing into Adora. She wasn't quite sure if she could breathe any longer with Catra's split eyes boring into her.

"Is there any reason you can think of that I shouldn't be going on this date, Adora?" Catra's tone was loaded but Adora had no clue with what. Catra squeezed her hand tightly, the only point of contact between them. Adora shook her head immediately.

"No! Scorpia is a great girl. W e lift together all the time at the gym, and she's really kind and sweet. Im sure shell show you a good time." All of that was true. The only reasons Adora could think of for Catra to decline a date with Scorpia were selfish. She buried the jealousy she felt. Catra dropped her hand. It felt cold.

Catra reached for her phone, whatever message she received made her smirk.

"She just texted me, that she made reservations to a restaurant. Y ou know the seafood spot a few blocks away from here?"

"Y ou love seafood, that's a good pick." Catra hummed noncommittally, turning back to her books.

Adora pulled out her own books, trying her best to not think about how much she longed to be the one to take Catra out somewhere.

Now

"That' s a nice tan you have there." That was the greeting Adora received from the Eternia Industries' vice-president. He sat at his office chair, making no move to stand to greet her. Adora floundered near the chair across from him, unsure what the meeting was about. She didnt want to pull a chair in case she overstayed her welcome.

"Thanks, I was spending quality time with my family this weekend." Spending time at the barbeque with Finn, Catra, and the rest of their friends was easily the highlight of the summer so far.

"Ah very nice. W ell, I want to get to the point." He cleared his throat and waved for her to sit. She did so. "Adora, we're really impressed with what you have done in your role as a senior manager. We would like to extend you an of fer to be the Bright Moon branch manager."

Adora was sat across from him mouth agape. She knew it was a prestigious position, far beyond what she had now as a senior

manager. She also knew that the current branch manager had a 24/7 on-call commitment as well as an expanded income and prestige.

"I'm surprised. I didn't think that I was still up for the position." Adora tried to keep the shock out of her voice but it was impossible for it to not filter through.

In the last year, she really took a back seat to spend more time with Finn. She wasn't working even close to the number of hours she was putting in before.

"It's true your hours are down, but your team productivity has blown through the roof!" He exclaimed with a smile.

"I've been delegating more. They're great employees I can't take credit for that." When Adora took a step back from work she realized that once she stopped hovering over them her team was competent. She didn't have to be over their shoulder for them to do a good job.

"Well, that's what a good branch manager would say. You don't have to answer now, just think about it. I really think being branch manager will propel you and the Bright Moon office to center stage in the company." The vice-president gave her what he thought was a winning smile and waved his arm, a clear dismissal if there ever was one.

This is what you've been working towards for the last two years Adora. It's within striking distance. She would think about it later though, she had actual work to do today.

Adora checked on how her team was doing and troubleshot a few problems and before she knew it, it was the afternoon already. She felt her phone buzz and saw a text from Catra:

Is it cool if I swing by with Finn for a few hours? Finn misses their mom and guitar.

Adora knew that there was no way Finn missed her, she saw them last night and they were an independent kid. Finn recently started guitar lessons so missing their guitar seemed the more likely of the two.

Did that mean Catra missed her? Or was Finn just wanting to practice and Catra didn't want to hurt their feelings? She stopped thinking about Catra missing her before she gave herself heart palpitations.

She texted back: *Finn is always welcome, same as Finn's mama.* Adora hoped it wasn't too much.

The reply was almost instant. *Okay, Finn and I will be there around three.*

Shit. It was close to two. She buzzed her assistant.

"Hey Jewelstar, sorry to bother you, but what do I have on my calendar for the rest of the day?" She asked quickly, leg bouncing beneath her office desk.

"No bother boss! You have a meeting with Kyle and Frosta to go over the monthly numbers at four." He replied easily. Adora cursed internally.

"Can you reach out to them and get them to email me the report instead? Cancel the meeting." *Those report meetings can always be emails*, she reasoned. "Also, if we have control of the meeting time, schedule most meetings before three."

Finn gets out of school around that time anyway, I should try to be more available in the afternoons.

"You got it! Anything else I can do for you?" Jewelstar was easygoing and incredibly competent. Adora loved having him as an assistant.

"No, I'm good. I'll be heading of f soon, if you aren't working on anything pressing feel free to take the rest of the day!"

"Sweet! I was planning on going to see my sisters today , so I'll let them know I'm swinging by early . What are you up to boss?" Jewelstar was also a bit of a gossip. *Well, no one can be perfect, I guess.*

"Nothing, just spending some time with my kid. Have a great rest of your day."

She made it home ten minutes before three. She pulled out the takeout menus she kept at home in case Catra and Finn hadn't eaten lunch. She heard the knock on the door and went to get it. *Would it be too much if Cat had a key to the house? I mean it would just be a convenience thing . it would probably be too much.*

Finn scampered in and made a beeline for their guitar, completely ignoring Adora. She rolled her eyes.

"W ell, good afternoon to you too." She said to the place Finn had stood in moments before. "I can tell they were really missing me." Adora teased, looking up at Catra. SHe smiled easily at Adora taking a step closer than she usually did, before rethinking it and taking a step back.

"I mean, I couldn't very well tell you that we've both been replaced by a guitar. Felt like a face-to-face conversation you know?" Catra shrugged and smirked. Adora rolled her eyes again.

They ended up listening to Finn play for an hour which was a labor of love because *jeez Finn cannot play at all.* It had only been a week of lessons and Finn was musically inclined. Adora had faith it would get better. *hopefully soon.*

Finn then insisted they watch a new movie that was streaming and Adora ordered takeout. It was a nice way to spend the afternoon. At

some point, Finn moved to lay on the floor leaving her and Catra sitting on the couch.

They would occasionally volley comments back and forth about the movie until Finn got upset that they were interrupting. Then they started whispering.

Adora was about to whisper what she thought was a *hilarious* comment about the protagonist's hair when she looked down. Catra had fallen asleep on her shoulder. She could feel her warmth through the fabric of her shirt. Stars, she missed her wife.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, this time for SURE it wasn't sad or angsty, right? RIGHT? This is the longest chapter to date and I think we saw some important developments. Please let me know what you think!

Fun fact: the OG flashback for this chapter was a college flashback of Adora losing her mind at putting sunscreen on Catra but my beta reader shamed me for making it too horny, so it got cut from this story lol. I don't regret it because I think this scene was more meaningful but I was still sad to see it go lol.

If you didn't see it yesterday I posted this one shot for the #BFSatPride challenge. I think it might resonate with some of y'all so feel free to check it out!

As always, kudos and comments make me the happiest little clam in the sea! Also follow me on Twitter for more updates and things.

Next week: Catra has lunch with her mom and in the past, Catra comes out to Adora.

A Warm Invitation

Chapter Summary

Catra and her mom go to lunch.

Catra comes out.

Catra gets invited out again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The summer barbeque opened the flood gates. Besides Adora being a total weirdo by throwing her in the pool, everything felt normal. *I mean let's be honest, Adora being a weirdo is also pretty normal.*

They both took care of Finn, chatted with their mutual friends, and Adora grabbed her a burger when she was getting her and Finn's food. After that successful outing, suddenly, their friends had no qualms about inviting Catra and Adora to the same things, so their social life synchronized again.

Honestly, even while living in separate places, Catra had seen Adora more often in the last two months than in the last six leading up to their separation. Playdates with Finn, "Best Friend Squad" board game nights, movie watch parties, restaurant outings, karaoke bar shenanigans, the list never stopped growing. It was an endless barrage of events where Catra couldn't help but notice Adora.

Adora was present, not checking her work email, laughing at Catra's jokes, dishing back at Catra, listening intently about Catra' s work, playing with Finn, *flexing* . It was all a reminder of how their marriage had been *before* when they were both friends and lovers.

This would only happen to me. *It's ridiculous,* she thought. When she left Adora she was sure about getting divorced. Suddenly, the emotional connection she was missing~~the~~ thing that drove her to separate from her wife~~was~~ available again, but only in the context of friendship. Adora cared but only as a friend. Most of the time, this was fine. But sometimes~~she~~ she saw Adora walking toward her with a big grin on her face and Catra simply *wanted*.

She tried to not think about it too deeply because overall, her life was a lot better than before they separated. Adora was present in her life and in Finn's. The time they spent together with Finn was so much better now, but it did have a downside. Now, she felt even more lonely when she was in her apartment without Finn.

It's one of the reasons why she jumped at the opportunity to have lunch with her mom this weekend, meeting at a restaurant halfway between Bright Moon and Thaymor. It was a bit of a drive, but mom time was worth it.

Catrina arrived ten minutes late, strolling in as if she was early. *Typical, mom can never be on time.* She gave her mom a kiss on the cheek. Her mother sat down, removing her sunglasses and placing them on top of her head. She looks Catra up and down, blue eyes shining with mirth.

"*Mija*, you don't call your mother, you don't visit! How is my precious baby girl doing?" The words sounded rough around the edges, but her mom's smile softened them into a lighthearted tease.

"*Mami, todo está bien*. I am literally visiting you right now." She rolled her eyes. "Also, I haven't been a baby girl in like twenty years." She pointed out, not for the first time and likely not for the last.

Her mom rolled her eyes.

"No, we met halfway this isn't a visit! And you'll always be my baby girl, Catra. Deal with it." She picked up the menu, eyeing Catra over the top of it. She looked like she might burst. "*So.* I saw those

pictures with your woman on Instagram. Did you finally fix things with Adora?" She blurted out the question with deep excitement practically bouncing in her seat.

"Mama! No, what're you talking about?" Catra shrieked, *what pictures?*

"Look here." Her mom pulled up her phone showing her the incriminating photo. It was on Glimmer's account—*of course, it's sparkles*. She didn't even question when her mom became mutuals with Glimmer, that was just her way.

It was a picture from the barbeque. There was nothing remarkable about it at first. It was a candid, Adora standing off to the side—*looking damn fine in her tight shorts*—grabbing a burger off the grill and minding Finn who'd been glued to their mom's side. Catra was on the other side of the barbeque.

She remembered that moment. Catra joked about making sure Adora didn't char their burgers—well mostly a joke, Adora wasn't the best cook. It was a running gag between them for most of their lives.

The camera caught Adora sending her an overly fond look, while Catra stared back at Adora like she hung the moon. *Caught on camera and posted on Instagram. She was doomed.*

"I'm your mother Catra, I know what you look like smitten, especially with Adora. Seeing as I had a front-row seat to both of you two cluelessly dancing around each other for most of your lives." Catra groaned, hiding behind her own menu. "I remember when you asked me if it was okay to have a wife, like Adora, instead of a husband when you fought with that one boy over lunch. I knew that it would be a love match then and there." She smirked.

Catra made a sound of deep disapproval. "I was nine and I didn't know I was gay, that's ridiculous mama." Still, she felt a tug at her heart. It was the same story she told at their wedding. "Mama I am not smitten, Adora and I are trying to be friends again."

Catra's mother raised her eyebrow and shook her phone in Catra's face, the message obvious. *Touché mom.*

"Okay , maybe I like the woman I married. But mama, Adora doesn't want to be together like that and what we have right now is good." She explained. The waiter dropped a serving of guacamole and chips. Catra lunged for the distraction.

Her mom scoffed, she was unmoved by the appetizer .

"Catra, *mija* , you left Adora ~~not~~ the other way around. Undo it if you want to be with her." She said it the same way she told Catra to pick up her laundry when she was in high school.

"It' s not that simple, you can't just go back mom." Catra sighed, exasperated. What would her mother know about this? Her mom and dad never fought.

"Well, obviously don't go back, you were miserable before. Move forward *mija* ." She eyed Catra again with a look that could only be described as pity. "*Tu sigues suspirando por ella, corazón.* "

Catra's heart panged at the overly romantic notion. She battled with her own lungs to avoid proving her mother's point.

"Even if you were right ~~which~~ I'm not saying that I want to move forward or whatever ~~Adora~~ doesn't want that." She said softly . Her mom raised both eyebrows as she grabbed a chip.

"You're trying to tell me Adora Grey , who asked me for my blessing to marry you when she was twenty-one, *three years before she proposed*, doesn't want to work on your marriage? When she stares at you like *that* still?" The incredulity was rolling off of her in waves. "Don't forget I've known Adora since she was barely a foot off the ground."

She shook her head at her mother's theatrics. "It' s just a picture mom. She told me that we weren't getting back together ." Adora

communicated what she wanted, she wasn't going to second guess it just because everyone else didn't understand. "We've even talked to divorce attorneys. *El divorcio anda en pie mami*."

"*Ay Dios mio santo, ayúdame con estas niñas.*" Her mom looked up to the heavens as if she expected immediate intervention. Catra rolled her eyes at her mother's dramatic pleas. "I'll believe it when you sign the papers, not a second before. There has never been a divorce in this family and I doubt you and Adora will be the first."

"Look, I came here to have a great time with my mom, not to get hassled by her. *Estas clara mama*?" She could feel her hands clenched into fists on the table, she noticed her mom looking at them. She waved her hand in surrender.

"Yes, yes, let's have a nice lunch I'm sorry. I know you've been having a hard time I'm not trying to be difficult." She offered. It meant a lot, her mom liked being purposefully difficult.

"Great. Now how is Papi and give me a run down on what my cousins are doing?" Catra's mom launched into a detailed recounting of what their family members were up to. They didn't talk about Adora for the rest of lunch.

Then

When Catra watched Adora eat, she wasn't quite sure why she liked her. Adora was chewing on too big of a bite, her cheeks full in a way that reminded her of a squirrel.

"Do you ever think about boys?" She blurted out. Catra watched as Adora choked on her sandwich, crumbs flying out of her mouth. *What a dummy.* Just shy of her sixteenth birthday, Catra had heard all the girls in her year tittering and gossiping about which were the cutest boys. All the girls except her and Adora.

Catra knew why *she* wasn't interested in talking about the boys in her class. She'd gone on exactly one date with a boy, Rogelio. He was nice enough if a little quiet. The date felt mostly like a friend hangout, so Catra figured it was fine.

At the end of the date, Rogelio kissed her and the only thing that flashed through her mind was Adora's blue eyes and how she wished she was kissing her best friend instead. So that was that.

Since that date a few months ago, Catra wanted to tell Adora what she figured out about herself, but she worried that Adora would realize that Catra had a crush on her. *It's like something out of a dumb romance book, falling for your best friend. Ugh, gross.*

"What do you mean Cat?" Adora had finally managed to choke down the bite she had in her mouth.

"You know! Like, do you think about boys romantically? Or like which ones I guess?" Catra asked uncertainly as she bit her lip. *Can you tell I have a crush on you, so you don't talk to me about the guys you like?*

Adora looked nervous as hell, glancing around the diner. "Um, I don't have any crushes on boys. Right now. Yeah. You know, I'm pretty busy with school and volleyball. Heh." She gripped the back of her neck, a strand of hair falling out of her ponytail as she did so. Stars, she looked so beautiful.

A Catra took a deep breath. She had to be brave. "I've never liked a boy before." She started cautiously, her tongue heavy in her mouth.

She tensed waiting for Adora's reaction. Adora didn't seem to pick up on what Catra meant, furrowing her brow in confusion.

"Huh, that's weird I thought you liked Rogelio." Adora was twisting her napkin tightly between them, fraying the edges. Catra grabbed her hand to stop her. They were soft and warm.

Catra needed another approach.

"I went on one date with Rogelio, but I didn't like him. I realized I only like girls." Adora looked like a deer caught in headlights. Suddenly, Catra became even more nervous. *What if Adora thinks being gay is weird?* She hadn't even thought of it as a possibility till that moment and she felt stupid for not preparing for that. Adora's eyes are opened impossibly wide, a deep blue framed by fluttering eyelashes. Catra tried to pull her hand back but Adora stopped her gripping it tightly within her own.

"Oh Cat. Thank you for telling me. You know I support you no matter who you love." Her voice was deep and sure, her smile blinding. Catra nodded but snorted internally. *I don't think you would if you knew I loved you.*

Adora glanced around again and leaned forward. They were still holding hands and Catra's burned where she was touching Adora.

"Cat, me too." Catra's eyes widened worried she had said that aloud.

"You too, what?" *Your hand also feels like it's on fire and you feel your heart flip flopping in your chest?*

"Um I'm gay. I was meaning to tell you, but I was just worried about how you would feel about it." She explained, relief clear in her eyes. Catra understood now why Adora looked like that earlier. She felt so caught off guard, she hadn't considered that Adora could be gay too. "I mean, I'm not trying to steal your thunder or anything! I'm sorry I probably should've waited, this moment should be about you"— Catra smiled softly, this time she gripped Adora's hand.

"It's okay dummy. It's good to know that we won't have to talk about dumb boys together." Catra joked, trying to move the conversation along. Catra avoided the question she most wanted to ask. *Do you think about me the way I think about you?*

Now

As she was getting back into town, she got a call from Adora. It wasn't too strange anymore for that to happen, so she answered without a second thought.

"Hey Dor , am I still good to pick up Finn at four?" Catra asked.

"W ow, I see how it is. No Hey Adora, how're you doing? Did you have a good morning? How have you been coping alone with the gremlin that is our child?" Catra snorted. The ribbing that would've been unimaginable just two months ago was commonplace now .

"Our child is not a gremlin and if they *were* a gremlin they'd get it from you. Now, what do you want? Or you just calling to bother me?" Catra sassed back.

"Y ou know I lo like bothering you. One of my favorite pastimes. Yep. But no, I'm calling because I was thinking it would be a nice day to go out to one of the lakes nearby for a picnic. Finn and I were wondering if you'd like to come?" Her voice was overly hopeful, cautious ex citement tinging every word.

Catra was weak for that phrase. *Finn and I* There wasn't much she wouldn't do for Finn and Adora.

"Sure! I just got back from lunch with my mom, I didn't have much planned before picking up the tyke anyways." She tried to downplay it, but she missed them terribly the last few days.

"Ex cellent! W ell, come by as soon as you can so Finn can get time to run around so they hopefully fall right to sleep when you take them home." *My apartment's not home.* The thought was a knee jerk reaction that Catra promptly ignores.

"As soon as you can? So *demanding* Adora." She'd meant it as a playful tease, but Catra couldn't help how her voice dipped down low and turned it into a *playful tease*. She heard Adora's breath hitch.

Suddenly, the call was tense and Catra remembered that things were not how they used to be.

"I just meant you should come soon if possible. I mean Finn! really wants you to come with us." The silence is stilted and awful for a moment.

"Yeah, Ill be there. Ill see you in a few." Catra said softly before hanging up quickly. Her cheeks burned with embarrassment.

An hour later, the three of them were outside by one of the smaller Bright Moon lakes, Finn running around trying to find the biggest tree to climb. Catra would probably have to climb up after them to get them down later.

God, it looked so much like that stupid lake Adora took her to after prom. Catra had thought about how much she loved Adora that night she was afraid Adora could somehow tell. She wondered if Adora had thought about that when she invited her to join. She wondered if she thought about prom night at all anymore.

"I think we should let Finn tire themselves out some before we eat. If we time it right, we can eat while watching the sunset so we can enjoy the view and still be able to see what we are eating." Adora was beaming at her, using the voice she always did when she carefully planned a date. It made her heart beat into her sternum.

"Sure, that sounds good." She agreed readily.

"How's your mom doing? And your dad?" Adora asked, genuine curiosity and sadness mixing in her gaze. Catra looked down, picking at an imaginary frayed thread on the picnic blanket.

"They're good, enjoying retirement to the fullest. They've been doing some traveling. Mom had a blast at lunch." She rolled her eyes performatively.

"I've no doubt she had a good time at lunch with her baby girl." Adora teased, eyes lit as Catra let out a genuine groan at the nickname. "Good for them, they deserve to travel. I miss them." The sentence ended in a shameful whisper, Adora's head hanging.

"They miss you too Dor ." She supplied. She leaned back, using her hands to support her weight as she surveyed the lake for a moment.

Adora shook her head disbelievingly. "I doubt that. They must hate me." She whispered looking down at one of her hands, clenching it, and opening it in quick succession.

"I doubt my parents could hate you." Catra tried to catch Adora's gaze but she wouldn't budge.

Adora had been part of their home, their family, for way longer than when they decided to get married. Her mom still kept all of Adora's school photos since first grade and when her dad talks about their childhood stories, people often ask him what it was like raising three girls.

"They have plenty of reason to hate me." Adora stared of f into the distance, face solemn and sad. "I hurt you. If someone hurt Finn the way I hurt you, I'd hate them." It was a vicious whisper , echoing anger whether at some imagined partner for Finn or herself, who could say.

"Y ou know it's not that simple." Catra wasn't quite sure if she was talking about them as a couple or Adora's relationship with her parents anymore. All of it was messy with no straightforward answer. "I think they're mostly hurt you haven't gone to visit them in Thaymor."

"I can barely make myself take the trip there to drop of f Finn at Mara's. Every time I go it somehow feels worse than the last." She finally looked at Catra. "Last time I barely made it to Mara's before I had a panic attack." She confided. She stretched out, mirroring

Catra's position, leaning back and propping her hands to support her, their pinkies almost touching.

"I know how hard it is for you to visit. And they know too." She assured. Adora's relationship with Thaymor would always be complicated. "I've forgiven you, and if they are mad about something they'd forgive you too."

Adora looked like a deer caught in headlights.

"You've forgiven me?" She said dumbly. Catra stared back, feeling caught by her own words. She hadn't thought about it when she said it but it was true. She was still hurt over everything that happened between them, but Adora apologized and changed her behavior. The anger and indignation she felt froze over, leaving a quiet sadness in its place. She'd never be happy that their marriage hadn't worked out but she accepted it.

"Yeah. I guess I have." She politely looked away when she noticed the tears welling in Adora's eyes. She cleared her throat. "If you miss my parents, I know mom wouldn't mind getting a phone call from you." She offered.

Adora gave her a tight smile, fake as plastic.

"I'll think about it." Catra could tell by the way Adora said it that she would not be thinking about it at all. "Thanks, Cat." The two words were loaded with emotion.

"For what? I haven't done anything." She looked down, hoping that Adora would just let the previous topic of conversation go. She took the hint.

"For being you." She said it so simply like Catra was some kind of gift. She could feel the warmth radiating off of Adora's hand so close to her. She'd do anything to reach out and touch it, comfort her, show her how grateful she felt to still have this part of her. *That's probably too much.* Her hand didn't move.

"You're such an idiot."She laughed. The words come unbidden through Catra's lips. Adora let out a bright loud laugh in response that took up all the space outside.

For a moment she expected Adora to answer with *Im your idiot* like she usually did when Catra called her names but of course, that couldn't happen anymore. Instead, she leaned back and shook her head while rolling her eyes.

"Yeah, I am."She said simply . For moments they stared at each other until Adora cleared her throat. "Did you see how ridiculously long Finn's summer reading list is? How are we going to make them do it all?"

Cara groaned but was internally thankful to move on to less heavy things.

"Ugh, I know! I think this kid will read more books than me by the time they get to middle school."She complained.

They kept talking, occasionally one of them would go chase after Finn, making them giggle as they tried to evade whichever of their parents was trying to get them. It took a double team to get Finn to settle onto the blanket and eat.

Catra eyed the picnic basket with interest.

"So how much of this is actually edible?"Adora huffed, slowly pulling out the food from the basket.

"All of it!"Adora announced, offended by the insinuation. Catra raised an eyebrow. "I mean, probably most of it."Adora amended. "It's just sandwiches and cut-up fruit, hard to mess up."

"You know what, fair point."She shook her head. They ate in relative silence, listening to Finn tell them about the things they saw and did while running around the lake.

The lake looked gorgeous with the sun setting behind it, the sky turning purple and red in some spots. A late sunset picnic was exactly the kind of activity she should be avoiding if she had any hopes of making this friendship work without becoming a pining mess. And yet, here she was.

As predicted, Finn tuckered themselves out and was fast asleep for the drive back home to Adora's house. Catra took the opportunity to address the elephant in the room.

"Hey , Im sorry about making our phone call earlier weird. I didnt mean anything by it, I was just caught up talking with you. I didnt mean to make you feel uncomfortable."Adora looked at Catra briefly before staring out at the road again.

"Its fine, you didnt do anything wrong Cat. We're readjusting our boundaries, it's normal for us to maybe say or do something that the other thinks might be too much."Adora tossed her a heart-stopping smile. She reached out and her fingertips brushed against the back of Catra's hands for a moment. "I for one, think we've been doing a great job at being friends again."

Catra would agree if it werent for the way her heart fluttered at Adora's smile. She needed to get a grip on how she felt about Adora before it ruined everything.

Chapter End Notes

Spanish translation time!
Mija: contraction of "my daughter ,"usually used as an affectionate nickname.
Mami, todo está bien: mom everything is fine
Tu sigues suspirando por ella, corazón: direct translation is "You still sigh for her, heart"it's basically a phrase that indicates longing and pining (imagine staring at a pretty girl across the class and sighing, that's the vibe).
El divorcio anda en pie mami: basically means the divorce is still on mom.

Ay Diosito santo, ayúdame con estas niñas: classic hispanic mom banger meaning "oh god please help me with these girls." Estas clara mama?: do you understand/are we clear mom?

So this is now officially the longest fic I've posted and we are just shy of the 50k mark! I know that isn't particularly long but I do feel proud of it. I'm pretty confident this will cross the 75k mark before it's all said and done. I think we are definitely in the home stretch now, only 7 chapters left :D

This chapter actually didn't exist in the first draft it was one of the added ones but it has grown on me and now I think it might be one of my favorites from this fic. Let me know what y'all think.

Kudos and comments keep me warm at night so I appreciate them!

Next week: Adora and Glimmer have a chat about Adora's potential promotion. In the past, college Adora and Catra FINALLY get together .

If you missed it, I posted a fluffy 5 + 1 two days ago. If you are interested in a slice of life fic where Adora is building legos and Catra constantly blue screens while staring at Adora's muscles Cherished is for you lol. There was no prompt for that one but it was based on someone (multiple someones tbh) giving me an idea on Twitter so follow me there if you'd like to yell fic ideas at me lol.

A Changed P iority

Chapter Summary

Adora and Glimmer talk about work.

Adora and Catra get together.

Adora and Catra hang out on their own.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora picked up the phone without looking at who was calling her.

"Adora Gray speaking." She muttered absentmindedly , burrowing further into the couch as she stretch out the blanket. She'd been about ready to take a nap and almost didn't answer her phone at all.

"What're you doing right now?" Glimmer asked, sounding exhausted on the line. Adora hummed.

"Currently? Nothing. I'm at home and kid-free at the moment." She explained, holding the phone to her head by hiking up her shoulder . Adora thought about going to the gym, but she was plenty sore from her workout yesterday and didn't want to injure herself. A nap sounded like a better use of her time anyway.

She was using the opportunity to relax but the house felt particularly empty without Finn and Catra there. It always felt worse the first few hours after they left, like Adora could still pick up the sound of their laughs or see them chatting away happily if she just turned her head fast enough.

"I was hoping you would say that—I am right around the corner . If I don't stay out of the of fice today, I will murder my mother." She

huffed, Adora could hear the sound that she assumed was Glimmer thumping her steering wheel.

"Keep your eyes on the road. And dont hurt Angella she' s a sweetheart."She admonished. Glimmer scof fed and Adora startled when she heard breaks screeching.

"Y eah, to you Adora. She's always being mean to me."She complained. "She doesnt take me seriously . She just constantly fusses over me."

"Y ou know Glim, some people would love to have a mother fussing over them."Adora gently reminded.

Glimmer pulled in a sharp breath through her teeth. "Sorry , sorry not how I meant it. I know you know, but Im sorry . Open the door Im in the driveway."She commanded. Adora could hear Glimmer 's engine cut off as she pushed herself off the couch.

"W ell, hello there stranger."Adora greeted as she opened the door .

"Might as well be, I feel like I never see you anymore now that you and the baby mama have whatever weird dynamic this is."Glimmer teased, walking and making herself at home sitting on the countertop.

"She' s not my baby mama."Adora sputtered, feeling her ears redden.

"Isnt she? Pretty sure she' s the mother of your child. Sounds like a baby mama in my book."Glimmer 's voice was innocent but the smirk on her face is anything but.

"How about we talk about something that isnt Catra,"Adora suggested, taking a seat on the bar stool next to Glimmer .

"Sure, what else is going on in your life then?"Glimmer still sat on the counter, full attention on Adora.

Adora bit her lip hesitating. "I turned down the branch manager position." She finally shared.

Glimmer gaped at Adora. "What? I didn't even know they of fered it to you!" She sputtered. "When did this happen?"

"A week or two ago. I was really surprised they of fered after I had that tiff with the current branch manager about spending time with Finn. I was pretty sure I was done for." She still hadn't fully wrapped her mind around it.

"I can't believe it. You're really serious about taking a step back from work." Glimmer's voice shook with awe as she looked down at Adora. Adora felt uncomfortable under her gaze, looking away and grabbing a pear that was sitting in her fruit basket.

"I mean yeah, we'd talked about it before. I told you I was going to spend more time at home." She mumbled, rolling the pear in her palm.

"Sure, you said that, but you'd been working towards branch manager basically since you were an intern! I didn't think you'd actually do something like this." She reached out and grabbed one of Adora's hands, squeezing it. "This is good." She breathed.

"I wasn't sure about turning it down. I thought about it seriously for a week." She explained haltingly. "I won't say it was easy to say no because it wasn't. But I don't regret it. I considered all that I was going to have to give up and it isn't worth it."

Glimmer beamed at her, eyes warm. "I'm proud of you Adora. I know how hard it is for you to prioritize yourself and your home life when you've given up so much to succeed in your field." The words make Adora relax. It felt nice for someone to acknowledge how difficult it was to say no at work, although she wasn't doing it for the recognition.

She was doing it for herself.

She sighed, eyes a bit distant as she thought about her career. She'd had a lot to think about since getting the job offer. "You know, I wanted to be branch manager for so long because it felt like it would unlock so many doors for my family. I could send Finn to a private school more likely to respect their pronouns, summer camp, family vacations." She let go of both the pear and Glimmer's hand, putting her palms on her forehead.

"You know, you're worth more than what you give Adora. Finn loves you because you're their mom, not because you buy them things." Glimmer moved her hand to pat Adora's shoulder.

"I know, I just didn't want Finn to struggle like I did. It was hard growing up knowing that there were things that would always be out of reach because of money." Never mind all the other bullshit Weaver saddled her with. "But I realize now that what I want to give Finn are my time and attention. Help them with their homework, talk to them, and take them out to do fun things. I've never felt closer with Finn." She couldn't help the smile that crossed their face.

"Aww, that's so cute Dor. I love that you feel that way with Finn." Glimmer cooed, the look on her face seeming to be one that belongs to her husband.

She bit her lip as she looked up at Glimmer. She'd been honest so far, it wouldn't hurt to go a step further.

"Saying no to the job, it wasn't just about Finn. I wanted to give Catra everything. We dreamed about what our future would be like for so long. It felt like we were finally living it, but there was always more I could give her." She admitted. "I lost sight of what was important when I laser-focused on this position. I wanted to prove that I was good enough, that I wasn't a disappointment." She laughed ruefully. "Instead, I ended up disappointing the most important people in my life because of it."

"Are you doing this to get back with Catra?" Glimmer asked cautiously. Adora smiled sadly, shaking her head.

"No. That ship has sailed Glim. She doesn't love me anymore." Glimmer opened her mouth, clear about to contradict her and Adora pressed a hand flat on the countertop. "Nope, I don't want to hear it. We talked with our big girl words, and she basically told me she wanted a divorce when we rekindled our friendship. That doesn't sound like something someone who is in love says does it?"

Glimmer deflated at that. "Okay no. But still, the chemistry between you two is like back when you were actually married and happy. That kind of thing can't possibly be one-sided."She pointed out.

Glimmer wasn't *wrong* really. There were times when she was suddenly inches away from grabbing Catra's hand or kissing her forehead and she didn't know how they managed to get so close so fast. But more than the comfort of physical proximity , they were of one mind. Countless times Catra would finish her sentence or send her a look over everyone's head, speaking a language Adora feared had been lost to time. She shook her head, refusing to dwell on it.

"Glim, I'm not going to get my hopes up for something that isn't going to happen. I turned down the job because I want to have more time with Finn and all my friends. That includes Catra."She set her jaw and started rolling the fruit under her palm again.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Yeah, sure, lump Catra in with the rest of us as if you haven't been seeing her three times as much as you see us."She accused lightheartedly .

"I want to be around Finn as his mom and Catra as a friend. Also, whenever you and Bow have your baby they're going to be spoiled rotten by their Aunt Adora."She grinned. Glimmer lit up at the thought.

The conversation veered towards Bow and Glimmer's road to parenthood, although Adora's thoughts never strayed far from how much she wished things could be different with Catra.

Then

"Adora, I need to talk to you." Catra waited for Adora to be alone in her dorm room and ambushed her. She'd never seen Catra look so serious. Adora started wringing her hands together. "I know you're planning on getting serious with Huntara soon"—

Adora laughed and Catra narrowed her gaze, lips pressed together.

Adora quickly cleared up the misunderstanding. "Oh no Cat, we broke up like last week." Humor still reverberated in Adora's voice. Huntara was nice and all, but she wanted way more commitment than Adora could offer—at least more than she could offer someone who wasn't Catra. It was one of the reasons she hadn't gotten around to telling Catra that they broke up. Her best friend's eyes widen, her normally tan skin going pale.

"But Glimmer said that you were thinking of moving in with Huntara for junior year." She sputtered. Catra grabbed her own arm and rubbed up and down, looking as if she was caving in on herself. Adora guessed she felt vulnerable, probably because she thought Adora changed their dorm plans last minute.

"Um, I have *no* idea where she got that from, but the thought never crossed my mind." She rushed to reassure Catra. "We finally get to be roommates this year, why would I let that go?" She asked incredulously.

Why would I ever want any distance between us Cat? Adora reached out and lightly punched Catra's arm. "Besides, Glimmer knows Huntara and I broke up. I mean we only dated for like two months Cat, it was never serious." Adora rolled her eyes playfully.

Some understanding seemed to flash in Catra's. "Fucking sparkles, always meddling in shit that has nothing to do with her," Catra mumbled under her breath.

Adora was more confused than ever. They figured out that they were still rooming together for junior year , what all was she missing? She took a step closer trying to catch Catra's gaze. She seemed to read the question in Adora's eyes.

Catra squared her shoulders, looking at Adora head-on.

"You know what, fuck it all." She almost sounded angry as she bit out, "Adora, I've been in love with you since high school. I mean, probably my whole life if I'm honest." Catra's words were sure although they had a nervous edge to them. She stood there staring at Adora expectantly , but Adora didn't understand.

"Uh you-what?" Adora could barely get any words out around the shock. Adora was dreaming. She was sure of it. There was simply no way this was happening right now. Sure she'd dreamed of a day when Catra would return her feelings but it was always that~~a~~ pipe dream.

Catra wilted the longer Adora fumbled looking for a way to respond to her best friend.

"I understand if it makes you uncomfortable or if you need space or whatever, just let me know so I can move in with someone else for next year if that's what you want. I'll stay with Scorpia until then." Catra moved to leave but Adora grabbed her hand, desperate for her to stay.

"No Cat don't go. I don't need space." Adora pulled Catra closer . "I just need you," Adora whispered as her hand trembled in Catra's. If Catra was brave, Adora could be brave too. "I love you Cat, for as long as I can remember." She admitted, finally getting it right.

"Wait-what? You love me?" Catra looked dumbfounded. Adora smiled at her best friend.

"I thought I was being pretty obvious." Adora snorted.

"Clearly not! I had no idea I" Catra cut herself off, looking at Adora with an almost feral look in her eye. Suddenly, she knocked Adora over barreling into her. With a loud groan, she landed on her back. Now, Catra was straddling her and she had her hands full of Catra.

"*Say it again,*" Catra demanded, eyes glued to Adora's face. She knew there was a command somewhere in there but her brain couldn't process it. Adora was about to swallow her own tongue. *I will not look down at Catra's boobs I will not look down at Catra's-* Catra was smirking at her. *Shit.* She looked Catra in the eyes this time. She remembered what she was supposed to say.

"I love you. So much Catra." She confessed again, this time filled with relief. "I always have."

Then Catra kissed her, and it was so different from what she'd dreamed about. It felt like coming home after an exhausting day, like taking a nap after swimming at the beach, like watching the stars on the back of an old pickup truck. It was natural and easy, like she was always meant to kiss Catra this way.

They parted softly Catra staying close, her body pressed into Adora's. "Wow," Adora breathed.

Catra rolled her eyes, but she couldn't stop the small smile playing at the edge of her lips. "Don't ruin it, dummy."

Adora then flipped them over so that Catra was the one on the ground, peppering her face with kisses as Catra giggled. She nosed under her chin, cuddling close and breathing Catra in.

"So, do you still want to move in with your girlfriend next year?" Adora said, feeling cheeky. Her whole body felt like a live wire, thrumming with energy.

"Girlfriend huh?" Catra raised an eyebrow while squeezing the leg she hooked around Adora's waist. Adora was nervous all over again.

I mean—shouldn't have assumed but I thought"—She mumbled from on top of Catra.

Catra shushed her with a kiss. That was *never* going to get old.

"Shut up dummy . Of course, I'm your girlfriend."Catra stated as a matter of fact as if she knew it would work out between them all along. Adora was going to combust from sheer joy . "And of course, we're moving in together next year . We've already wasted enough time."

Silently, she disagreed. She would wait forever if it meant she finally got to have Catra like this. Adora rushed forward to kiss Catra again, moving her hands to touch her sides. Catra suddenly leaned back, her eyes widened like saucers on her face.

"Adora we could've been doing this for years!I feel so stupid right now!"Catra pouted but she looked comfortable enough as Adora gripped her hips and drew her closer. They were still laying on the floor of the living room. "Ugh Glimmer's going to be *insufferable* about this, she lied to me so I would confront you!And it worked!" She screeched.

Catra looked so insulted Adora laughed aloud. Adora paused.

"I mean, we don't have to tell her that was why we ended up talking about our feelings."Adora pointed out helpfully sliding her hands around Catra's waist. Catra smiled, pleased with the idea.

"I like the way you think, princess."Catra snuggled closer and Adora sighed, dazed.

"Hey princess, why are we cuddling on the ground when you still have a bed in this apartment."She said in a suggestive tone. They eyed each other and took off racing to the nearest bedroom, laughing all the way there.

Now

It was quickly becoming routine for Catra and Adora to spend some time together after Finn has fallen asleep on the days Catra dropped Finn off. They were currently sitting on opposite ends of the couch facing each other.

Catra's eyes looked like they were on fire, alight with humor as she retold the latest from the debacle that was Sebastian's quest for a tattoo.

"I don't get him. I mean when he first came in, he told me he wanted me to tattoo him on the spot because of what you told him about me." Catra eyed Adora for a moment. "Actually, what did you say about me? I don't think I ever got around to asking." She needled with a smirk.

"I just~~I~~ said you were a good tattoo artist. Which is true." Adora defended. She could feel the heat in her face. She did a little more than say Catra was good~~A~~dora all but gushed about Catra's art and told Sebastian he'd be an idiot if he went anywhere else.

"Of course, that's true. That's all you said?" The mischievous look on Catra's face told Adora that she knew there was more to the story.

"Y up." Adora said, popping the p. *I mean it's true I did go off on a tangent about Catra's work but I don't need her to know that*. Sometimes she felt so transparent like Catra could just see the love she had for her beating in her heart. Catra eyed her for a moment but seemed to let it go.

"Anyways, get this~~for~~ the last month we've had three meetings for redesigns." She widened her eyes comically. "*Three meetings Dora!* And he kept changing what he wants! I keep upping the deposit and charging him for the meetings to see if he will just go away and he just keeps paying without batting an eyelash."

Catra looked so gorgeous, her hands moving animatedly as she talked, her eyes lighting up and her hair bouncing a little as she delivered a great impression of Sebastian.

"I want my dearest Mermista to faint at the sight of Dragon's Daughter Three on my chest! A true piece of art on my flesh!" Catra burst out laughing at her own joke and Adora laughed along with her. She shrugged as her giggle trailed off. "It's easy money though, seeing as we probably are never going to get to the actual tattoo at this rate."

Catra threw herself back as if she were exhausted merely from retelling the story. *What drama queen.*

"You know I'm so proud of you. I always knew you'd be such a successful tattoo artist." The words might be too much and they absolutely reeked of affection but Adora couldn't help it. Besides, she was allowed this ~~to~~ be proud of her best friend.

For a moment, Catra beamed at her. She was always one for praise. But then, a cloud seem to pass over her face as she eyed Adora more seriously. Involuntarily, she leaned back, giving Catra more space.

"Did that make you uncomfortable?" She asked softly. Internally she berated herself. *Of course*, it was too much. She just needed to get a handle on—

"No." Adora's eyes widened at the answer and the silence that followed. She wasn't quite sure what to say to that. Catra seemed at a loss as well. Suddenly everything felt so awkward and it felt like they'd stumbled backward fifteen steps.

Catra let out a loud sigh. "I just ~~w~~hat you said reminded me of before." She said plainly, the edges of her voice raw. Adora furrowed her brow and leaned a bit forward, trying to see Catra's face clearer.

"Before...?" Adora trailed off, hoping Catra would shed light on what she meant. She really wasn't sure what Catra was getting at. Catra scanned her face for a moment with pursed lips.

"Before we were separated." She finished softly. Adora's heart beat wildly in her chest. Catra had never brought up the topic in such a forthright way since they rekindled their friendship. "Do you remember that work holiday party where you tried to pass me off as an interior designer?"

Adora nodded solemnly. "I do remember. I behaved like an ass." Sometimes it kept her up at night, reminders of moments when she disregarded Catra so completely.

"I felt like shit." She whispered tucking her legs close to herself, retreating from Adora. It hurt but she understood. "Sometimes it feels unreal, to hear you say these things now when I think of how things were before." She admitted.

Adora tried to swallow the lump in her throat, but there was no use. She covertly wiped a wayward tear, hoping Catra wouldn't notice. Of course, Catra noticed looking at her with concern. She moved to reach her hand out to Adora, *to comfort Adora* but she pulled back harshly.

"No!" Catra pulled away as if burned. Adora took a deep breath to steady herself. "I *hurt* you Catra. You don't need to comfort me when you're the one who was treated poorly." She explained desperately. "I don't deserve your compassion. Or for you to look at me like that." She gestured at Catra, her face a soft understanding that could be mistaken for pity if you didn't know her well enough.

"Adora." Her voice held a gentle chastisement.

Once again, she slowly lifted her hand, this time purposefully keeping her gaze on Adora, seeking permission. She put her hand on Adora's knee, the closest part of her she could reach. Her hand

felt warm and comforting. Adora couldn't help but relax a fraction under Catra's touch.

"I didn't tell you that to hurt you with it." She explained. "I want"— Catra looked away for a moment her eyes fixing on the clock on the opposite wall "I—want to allow myself to be honest with you." To Adora, it felt like a revelation. "I want to tell you things again." Her voice burned but Adora couldn't tell with what.

"I want that too." She couldn't help but respond. "I'd like for us to be close." *There was a time when our lives were so happy and entangled Icouldn't tell them apart even if Itried.* She dismissed that thought violently, hoping Catra didn't catch the shadow of it passing along her face.

"Then you have to stop steeping in guilt." Her voice cracked over the words sharply, her hand moved off Adora's knee to clench at her side. "The past is done Adora. You need to stop living in it. You can't take back what you did at that party any more than I can take back turning my back on you when you reached out to me that night."

"You had every right to ignore me." She murmured, crossing her legs like a kindergartener and holding onto her ankles. In her mind's eye, she can envision Catra in their bed, tense and pretending to be asleep until Adora slinked away defeated into the guestroom.

Catra rolled her eyes. "That's not the point. We both could have done things differently that night." *We both could've done so much differently* remains unsaid. "We can't fix that now. But maybe we can fix this?" She asked imploringly.

Adora swallowed roughly, once again trying to keep the tears at bay. "I can't promise that I won't feel guilty about things I've done"— *The thing Iregret most in this world is letting myself lose you* "—but I'll work on it. I don't want my guilt to keep you from opening up to me." She felt herself getting lost in Catra's eyes. "If you want to, of course, I'm not expecting anything." She added.

"Okay ."Catra took a deep breath. "I hated that you did that, but I hated it more that you left our bed that night."She eyed her cautiously.

"Really?"Adora asked. Of all her mistakes that night, sleeping on the couch felt like the smallest. "I wanted to give you space. Y ou seemed to want it at the time."She of fered. "But Im sorry that it hurt you."

"I can see why you might have thought that."Catra gave her the olive branch as if it didn't mean everything to Adora. "And you don't have to apologize."

It was Adora's turn to roll her eyes. "How about this? Im going to try to stop being a sentient well of guilt but you're going to let me own up to the shitty things I did and apologize."Catra's eyes shined with laughter as she shook her head.

"Fine if I must. Y ou have a lot of apologizing to do."She cracked. Adora smiled but internally winced. *You have no idea Cat.* "Number one apology I want is for all of the terrible meals I had to endure during our marriage."She waggled her eyebrows and Adora couldn't help the cackle that escaped her. That shattered the serious mood.

"Oh no, I refuse to apologize for all of the nutritious meals that sustained you."She couldn't keep a straight face as she said it. Suddenly they were both giggling like high schoolers rolling on their backs, legs occasionally colliding. They continued to rib each other back and forth until their laughter subsided.

"Did anything interesting happen for you today?"Catra asked once she could breathe again. Catra lounged on the couch, stretched out in an almost abnormal pose, arms and legs akimbo. Catra was always weird when she was comfortable, bending into the oddest shapes.

"No, nothing interesting really ,"Adora answered honestly , turning down the branch manager position long forgotten.

Chapter End Notes

So I added a whole lot to this chapter last minute and at least right now (.5 seconds after adding it) I feel soooooo much better about it. Let me know what you think!

As always, kudos and comments are the fuel that people and plants crave (10 points for whoever gets the movie reference lol). Also, if you like me follow me on Twitter.

On another note, I have been a bit of a busy bee since I updated last Friday. *ah hem*

If you are a fan of the Mask and Mistakes Universe (Superhero AU) we have Adora's Origin Story (Backbones and Breakouts).

If you watched First Kill or just want to enjoy Catradora being a hot vampire and monster hunter who hate each other we have this First Kill AU (What You'd Do to Me).

If you want a fluffy domestic funnies where Catra tries to keep Adora's plants alive we have Planted

Obviously, I wrote them all so I would recommend them all but y'all can decide for yourself which of my content is for you lol.

Next Week: Catra picks up Finn from Thaymor and has a chat with Mara. In the past, Adora and Catra celebrate their first Christmas as an engaged couple.

A Family Affair

Chapter Summary

Catra picks up Finn from Thaymor.

Catra and Adora have their first Christmas in Brightmoon as an engaged couple.

The drive back home is a long one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I'm so, so, sorry Cat, I told them that I had to be done by noon but then the computers were down, and IT couldn't fix it until it got permission to update some software, it's all been a mess I just"— Adora rambled on eternally about whatever IT issues have her stranded in the office today. Catra rolled her eyes, put her phone on speaker, and focused on the road.

"Jeez Dor relax, I don't mind picking up our kid, the drive isn't that long." It was only an hour fifteen each way to Thaymor . They really needed to make a better effort to let Finn spend time with their family anyways. "I'm glad they got to spend the weekend with Mar and my parents." She added aloud.

"Still, I'm sorry it was so last minute." Adora sounded miserable. The words made something in Catra twitch, too close of a reminder of how things were before. *"It's different now"* she reminded herself. She'd forgiven Adora and this was the first time she'd flaked out of something for work since they restarted their friendship in earnest. And it wasn't Catra's place to judge how Adora spent her time anymore.

Besides, she had a more pressing concern.

"W as the drop-off... okay for you?" She asked tentatively , not knowing if it was something Adora would like to talk about. She thought it might be the first time she'd made the drive up to Thaymor since they last did it when they were still together. She heard her fumble for a moment before the line went silent.

"It wasn't the worst it's been." She admitted hesitantly . "I didn't have a panic attack which is progress, believe it or not. I was really anxious before and after ." She clammed up and the silence between them lingered.

"I'm glad it was better than other times," Catra af firmed. She wasn't sure what else to say.

Adora sighed loudly. "Y eah, I mostly was worried about Finn, but I don't think they noticed," Adora responded, whatever latent anxiety was still there permeating her voice.

Catra switched gears, not wanting to hang up on a dark note. "Hey , you owe me for this! I don't have time to stop by my parent's house and I'm never going to hear the end of it from my mother . That I was in town and I didn't stop by ," Catra teased. It was her M.O., making Adora comfortable by purposefully bothering her about shit that didn't really matter .

"What do I owe you Cat?" Adora sounded amused. The question bordered on flirty and it made heat flash through Catra. That was happening a lot more lately. *Catra you need to hold it together, she doesn't mean it that way.*

"Y ou can break the news to my mom and fall on that sword for me." She suggested. *Probably the most unsexy suggestion ever . This works.*

"Ha! I'd rather go to three more days of these meetings than face Catrina when she's mad." Adora laughed as she swatted the idea away. Catra couldn't help but agree with her on that one.

"Well, whatever dummy, I need to go. Im almost at your sister's actually." She stuck her tongue out as she took the last turn to pull into Mara's driveway. The road hadnt been paved in a while so it was always a challenge. Catra heard Adora go unusually quiet on the other end, and she wasnt sure why.

"Adora? You Still there?" She tried, unsure if she lost reception.

Adora sputtered, "Yeah, yeah. Please send Finn and Mar my love." Now Catra was the quiet one. Adora cleared her throat, clearly uncomfortable.

"Okay Dor, got to go." She hung up before the conversation somehow got more awkward. A few minutes later she parked in Mara's driveway and knocked on the door. Mara looked surprised to see her. *Adora probably forgot to call ahead. Dummy.*

"Finn! Your mama is here, come and say hi!" She hollered. Mara's house is on the outskirts of Thaymor, more rural than even where they grew up together, which is saying something.

Finn ran up to Catra, hugging her close.

"Hey, mama. Missed you!" They let go and gave her a cheeky grin. She couldnt help but crouch down and ruffle their hair.

"Did you pick up all of the things you need before we head out?" She asked. Finn looked guilty, glancing at their aunt to see if she would help. *Good luck with that kid.*

"Go take a shower and pick up all your stuff so we can head out before it gets dark." She told them as she turned them around. Finn sent her a glare when she said the word shower, but Catra held firm.

They gave a pleading look to Mara who raised her hands in a defeated way. "Mama's the boss squirt, not me." She said in a theatrical sad voice, shaking her head as she did so.

"Shower? Really?" They complained, a pout at the ready .

"Y es, shower," Catra repeated, giving them a tired look that meant they couldn't wiggle out of it.

There was no getting Finn to get clean after a long drive and a weekend being spoiled by Mara. She'd made that mistake one too many times. Finn grumbled as they went to the guest room.

"Don't think I'm not glad to see you Catra, but where is my sister? I thought she was picking up Finn?" She furrowed her brow as she asked. She gestured for Catra to sit at her dining table, a sturdy rustic thing Mara built with her bare hands.

"That was the plan, but she got stuck in a work meeting. Y ou know how she is about work." Catra replied, lips pressed together .

Mara's eyes clouded over. "That girl needs to stop working so hard before her life passes her by. She told me she was up for that branch manager position." Mara sighed sitting next to Catra.

Catra's stomach dropped.

She'd avoided talking about Adora's work for months until they finally address some of that elephant in the room the week before. It felt good to finally tell Adora about how she felt, even if it was just about one incident in the barrage that caused their marriage to crumble.

Adora's work remained a sore spot, but wouldn't she tell Catra about this? She had no idea that Adora was in the running for the branch manager promotion, never mind that she'd received an offer. *Is this why she looked so guilty when we talked last week?*

She shook her head and shoved her feelings down. "I wouldn't know anything about that, I haven't really talked to her about her job lately," Catra responded honestly . Mara looked at Catra, really studying her face.

"How are you doing, Kit?" Mara leaned her face in her head, looking at Catra with interest. She smiled at the nickname, the only person that called her that was Mara.

"I'm good Mar , never better." She assured her , which was true in a way. Mara's eyes shined bright, and her smile was so warm. It reminded her of Adora.

"I'm glad to hear it." Mara' s smile dimmed and she looked tentative as she bit her lips, gaze razor-focused.

Catra knew that look.

"What do you wanna know , Mar?" Catra asked, already feeling tired. The idea that Adora will be the next Bright Moon manager threw her for a loop and she wasn't ready to get grilled.

Mara sighed. "I know it' s not fair to ask you this, but is Adora okay?" Catra's smile tightened. She should've expected this from Mara.

"I agree Mar , that's not really fair right now." There was an edge to Catra's words—she' s annoyed Mara would put her in this position. She sighed, looking down at her hands. "I don't know . She seems to be doing okay as far as I can see. We're getting along better than when we first separated. I don't know what else to say ."

Mara still looked apologetic but that didn't make Catra feel any less uncomfortable. "I worry about you too, you know . You're just as much my little sister." Mara reminded her .

Catra felt herself relax a bit. "I know Mar . I appreciate it." She knew Mara was upset by the news of their separation. "I just don't want to talk about Adora with you. It's weird, you know?"

Mara rolled her eyes. "Just because she' s my sister doesn't mean I don't see how she hurt you. How you're both hurting now ." She crossed her arms over her chest as she sat up. "Also, I grew up with you too, Kit. I'm not picking sides."

Catra sighed. Adora and Mara probably got their stubbornness from the same place. "Okay then, what wisdom do you have for me? Have you and my mom been planning this?" She accused, only half-joking.

Mara laughed at that, shifting her chair so she could lean back. "I think you're better off talking with me than Catrina about things like this." Everyone knew Catra's mom was a firecracker. "I just want to know that you two are actually doing alright and not putting up a front for us. I know you're hurting—you don't need to hide it. That must be exhausting."

"This stays between us," Catra clarified. Mara nodded warm smile back in place. "I really am doing better, but I'd be lying if I said I didn't miss Adora." Catra caved, admitting this to another soul for the first time since everything changed between her and Adora. Mara's face stayed neutral, but she could see a spark in her eyes. *This was probably a mistake.*

"Why don't you talk with Adora about fixing things then?" Mara had a wide grin and big hopeful eyes that made her look more like her sister than ever. *Correction, this was definitely a mistake.*

"Adora wants to be friends and I want to respect that." Catra looked down, her fingers finding the grain of the wood soothing. "Besides, even if we both wanted to, I don't know that we could fix whatever is broken between us. It's been so long, and we've hurt each other so much," she admitted with a whisper.

Forgiveness, friendship, co-parenting—that was one thing. But to let Adora in again, to let her be Catra's *everything?* It took trust in Adora that Catra simply didn't think she could muster. That didn't even take into account that Adora didn't *want* to get back together. How was she meant to hold herself out to her wife and then bear it when Adora looked at her with pity and murmured about *just friends* and *I'll always care Catra, just not like that*. Not the way Catra wanted.

And there was that *promotion.*

"Isn't it worth a try?" Mara wondered quietly, breaking Catra's reverie.

She collected the thoughts swirling in her mind for a moment. She leaned forward, fixing Mara with a hard stare.

"Look, that last year we were together was miserable. Adora didn't prioritize me or the time that we spent together, she just cared about that damn promotion. She didn't listen to me. She didn't love me anymore." She laid out all the facts for both Mara and herself. "At least as friends, I get to keep a part of her. Even if it isn't what we had before."

To have this part of Adora was more than Catra could have ever hoped for when she stormed out of her house with tears in her eyes and beat-up luggage trailing behind her.

She pressed further this time looking out the window to the rolling hills on Mara's land. "There's no reason to think that she's changed, if anything the promotion will make her even more absent than before." Another thought occurred to her. "And I had a girlfriend, Mara! I know for a fact she's been seeing other people!" *At least she's been sleeping with other people*, Catra thought bitterly. "Do you think we should just forget all that?"

The reasons why trying again would be stupid, stupid, *stupid* were just insurmountable. Every worry that lived orbiting her thoughts about Adora and fixing their marriage spilled forward. Usually, she tamped them down because it was all moot anyway, given that the only thing on the table was this exhilarating but painful friendship.

Mara just smiled, leaning on the table.

"I think you'll find that time heals more than you'd think. I'm not saying it would be easy or that you should even do it." She explained in that easy way of hers. "You've been with someone else. Maybe you've found that what you need isn't what Adora can offer you. But if in your heart you still love her, you should think about it." Mara

advocated eyes wide and honest. Catra could feel a lump in her throat that she viciously pushed down.

This is it. Im going to burst out crying in my sister -in-law's house. This is going to be so embarrassing.

"I Mara I just cant. I dont want to be rejected by her ."She managed to croak out, running her hands through her hair. *Again. How I was rejected every time she stood me up or didn't listen or—*

"I wont pretend to know whats going on in your marriage better than you do Kit, but I cant imagine a world where Adora doesnt love you like that. Doesnt want to be with you."Mara reached out and touched her knee gently. *Well, you don't have to imagine because we're living in it.* "She might have been shit at showing it"— *Understatement of the century Mar .* "and I wont justify that. But that girl has loved you as long as she's known you."

Adora's love her care and friendship for Catra was never in question. She knew Adora still cared, but it wasnt what Mara was implying. She hadnt been there, she didnt know , hadnt been hurt the way Catra had.

"I dont want to talk about this anymore."She edged her seat backward moving out of Mara's grasp. She somehow simultaneously felt better and worse after talking to Mara. Mara looked like she was about to protest, but at that moment the shower water stopped running.

"Saved by the bell,"Mara murmured as she got up of f her chair. She walked up to Catra and gave her a hug. "For what it' s worth Kit, well always be family."

Catra felt her eyes water at that. She hugged Mara tightly, her forehead touching the tall woman's collar bone.

"It' s worth a lot. You are my family too, Mar."She agreed.

Then

Catra tried to do the math between the recipes, oven temperatures, and cook times—it was pointless. She was about to throw all her pans at the kitchen wall. Even the roasting pan, which weighed a shit ton. *I should get Adora to do it.* Her fiancé happened to just walk into the kitchen and froze, probably because she could see the unhinged gleam in Catra's eyes.

It was their first-time hosting Christmas at Bright Moon with both their families. The cooking fell mostly to her because getting Adora to do it would be asking for trouble. And even though Adora had been great about dealing with all the non-cooking errands that had to happen there were just *so many damn things to cook.*

Adora approached Catra very slowly, the way someone would approach a wild animal.

"Hey , Cat. My love. Whole heart even." Adora flashed her a dorky smile that made her melt just a little. Adora reached her and tugged her into her strong arms. She felt her jaw unclench. "Want to tell me what's going on?" Hmm?" Adora murmured into her hair .

Catra unloaded on her.

"Our oven is too small for the amount of shit that has to be in it, I don't know how to make the *fricasé de pollo* that mom always makes for Christmas, I can't read the pie recipe that Mara sent me because Raz writes like a goddamn gremlin, and even if I could get it all to work I'm going to look like an absolute mess because I don't have time to shower after dinner." Catra shut her eyes tightly to prevent the tears of frustration she could feel bubbling up.

Adora's hand gently move to her jaw , tilting her face up.

"Hey , hey, hey, look at me." Adora' s blue eyes were boring into her, and she felt the world right itself again. "To start, it doesn't matter whether you shower or not, you'll be the most beautiful woman in the

room.”She grinned broadly as she scanned Catra's body before her eyes flickered back up to her face.

Catra rolled her eyes but she could feel a blush spreading across her cheeks.

“Y ou're just saying that because you're marrying me.”She muttered, feeling contrarian. Adora pressed a soft kiss to her forehead.

“No, it' s just the truth since you're the most beautiful person in the universe. It has to be true that you're the most beautiful woman in any given room since that's a smaller data set.”She said cutely , eyes dancing with mirth. Her gaze softened and she tenderly held Catra' s hands, interlacing their fingers. “This is just our family . Even if we serve them a charred chicken, they will love us. Well be fine.”

Catra nuzzled in closer . “But it' s our first time hosting and I just wanted to make a good impression.”Catra hesitated. “I just don't want them to think that Im not capable or not ready to marry you or something.”

Adora let out a loud laugh. “Cat, if making a perfect Christmas dinner is required to get married, I will never be eligible.”Adora sputtered between chuckles, pressing her forehead against Catra's.

She felt silly now that she'd said it out loud, but it also felt like a weight lifting off her shoulders.

“Y eah Kit, I thought you were going to marry my sister, not banish her into spinsterhood.”Mara turned the corner smiling cheekily .

“Mara!”Adora turned red, pulling away slightly while still holding one of Catra's hands.

“W e thought you might need some help in here.”Catra' s mom walked in next, placing a comforting hand on her daughter 's shoulder.

Catra looked at her mother and Mara, suddenly so grateful to have them here instead of just stressed.

"Yeah, probably." She agreed. "Mama, can you start the chicken, and Mara—what the hell did Raz write on that?" Catra asked, feeling slightly embarrassed for needing help at the eleventh hour.

Catrina wasted no time picking up where Catra left off with the *sofrito* the pungent garlic and onion smells wafting throughout the kitchen.

"I think this says—two spoons of sugar sprinkled on the dough? That sounds right." Mara muttered absentmindedly as she transcribed the old recipe onto her phone.

"What do you need from me captain?" Adora asked bumping her shoulder into Catra's.

"Can you chop these veggies while I get the other ingredients?" Catra asked, holding up an onion and three carrots. Adora leaned in and gave her a sweet kiss before relieving her of the vegetables.

"Of course babe." She surveyed the bustling kitchen for a moment before grinning at Catra again. "You see? We can work this out together Cat."

Catra rolled her eyes fondly. "Yeah, yeah get chopping." She pretended to whip Adora with a kitchen towel she had handy which made her laugh loudly.

With all hands-on deck, Christmas dinner was ready and Catra even had time to shower.

Now

Finn fell asleep on the drive back, as expected. They looked so cute with their mouth half-open their breaths deep and loud, never quite

reaching a snore. Catra was grateful, she didn't think she could keep her mood from Finn for long. They were a smart kid.

Saying aloud all the reasons why Adora and her wouldn't work together anymore was emotionally exhausting. Hearing Mara say she was sure that Adora was in love with her was worse than that. Ultimately their romantic relationship was a failure because Adora didn't see Catra that way anymore. How dare Mara try to give her false hope.

The plan had originally been for Catra to take Finn back home to *Adora's house*, Catra reminded herself and for them to spend some time together as a family. But Catra didn't want to see Adora right now, feeling as raw as she did.

She took a deep breath and called the woman in question.

"Hey Cat! You making good time back from Thaymor?" Adora sounded chipper, there was some background noise Catra couldn't distinguish.

"Yeah, we'll make it back before it's dark out." She took a deep breath. "Listen, do you mind if I keep Finn tonight? I'm feeling tired from the drive, and I just want to go straight to bed." She bit her lip as she waited for a response.

Catra heard the clattering in the background stop, finally realizing the noise was from the kitchen—*she was going to try to cook dinner*. She felt a pang of guilt and something else at that.

"Oh. Um, sure Cat whatever you need. Are you okay?" Adora cleared her voice awkwardly. It was clear as day that she was worried. Her voice took on a higher pitch and she hesitated as she asked about Catra's wellbeing.

"Yeah, I'm fine Dora. Just tired." She winced at how unconvincing she sounded, even to herself. She heard Adora take a big gulp of air.

"Cat. Are *we* okay? Mara didn't say anything to you, did she?" Adora's voice was full of suspicion.

Caught. Damn. She briefly considers bringing up the branch manager promotion but quickly dismissed the idea. She really didn't want to have a drawn-out conversation or a fight with Adora right now, especially since they hadn't fought since they rekindled their friendship. Maybe she'd bring it up when she was feeling less off balance.

"Your sister was great as always. I'm feeling worn out but it doesn't have anything to do with you." Catra offered, trying her best to keep her voice even. *There are lies and there are damn lies, I guess.*

"We're good," Catra finished reassuring Adora. *They were good. That isn't a lie.* She tightened her grip on the stirring wheel.

"Okay Cat, I won't make you talk to me if you don't want to." She sighed and Catra could imagine the little furrow in her brow as if Adora was sitting across from her. "I'm here if you do though. Want to talk I mean. I'll see you tomorrow?" Adora didn't sound reassured. Catra took the opportunity to hang up like a lifeline.

"Yeah, tomorrow's good. Goodnight." Catra dismissed her quickly.

"Tell Finn that I'll miss them." Adora's voice was a warm whisper, but it sounded choked. It shot straight through Catra's heart. *Fuck, I just can't do anything right today, can I?*

"Finn loves you Dor, I'm sure they missed you tons." *Same as me.* "I really have to go now."

Glad she didn't have to talk with Adora anymore, she managed to hustle Finn through their bedtime routine with little fuss. She makes it to the shower before she started to mope again.

The conversation with Mara brought up something else she avoided thinking about. If there was no hope for them as a married couple,

Catra and Adora had to get divorced at some point. *Some point soon.*

She'd talked to her attorney, and she assured Catra that it was only a matter of time before the paperwork was finalized. She refused to go to any of the hearings once her attorney told her it wasn't mandatory and from what she'd been told, Adora had a similar setup with her attorney. One day, they'd have to sign on the dotted line and that would be that.

Every time she thought about going through with the divorce, she felt like she might throw up. She knew it was inevitable, knew that Adora fell out of love and only wanted to be friends. But the thought of losing that last tie between them, the last thing that marked their relationship as different from friendship made her tremble.

And the worst part was that she started all of it. Sure, Adora was not a good wife to her, but *she* left Adora. She never reached out when she wasn't angry, and she did a shit job communicating what she needed.

She asked Adora for space, *she* wanted to separate and see other people, and *she* filed the paperwork. She couldn't just roll that all back now, no matter what Mara thought. She had no one to blame but herself for being in this position. For losing her wife.

Chapter End Notes

> Eyyy so I am going on a trip tomorrow and I was like hmm should I make them wait until Sunday or should I just post today? And clearly, the answer was to send this in early lol.
>
> ALSO maybe keep your eyes peeled because I intend on posting something fluffier later tonight :D
>
> So this was a wee bit sad. Just a wee bit? Progress is not linear folks and if you thought that they would smoothly glide back into

a beautiful marriage with no struggle then... you dont know me lmao. BUt never fear!They are still building forward. :)

As always receiving kudos and comments is what keeps writing and posting on this beautiful website. Also, follow me on Twitter.

(Out of curiosity and if y'all dont mind sharing-do you only read SPOP fics or are there other fandoms you enjoy? Im planning on branching out a little and Im curious what else y'all read!).

Nextweek: Finn and Adora hang out in the park. In the past, Adora finds out about Starla.

An Undiscussed Hurdle

Chapter Summary

Finn and Adora go to the park.

Adora finds out about Starla.

Finn has questions about their moms.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Mom, can we go to the park today?" Finn looked up from their homework with their quintessential puppy dog stare.

Adora sighed, running her hand through her hair. She was tired, hadn't even *thought* of what to make for dinner, and had zero desire to take her kid to the park. She tried to hold firm, though she felt herself melting under the look. Finn knew exactly how weak Adora was for their sad pout and used it to its full advantage. She spread her hands on the counter, bracing herself against it.

"Bud, we went to the park yesterday ." She told them, hoping they would leave it alone. They twirled one of their pencils around their fingers while contemplating their next move, a calculating look that doesn't belong on the face of an eight-year-old.

"I know , but Sophie said she was going to be at the park today and I haven't played with her in such a *long* time!" They urged, eyes bright with excitement. Adora gave her kid a side-long glance.

"I thought you colored with Sophie last week when Mama took you." She said knowingly and watched how they froze up. *Caught*. Catra had told her about the play date which was something Finn probably hadn't been counting on. *Little rascal.*

Finn rolled their eyes exasperatedly, switching tactics. "Yes, but coloring is different from the park mom, it's not that same! I did all my homework and I promised Sophie I'd be there. Can we please go?" Their voice carried a bit of a whine as they rocked in their chair.

Adora shook her head and straightened out her back, knowing when Finn set their mind to something like this there was no arguing with it. She'd have better luck giving in now than arguing about it for another half hour.

"Alright, grab your shoes. We'll make it to the park for a little bit." Adora sent them a hard stare. "But *only* for a little bit, you hear me?"

They blew right past her making a beeline for their shoes. "Yes! Thanks, mom!" They called over their shoulder, a giggle in their voice. Adora couldn't help but smile at the sound.

She bit her lip and looked out the window, noting that it was still light out. If she was going to go to the park she might as well make the most of it. She pulled out her phone to text Catra.

Hey, Finn and I are going to be at the park in half an hour. Do you wanna join?

She gets a reply almost instantly.

Heyyyy hot stuff ;)

Adora's eyebrows shot to her hairline, and she could hear her heart in her ear drums. Before she could think anything more of the message, it was followed up with *Lol sorry, it's Bonnie, Catra is in the middle of a session. She's probably going to be burning the midnight oil on this one.*

She then received a voice memo. Adora's fingers trembled as she played it.

"Lonn, I swear , if you try to flirt with *my wife using my phone,* I will end your existence. Tell Adora I'd love to go to the park, but I really can't make it today."Adora's heart clenched at hearing Catra call her *my wife*. She then hears Lonnie's voice echoing closer than Catra's, clearly holding the phone.

"Well, you just told her yourself I've been recording you."Lonnie's voice drips with smugness. Adora laughed as she heard Catra's indignant squeak.

"How much of that was recorded!Lonn, I swear you are *so* lucky my hands are literally busy."Catra sputtered off as the recording ended.

Thanks for letting me know Lonnie, hope you're doing well! Adora texted back, thinking it wise to not comment on the whole exchange. Sometimes she couldn't believe Lonnie and Catra got any work done in the same building.

When they got to the park, Finn immediately ran off in the direction of their friends, leaving Adora only with her thoughts as she kept an eye on her kid.

Thankfully, it seemed the other day that Catra canceled their plans was a minor blip. The next day , Catra dropped Finn off with a gentle smile and no indication of whatever it was that bothered her when she went to Mara's. She tried not to think about it much but keeping her thoughts from Catra was always going to be a fool's errand.

Adora felt so off-balance with Catra. On the one hand, it felt so right to spend time together, especially with Finn or the few times they had hung out alone. But sometimes she'd reach out to pull Catra into her body, to kiss her nose or her lips, to tell her how much she loved her, and reality came crashing back down on her. Even though it felt like she had Catra, she didn't really , at least not the way she used to.

Adora felt like before she got together with Catra, hormonal and confused, desperately wishing and dreaming for something that was

unattainable. The only difference was that now Catra really *was* unattainable, and she had vivid memories of what it was like to truly have her, not just wishes and dreams. She hunched over, putting her hands in her head and groaning.

This is so much worse than college. Im such an idiot, how am I going to keep everything together in front of Catra indefinitely. Adora knew how. She was terrified of losing what she *did* have with Catra. Adora was always the coward out of the two of them. And now she knew exactly what it felt like to lose it all.

Then

She wasnt sure why she always felt so on edge right before seeing Catra. Probably because she wasnt quite sure where she stood with her wife. She sighed, leaning back against the far wall of the living room.

Adora thought Catra really took the idea of taking space and ran with it, given that they separated six months ago, and shed shown no signs of trying to come back. She should come back home soon. Shed talk to Adora when she was ready. Adora just needed to be patient for a little while longer. She hoped.

For now, Adora waited for Catra to drop off Finn, hoping something would break them out of their holding pattern. She heard the tell-tale sign of the doorbell and sighed, standing to her full height as she opened the door. As always, Finn arrived excited about the quality time they spent with their Mama.

"How are you doing Finn?" She asked gently, happy to see her kid.

"Great mom! Mama and I went to Thaymor. We saw grandma, grandpa, and Aunt Mara! I got to go to your favorite playground—they moved the swings to the back. Aunt Mara pushed me, and I got sooooo far off the ground." Finn kept explaining their weekend trip to

Adora and Catra's hometown as Adora froze over . She bit her lip to keep from frowning.

She gave Finn the best smile she could manage. "That's great buddy! I didn't know you were going to Thaymor , I would have helped you pack more clothes." She couldn't help the way she pressed her lips as she tried to catch Catra's eye. Catra avoided looking directly at her, opting instead to look down at Finn. *Figures.* Adora ignored the brush-off and listened attentively to Finn as their voice got squeakier while telling Adora more stories.

"Next time you should come with us, mom!" Finn enthused. They didn't notice the tension in the room, or at least they didn't let on if they did. Adora hadn't been back to Thaymor since they separated, and she couldn't quite stomach going alone. She always hated going back to Thaymor.

"It sounds like you had a full weekend. Why don't we say bye to mama so we can check your backpack for school and get ready for bed?" Finn gives Catra a big hug, looking slightly dejected by the idea of her leaving. *You and me both, buddy*.

"Actually Finn, why don't you go pack those books that you mentioned wanting to bring to mama's apartment while I talk to mom?" Finn bounded up, excited at the mention of books.

Adora whipped her head around trying to make eye contact again. Catra still avoided her eyes and her teeth tug at her bottom lip, a sure sign that she was anxious. Which in turn made Adora anxious.

Would she finally ask her about the divorce papers? She really didn't think she could take that tonight. *Or any night really.*

"What's up? Is everything okay with your parents? Why were you in Thaymor?" The questions spilled out of Adora in a torrent. Catra finally looked up at her, a tentative smile on her face, and Adora was struck dumb by how beautiful she looked. It calmed the swell of her anxiety and let her fall silent.

"Yeah, they're fine. I'm sorry I didn't tell you I was visiting. It was a spur of the moment thing and I couldn't bear to be in town and not see Mara." She explained, still eyeing Adora with a slight smile.

She felt herself soften at those words. Mara and Catra had a tight bond given how close they all were growing up. It was one of the things that made her relationship with Catra feel right, the way they both loved not only the other but their families so completely.

"Of course Cat, I was just caught off guard. You're always welcome with my sister." Adora took a deep breath, took a risk, and reached out to touch Catra's hand. "You're always welcome here too." She tacked on, hoping she wouldn't somehow make things tenser.

Catra leaned into the touch and squeezed her hand. Adora felt like she couldn't breathe. For a second, it felt like before, when everything was fine. Then Catra pulled away.

"I wanted to talk to you about something else." Catra gnawed on her bottom lip again—*stop staring at Catra's lips you useless*—and Adora's nerves shot up again. *She has to be asking for a divorce. This is it.* Adora braced her body for impact.

"I just wanted to let you know that I've been on a few dates with a girl." She said haltingly. "I'll let you know if it gets serious enough to tell Finn, but I thought you should hear it from me before you heard it from one of our friends." Catra stared at the ground, the wall, anywhere but Adora.

She couldn't breathe. No amount of bracing could have prepared Adora for this.

Oh no. This is so much worse. A few days after Catra left to stay with Scorpia and Perfuma, they discussed separating meant being able to see other people, but Adora never thought that would actually *happen*. She thought it was just a thing people said. She hadn't touched any woman but Catra in over a decade. She didn't want to. How could Catra? Was she so far removed from everything,

from *Adora* that she just wanted to start anew? It was at that moment she realized things were well and truly over between them.

She took in a sharp breath, anger burning in the pit of her stomach. "Uh okay I-I really don't know what you want me to say Catra. Do you want my *blessing*?" The words came out with so much vitriol that Adora almost looked around to see who delivered them.

Catra took a step back, looking like she'd been burned. But she wasn't—she'd burned Adora this time. "I'm just trying to be honest and show you respect Adora." She said in a controlled voice Adora assumed she thought was reasonable.

Respect? Adora's temper rose even further. "Wow! Thanks, Catra, I feel *so* respected right now—you know what, see who you want, go where you want, it clearly isn't any of my business anymore." She sneered. Adora opened the front door and Catra walked through but hesitated on the porch, turning back to look at Adora.

She looked at Adora with *pity* of all things. She didn't wait for Catra to leave before she slammed the door shut.

Now

"Hey Finn, talk to your Aunt for a bit yeah?" Adora had finally managed to wrangle Finn into the car after extending their park time by ten minutes. While she had them trapped she thought it might be a good idea to have them call Mara.

"Yeah!" Finn sounded excited at the prospect. Adora nodded and dialed Mara, putting the phone on speaker and holding it over the car's center console.

"Hey kid, how are you?" Mara picked up the phone almost immediately.

"Auntie Mara! I just played with some friends and now mom and I are going home!" Finn jumped in before Adora had a chance to say hi to her sister. She shook her head and let her kid take charge.

"Oh, Finn! That's really cool tyke! What'd you play?" She asked, voice dripping in affection. Finn gave Mara a full recounting of their day and then passed the phone on to Adora. She took it off speaker after Finn said their goodbyes.

"Hey Mar, still have time for your sister?" Adora teased using one hand to put the phone to her ear and the other on the steering wheel.

"I always have time for you kid. You sound so much happier now, I can hear it over the phone." She said softly. Adora can feel her smile.

"I am. Im sorry I couldnt pick up Finn last weekend and I didnt warn you about it. Work got crazy." She sighed and her hand tightened on the wheel. She really had to make it up to Mara.

"It's fine, I saw you when you dropped Finn off and it was nice seeing Catra." Mara used that as a transition. "Speaking of Adora, I know there are little ears about, but you should really speak to your wife."

Adora rolled her eyes. "I talk to her all the time. At least once a day." Catra and Adora had picked up on texting regularly about anything and everything.

"You know that's not what I meant," Mara said exasperatedly. She'd been urging her to try to fix things for a while.

"Speaking of" Adora cleared her throat "that person. Did you say anything to upset her?" She couldnt shake the feeling that Mara did *something* that made Catra cancel their afternoon plans.

"I would never try to upset Catra. And if we *did* have a *private* conversation, then that's between Kit and I. Im not a snitch." Mara

sniffed. "But if you care to know , maybe you should just *have a chat with her.*" Mara insisted again, frustration seeping into her voice.

Adora bit back a scoff. Her sister was so far off base that it was laughable. And even if there was some *spark of interest* between them, Adora couldn't be the one who upset the balance they managed to find. She wasn't the one who left—wasn't the one who wanted to be just friends. She couldn't entertain the idea that there was a possibility of more when she'd already recovered more than she ever deserved. Not that she could say all that with Finn in the backseat.

"If it ain't broke don't fix it Mar . I have to go—Finn and I are almost home. Love you!" She rushed her words in an ef fort to get off the phone.

Mara sighed, knowing when Adora was trying to evade a lecture. "I love you too. Be good to my favorite nibling!" She warned.

Adora rolled her eyes as she hung up.

"Mom, is Mama your girlfriend?" Finn suddenly piped up from the back seat. Adora caught their inquisitive stare through the rearview mirror and was glad she could keep her eyes on the road as she answered the question.

"Um no Finn, she isn't. Why do you ask?" She wasn't expecting Finn to broach a topic like that so directly. Although, she was glad they felt like they could ask. She wished Catra was here to help field the question.

"You hang out a lot with Mama, and Bryce said he was Sophie's boyfriend, and they hang out a lot," Finn explained. "And you were married before." They dutifully pointed out.

"Ah, I see. I can imagine sometimes it can be confusing, your mama and I." She tried to sound sympathetic as she scrambled for an answer that was appropriate for an eight-year-old. "Well, we're

friends Finn. We don't have a romantic relationship right now. We like to hang out platonically."

"Platonically?" Finn's head tilted in confusion almost leaning into the seat belt across their chest.

Adora met their eyes through the rear-view mirror. "It means not romantically." She explained.

"So, you could have a girlfriend?" Finn asked their tone full of doubt.

"I could." She agreed. She probably wouldn't but she could. Theoretically.

"And Mama could have a girlfriend?" Adora kept her face neutral as her thoughts automatically drifted to Starla.

"Yeah, bud." She answered.

"So, you're just friends like me and Sophie?" Finn tried again, voice filled with skepticism.

"Exactly." She affirmed again.

"But more, because we're a family." Finn made the statement almost like a question.

"Yeah, that's true Finn. You're mama and me, we're really good friends because we're also family. Like with Auntie Glimmer and Uncle Bow. They're friends that are like family. Or Auntie Fuma and Scorpia." She explained, hoping that Finn would accept that answer.

"Okay, I guess that makes sense." They admitted grudgingly. "So, mama isn't moving back home?" Adora felt her chest tighten at how small Finn's voice sounded when they asked that question.

She couldn't help but sigh longingly at the thought. "I don't think so, Finnie. But that doesn't mean we love you any less." She comforted.

I know .”They said, looking down at their feet as they nudge the seat in front of them. Adora reached her arm back and lightly squeezed one of their calves in assurance.

“Do you like it better now that we're hanging out together? Or would you rather we did things like before?” She asked, genuinely curious. She waited nervously for the answer. If spending more time together was hurting Finn, then they'd have to stop no matter how much the thought made Adora tremble.

Finn shook their head adamantly. “No! I like it like this. Y ou and Mama are happier and I get to see you more. I don't wanna go back to not doing things together.”Adora’ s chest loosened a bit at hearing that Finn preferred how things were now.

She nodded her head. “Okay , that’s good to know kid. Ill make sure to let Mama know that you like family time so we can keep doing it alright? But what we do as a family doesn't mean Mama and I are anything more than friends alright?” She clarified again. She didn't want Finn to hold out hope of something that wasn't in the cards. That kind of hope wouldn't do much for either of them.

“Okay .”They nodded looking back down at the toys they took to the park.

She made a mental note to let Catra know that Finn was thinking about this. Maybe she'd call and talk to her about it later tonight. Although she knew she shouldn't, she felt warm thinking of lying in her bed, whispering on the phone to Catra like they were back in high school.

As she parked in her driveway, she shot Catra another text *We missed you today. I hope your session was good!* She started collecting her things from the back seat of the car when she saw Finn jump out of the car and sprint towards the house.

Before she could remind them to wipe down their muddy shoes before entering the house, Finn turned the corner. She heard their

squeaky voice yell "Mama!" followed by a gorgeous laugh. Adora would know that laugh anywhere. Without consciously deciding to, she picked up her pace to close the distance between her and the house.

And at her door was Catra, one hand full of Finn while the other had a bag of takeout. Adora felt like she got the wind knocked out of her. She pressed her foot into the gravel, trying to focus on the crunch or the weight of her boot. Anything to keep her from floating off the ground. Catra looked at her amusedly as she placed a tender kiss on Finn's head.

"I finished my session and I decided to grab some takeout. I thought you two might be hungry, so I grabbed extra. Figured I could surprise you with dinner." Catra's voice turned soft and tentative. "I hope that's okay."

Adora grinned as she unlocked the door, never taking her eyes off Catra. "Of course, you know I never turn down free food." Adora joked, hoping to disguise how lovesick she felt at the idea that Catra had thought to surprise them.

Catra smirked. "Of course, that's what I was banking on, princess." She teased as she made her way past Adora and into the house.

Adora's stomach flip-flopped. *Now that's a nickname I haven't heard in a while*. Catra hadn't noticed the reaction, busy watching Finn attempt to go inside. Catra grabbed Finn by the back of their shirt before they could do that.

"Hey, remember to wipe your feet down before you go in, yeah? And go wash up before dinner." Finn dutifully wiped their feet and ran inside.

It felt like a normal Tuesday night. Like they still lived together and loved each other and just always did this. It felt *so* unbelievably good.

Adora turned to face Catra. "Seriously , thank you. If it weren't for you, we would probably be having peanut butter and jelly sandwiches tonight."She admitted with a small laugh.

Adora resisted the undeniable urge to kiss her, and instead grabbed Catra's free hand, rubbing circles with her thumb. She'd taken to doing that anytime she felt like her feelings were too big to contain in her body. Catra stared back at Adora, looking like she was trying to figure out a hard math problem or sing the alphabet song backward in her head. Adora held her stare, sure her curiosity was obvious in her expression.

After a moment, Catra's face cleared and turned soft. "PB&J isn't a bad deal. Come on, let's go inside before the food gets cold."She said as she tilted her chin towards the door. Instead of letting go of Adora's hand Catra tugged on it, dragging her inside. Her heart swelled.

Adora would keep her feelings to herself because having this~~C~~atra bringing take out, calling her *princess*, being a family again~~w~~as everything she needed, even if it wasn't everything she wanted. It would have to be enough.

Chapter End Notes

> I won't even lie, this chapter has some of my favorite lines from the whole fic, even though it isn't one of the bigger chapters regarding plot. And Finn is the most precious baby!Things are going to come to a HEAD in the nex~~t~~chapter and it will become very apparent how this will all wrap up... FOUR MORE ~~C~~HAPTERS ALL THAT'S IT!
>
> Also!Someone made a Spotify playlist for the fic y'all!It's really good and you can read about me screeching about it on this Twitter thread.
>
> This week I posted some other things y'all might want to check out!

I added a really fluff installment to the Superhero AU, essentially five times Catradora have their date interrupted and one time they finally get to go on a date. It stands on its own you dont need to read any of the other superhero AU fics to enjoy Dates and Delays.

If you like Catra when she is a meanie on the outside and softie on the inside and Adora when she is being very type A and oblivious, then Chairing if Caring is for you!(Y es they are in fact fighting about a chair, itll be fun promiseee).
If you want to see a long smuffy fic with Catradora in a friends with benefits situation, then By Any Other Name is your pick!
You know or read both thats also an option :D

Kudos and comments make me very very very very very verryyyyy HAPPY. Also, follow me on Twitter where I am starting up some interactive challenges!Currently , I have a twitter poll up on a few songs and I will do a Catradora fic based on that! So go vote if you are interested :)

Nextweek: Catra and Glimmer have their (long-awaited) wine night. In the past, Catra advises Glimmer on what to do about her crush on Bow.

A Corked Solution

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer have a wine night.

Catra advises Glimmer about Bow.

The unthinkable happens.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sometimes, she thought being estranged from Glimmer wasn't the worst thing to happen to her. Because now that they were good again, she had to deal with Glimmer in *her* apartment scouting through *her* bottles of wine as she looked for the good stuff. *Nosy bitch,* Catra grumbled internally. She was hunched over, practically on all fours rooting through the modest wine rack.

"It's been a long time since we've done this," Catra noted as Glimmer ignored her in favor of the alcohol selection. She crossed her arms and smirked lightly. "You know, we could've had our traditional girl's night if you hadn't thrown a temper tantrum about the divorce."

"We aren't going to talk about your love life until I have wine in my system. It's too much to handle sober." Glimmer muttered absent-mindedly as she waved a hand in Catra's direction.

"Not much of a love life to talk about since Starla." She groaned, sitting on the couch. She still had a clear view of a thieving Glimmer focusing like she was disarming a bomb, not picking between a malbec and a merlot.

She paused her perusal for a brief moment. "Yeah, we didn't really get a chance to talk about that did we?" Glimmer looked up from the two wine bottles in her hand to glance at Catra.

"Yeah, honestly don't know if I want to." Catra eyed her friend warily, sinking further into the cushion of precisely where she'd been dumped. *Poetic huh.* It had been almost four months since she and Starla broke up. She was well and truly over it.

"Suits me just fine." Glimmer shrugged flippantly but her eyes stayed on Catra's for a moment.

Catra rolled the corner of one of her throw pillows in her hand as she decided whether she even wanted to open *that* can of worms. "I do have one question for you though." She bit her bottom lip. "Why did you think Starla and I wouldn't pan out?" The comment Glimmer made all those months before still stuck with her and she was curious about what her friend saw.

Glimmer sat onto the ground with a small *oof* before putting down the two bottles and looking back up. She pressed her lips together as she contemplated what to say. "I mean there were a lot of things. For one, I've seen what you look like in love and it looks nothing like what you had with Starla. On top of that, I just thought you two were just too similar." Catra's head snapped to Glimmer as she echoed Scorpia's thoughts almost word for word. "Sure, you had similar artistic interests and that's great but you didn't *complement* each other. It never felt like you were particularly challenged or stimulated by her."

Catra's jaw dropped. "Shit. You were holding all that back?" She breathed, staring at Glimmer incredulously.

Glimmer preened. "See? I can be nice. I totally have a filter." She boasted as she got up and picked up the two bottles from the ground.

Catra scoffed as she rolled her eyes. "Only on very specific occasions. You're lucky I like you sparkles."

"Oooh, I love you too Catra." She cooed condescendingly . "Say , do you remember when we first started doing these, and Adora and Bow thought we would murder each other?" Glimmer looked positively gleeful remembering the anxiety their partners had the first time they announced that they would be hanging out one on one overnight.

She cackled as she thought of the stunts they'd pulled. "Remember that time we faked a fight right before we were going to hang, then drove off into the sunset before they could realize? T ruly unhinged Glim."

Glimmer sighed fondly. "It was some of our best work. I really thought Dor would call a wellness check or something."

"She probably didn't want us arrested." Catra pointed out. "I wonder if they ever figured out that this is all we do?" She looked around at the relatively low-key setup they had.

"What eat, drink wine, and talk mad shit about everyone? I don't think so. I think Bow has an idea. He snuck some painkillers into my overnight bag. He still looked a little nervous when I said goodbye to him though." Glimmer laughed.

"W ell I, for one, am glad we're doing our epic wine night again," Catra said. Glimmer grunted her agreement as she ducked down again to continue searching through the bottles, ignoring the two she'd previously picked out.

"Thank stars, a decent bottle!" Glimmer was holding up another two bottles of wine like trophies.

"Y ou're just moving the around there aren't that many to pick from." She jeered as she got of f the couch and picked up the wine glasses

on the table. "Besides, are you supposed to be drinking anyway? You said the last time we got together was *the last time*."

Glimmer's smile dimmed for a moment. "We're having more trouble than we first thought with the process." She admited softly. "Looks like we wont be able to get pregnant till next year."

Catra reached out and placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder, face utterly repentant. "Oh Glim, Im so sorry."

Glimmer shook her head as if chasing the sad thoughts away. She smiled brightly, although her eyes were suspiciously wet. "It's fine. We're just bummed out you know? We thought that we'd be able to start immediately and it just isnt as streamlined as we hoped. Well get there though. But the good news is that for now, I get to drink with you!" Glimmer finished uncorking the bottle and poured out a generous helping for both of them. "I cant drink wine with Adora, she has no taste. The wine at your house has really gone downhill since you left it." Glimmer commented conversationally.

Catra gave Glimmer a withering stare, taking her cue to drop the previous subject. "Im sorry that the end of my marriage has inconvenienced you, sparkles. My bad."

"You should be. Dealing with bad wine and Adora's cooking? It's a wonder I havent died!" Glimmer handed over Catra's glass.

"You know, some people would say that's insensitive." She took a drink from her glass, the wine heady as it swished in her mouth.

Glimmer snorted. "What is? Making fun of Adora? Or bringing up the fact that you arent together?"

Catra smirked. "Yes."

Gimmer threw a pillow at her and Catra laughed. "Well, Im done trying to be sensitive. You got sensitive Glimmer for over a year it's too tiring." She huf fed as she sat on the couch.

Catra leveled a stare at her. "Really? That was sensitive Glimmer? How are you even married to the cinnamon roll that is Bow."

"That's why you got sensitive Glimmer for a year instead of the three-month trial." Glimmer started sampling the charcuterie board Catra built out for them. "Speaking of your soon-to-be-ex-wife, when are those divorce papers getting delivered? You know, so I can bring out sensitive Glimmer again." She eyed Catra curiously .

Catra popped an olive in her mouth to avoid answering. *Ugh, why is everyone so interested in when we get divorced? Stars alive!*

"I don't know , ask Adora." She deflected. The divorce was well underway but she'd be damned if she spent her whole free evening discussing it.

Glimmer munched on a homemade dip. "Nope! Tried that months ago! She said she was expecting the paperwork from you then basically told me to drop dead." Catra's heart did a weird thing. "It's almost like both of you are avoiding getting divorced. I wonder why that might be?" Glimmer got so theatrical when she started drinking, even before the effects of the alcohol hit her.

"We aren't avoiding it. The judge is already involved. Our lawyers are negotiating the marital settlement." She stated each sentence like a report because that's what the divorce felt like right now. An academic exercise. Catra kept the process at arm's length and really only talked to her lawyer about it. She still refused to go to the hearings. "Maybe we don't talk about it every second of the day because we're trying to be friends?" She challenged.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Yeah, I got that one from Adora too. You can be friends and not be married you know. Exhibit A." Glimmer waived her arm between the two of them.

Catra raised an eyebrow. "I mean Glim, let's be real, you've always wanted to marry me." She preened performatively as she gestured towards herself. Glimmer blushed at the reference to her college

crush on Catra but otherwise kept her hard stare. Catra sighed. *This must be some overprotective bullshit.* Glimmer was always watching out for Adora, an annoying chihuahua barking at anything that went near the dumb blond golden retriever.

Fuck it.

"Look sparkles, I know Adora doesn't love me anymore I'm not trying to do anything other than be her friend. So, if this is some weird protecting Adora's heart bit you can relax." Catra leveled with her before taking a harder tone. "And I don't appreciate you trying to do that when we're having our girl time. You can threaten me some other day." She raised her glass in a salute, ready to move wine night forward with that bullshit out of the way.

Glimmer looked at her like she'd grown another head. "Wait. You mean to tell me that you think Adora *doesn't* love you anymore?" She enunciated every word slowly as if trying to make sense of them.

Catra felt uneasy. *This isn't where I thought this was going.*

"I mean obviously not. She said she only wanted to be friends. And like all the crap that happened while we were together." She waved her hand indicating it was self-explanatory.

Glimmer started cursing under her breath. She took a deep breath and a swig of wine. "Okay hold on. I'm still trying to process this. So, your version of events is what? You left Adora, she fell out of love, and now she wants to be platonic besties with you?" Glimmer sneered over her wine glass, swishing it from side to side.

Well, it sounds ridiculous when you say it like that, sparkles.

"No. Adora fell out of love with me *as evidenced by* the state of our marriage, I left because we both deserve better, and now we're trying to be friends for Finn." She listed off. Catra felt pretty confident that she was right.

"Did Adora say , out loud, the words Hey Catra I am not in love with you, but I want to be friends only for the purpose of not traumatizing our child"? Glimmer probed, her voice teetering close to panic. Her eyes were wide as she stared down Catra.

"I mean obviously not Glim! Adora's too nice to be upfront, that' s why she started hiding behind her work in the first place!" Catra runs her hands through her hair. "This feels like the seventh time someone has asked me that question." She stated as an afterthought.

Glimmer groaned and guzzled. Just like that, half the bottle of wine was gone, courtesy of Glimmer. She looked stressed out as if just sitting next to Catra was absorbing all of her energy .

"Because you clearly arent listening! If she didnt say that how can you possibly know how she's feeling"? She leaned back on the couch putting her hand on her head, pressing on her temples.

"She said she wanted to be friends Glimmer! What is there to understand"? Catra deflated as she pressed her lips together . "She doesnt want me. Not like I want her ."

"Ugh, Cat, you need to talk to *your wife*. This is ridiculous." Glimmer looked at Catra, some cross between sad and deeply annoyed. "Also, Im not trying to be an asshole here, but Catra you *left* and kept her at arms length. Got a girlfriend. In what world was Adora supposed to pick up that you are in any way interested with all that going on"?

Catra sputtered uselessly for a moment. Maybe Glimmer had a *very small point*.

After Catra stayed silent, Glimmer groaned aloud. "I honestly dont know what to do with both of you. I want to shake you till your teeth chatter. See if thatll knock some sense into you."

"That's not very nice of you, Glim." Catra wanted to push but she didnt because of Glimmer 's death glare.

"Did Adora tell you that she turned down that big promotion at work? The one for Bright Moon branch manager?" She needled, eyes trained on Catra's reaction.

Catra felt like she had cold water dumped all over her. "She didn't even tell me she got the promotion in the first place but that~~tha~~t can't possibly be true Glim. All she's ever wanted is the promotion."

Adora's job was the thing that made the rift between them the most obvious. She cared more about that promotion than she cared about being with Catra. She was *so* sure that Adora was going to take it that the thought of her saying no didn't even cross her mind.

Glimmer slammed her hand down on the arm of the couch. "Are you sure that's all Adora has ever wanted Catra?"

Catra glared at Glimmer.

"That doesn't necessarily have anything to do with *me*. There could be plenty of reasons why Adora turned down the promotion." She averted her gaze. *I just can't think of any reason she would.*

"You haven't talked to her about this, but I have, and believe me when I say that Adora turning down that promotion has at least something to do with you." Glimmer said beseechingly . Catra stared at Glimmer, indecision tearing through her.

Glimmer could be making a mountain out of a molehill. She would look like an idiot if she showed up at Adora's house this late at night. It probably had nothing to do with her, really. For a moment, she considered driving to Adora and settling the roaring questions in her mind. She shook her head.

"Glim here's what we're going to do. We're going to forget about the fact that I'm going to be a divorced woman soon. We're going to forget about the fact that you and Bow aren't pregnant yet. We're going to let go of our real-world problems and just watch some trashy television. Deal?" She offered to her friend.

She'd been drinking for the better part of an hour. She wasn't going to just show up half-cocked at Adora's house and abandon her friend. She'd ask Adora about it the next time she saw her and put an end to whatever false hope Glimmer was feeding her.

Glimmer stared her down for a moment then smiled wide. "I thought you'd never ask. This is why you're my favorite Catra." She stood from her seat to grab the wine opener and started removing the cork from the second bottle.

"You're my favorite too, sparkles." Tonight, she was going to let loose and forget about Adora and that damn job offer.

Then

"Why are you making that face?" Catra asked as she put down her tray and sat across from Glimmer. She looked like she licked a lemon, eyes cold and distant with a far-off gaze that told Catra she was anywhere but in the cafeteria right now.

Her eyes snapped to Catra. "What face? I'm not making a face." She said unconvincingly.

Catra's eyes followed where Glimmer was staring right at Bow and Perfuma across the cafeteria. Glimmer's eye tightened as Bow leaned in closer, laughing at something Perfuma said while she twirled a loose lock of hair between her fingers.

"Huh. I see. You're pouting over pretty boy. Oh, sparkles are you going to go drag him over here?" She teased as she picked up the bruised apple on her tray. She reconsidered and put it back down.

Glimmer stared for a moment longer before turning her attention to Catra. "No Catra. I'm not staring at Bow, everything is *fine*, and I *don't* want your sass today." She snapped, glaring down at the table.

"You never want my sass, it's part of why we're friends." Glimmer's lips twitched slightly at that, but her eyes went back to Bow. Catra leaned forward. "Okay, seriously, what's the deal with you and Bow?"

"What do you mean?" She eyes Catra wearily.

"Are you dating or friends or?" She raised her eyebrow as she trailed off. Glimmer blushed furiously.

"We aren't dating. Yet. I don't know maybe never." She flopped forward sighing, defeated.

Catra leaned forward with an exasperated sigh of her own. "Okay, you need to tell me what's going through your head because Adora has the emotional intelligence of a peanut and won't be picking up on these sad bi-girl vibes you're projecting out to the world." She sighed and picked up her fork. "I'll give you ten minutes of non-judgmental listening starting now." She proposed as she rolled her noodles.

Catra's eyes widen as the floodgates open, Glimmer spilling her guts onto the table.

"We're such good friends, but it feels like something more from my end. But I can't read him!" She groaned as she tugged on a piece of her short hair. "He's just so friendly with everyone and he's so much happier and more himself now. He practically glows with self-confidence. And everyone can tell. I think I might love him. As more than friends." Glimmer looked up expectantly taking deep breaths as if she'd run a marathon.

Catra blinked slowly. "Okay, that can be a very challenging position to be in. What do you think you want to do?" She asked, using her rarely exercised neutral tone. This was going to be so difficult.

Glimmer tossed her a panicked look. "I don't know! What if I'm wrong and it's all me and he just stops being friends with me? I don't know

what Id do without him."She covered her face with her hands and groaned.

Catra fixed her with a hard stare. "Look Glimmer , Bow's a sweet guy. Even if he wasnt interested, which Im not saying he isnt, he wouldnt drop you because of that. Bow's dependable and loyal. He always makes efforts for his friends, and he does more for you than everyone else combined. I think the risk is negligible."

She mulled over Catra's words for a moment. "Okay , Ill think about it."She allowed. She then leaned forward putting her head in her hand. "What about you and Adora?"

Catra rolled her eyes waving her hand dismissively. "There is no me and Adora. Again, Adora has the emotional intelligence of a peanut. If she liked me, she wouldve just said it at some point. So, she doesnt."Catra' s logic was flawless. She'd known Adora since they were children and there was no way Adora would be able to keep a crush a secret from Catra for very long.

"W ait. So you *do* like Adora?"Glimmer asked, delighted as she put her hands down on the table. Catra was startled, realizing what she just admitted. She couldnt believe she just got played by *Glimmer* of all people.

"Of course, I like Adora. I thought you knew!"She pointed an accusing finger at her.

"No Catra I didnt!This is great!Y ou guys would make such cute babies, Im so excited!"Glimmer practically bounced in her seat, eyes wide with excitement.

She shook her head at her friend, popping her bubble. "W oah slow down there, Adora and I will only ever be best friends. I cant cross that line with her."She looked around for any of their other friends. "And could you please keep your voice down!"She hissed.

Glimmer ignored her.

"Why do you think you can't cross that line? Because maybe she doesn't feel the same way and it would make your friendship weird"? Glimmer echoed her own words back at Catra, grinning victoriously as if she proved some point. She definitely *didn't*.

"Y es but it's different with us! Adora really doesn't like me like that." She grumbled. Bow was clearly into Glimmer he made big moony eyes at her.

"Oh Catra, like a wise woman once said *the risk to your friendship is negligible*." Glimmer smirked openly flicking Catra' s forehead.

"I hate you. Don't tell anyone about this." She threatened, getting up and towering over Glimmer's short frame. Glimmer leaned back rolling her eyes.

"Don't worry I won't. Y ou're my favorite too Cat." She also stood and walked with Catra. "Y ou have a class in the rec hall now, right? Let' s get moving." They bustled out of the cafeteria, mutual secrets in tow .

Now

Catra tried to hold in her laugh as she watched Glimmer striding into the restaurant from the corner of her eye. Glimmer was wearing heavily shaded sunglasses, looking incredibly groggy. Bow sat at a table waiting for them to start brunch. He gave a deep sigh and a smile to his wife when he saw her.

"So, she' s returned in one piece"? He teased, looking over Glimmer's general state.

"More or less." Catra intimated. They made quick work of ordering off the menu before settling more deeply into their chairs. Glimmer kept the sunglasses on even though they were seated indoors and Bow kept looking between them like that would give him a better clue to what went on than just them being hungover .

"So will you tell me what you two were up to?" Bow asked as he curiously glanced at them. Glimmer and Catra held eye contact and broke out in a laugh.

"Not a chance babe." Glimmer pat Bow's lap and gave him a kiss on the cheek in consolation.

"Yeah, sorry Bow, our lips are sealed," Catra confirmed, even miming zipping her lips and tossing the key.

Bow rolled his eyes, grabbing plates as the waitress started dropping off plates. "You aren't supposed to keep secrets from your husband and best friends." Bow grumbled good-naturedly, digging into his pancakes.

"Still not telling you." Catra drowned her waffles in blueberry maple syrup and butter. She was sure it would help with the hangover.

"So what did you do with your night?" Glimmer asked her husband.

Bow lit up, talking about his friend who's remodeling a boat. Halfway through his retelling Catra thought it might be Sebastian but to be honest, she didn't really want to know. Her phone rang. She glanced down and saw Adora's name flash on her phone. She couldn't help but smile.

"Hold on one second I need to take this." Glimmer gave her a knowing stare as she picked up the phone. Catra flipped her off. "Hey Dor, you'll never guess"—

Catra was cut off by the most panicked she'd ever heard Adora. "Catra. I lost them. I can't find them. I don't know where they went, I just don't know how this happened!" Adora sounded like she wasn't quite breathing, the sound of air rushing jagged and unnatural.

Catra stilled, all her muscles tensing involuntarily at Adora's distress. "Adora what are you talking about? Slow down." She asked trying to keep her voice even.

Glimmer and Bow both stared at her with concern, the clatter of silverware halting. Catra could feel panic rising in her own chest as she waited for Adora to make some sense.

"Finn! I can't find them. We're at the aquarium. Please come. I don't know what else to do." Catra can barely make the words over Adora's full-throated sobs. Catra's heart seized in her chest. *Finn*. Nothing could be worse than this, her baby could be anywhere—

"I'm with Bow and Glimmer I'll have them drive me. Hang tight Adora, we'll be right there." She promised raggedly. As if she could be anywhere else than looking for her kid.

She could hear Adora's sniffles as she tried to collect herself. "Okay. Call me when you get here, I'll call you if I find them." The line went dead immediately.

"Finn's gone missing in the aquarium, can you please give me a ride there?" Catra said the words, but her lips felt numb. Her stomach turned violently, already rejecting the few bites of food she'd had.

Glimmer let out a gasp and reached out to grab Catra's hand clutching it tightly. "Catra of course we're going with you."

Bow pulled out a few bills, dumping them on the table along with their half-eaten breakfast. They all but ran to the car, Glimmer sitting next to Catra in the back, rubbing her shoulder silently. Catra curled up in the back seat of Bow's car, hoping against hope that Finn was okay.

Chapter End Notes

> I am super swamped and will be working all weekend which means I'm going to post this now before I get buried under a mountain of work.
>
> Sooo it's a cliffhanger folks. Sorry about that. Y'all are going to have to cope until next week.

I enjoyed writing all of the Glitra friendship here, and Catra finally knows about the promotion! Although obviously there are more pressing concerns ATM. Obviously, I won't let anything happen to Finn. Let me know your thoughts (if yelling at me will make you feel better go for it lol).

I FINALLY finished drafting the last chapter , so everything is written down, nothing will stand in our way folks! THREE. CHAPTERS. LEFT.

As always, kudos and comments are super dooper appreciated! Also follow me on Twitter.

A few days ago I posted my first canon fic, Bloodstained Mark it's short and angsty , I'd love if y'all showed it some love (as my resident angst squad).

Next week: Catra and Adora look for Finn. In the past, Finn gets adopted.

I'm now going to hide from the pitchforks! Until next week!

A Lost Shark

Chapter Summary

The Best Friend Squad looks for Finn.

Adora and Catra bring Finn home for the first time.

Adora and Catra bring Finn home to rest.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We locked down the aquarium, right?" Adora's voice carried over the hurried conversation of the employees. She knew she already asked this, but she wanted to double-check. Again.

The man nodded, only a touch frustrated. "Yes, ma'am we closed all the exits, if they are here we will find them." The employee closest to her assured her. She flexed her toes in her sneakers, quashing the need to bounce her leg.

"But what if they aren't here? What am I going to do if I can't find them?" Adora was mostly talking to herself at this point. She felt close to tears for what felt like the millionth time that day. Once again, she had no idea how she lost sight of Finn for one crucial moment, and she couldn't help but hate herself for it.

"Adora, Finn loves the aquarium. Chances are they're somewhere in here and haven't heard anyone calling them. We'll find them." Netossa consoled putting a hand on Adora's shoulder and squeezing lightly. A few of the other employees who knew Finn nodded along.

Adora's head whipped towards the entrance as she heard Catra yelling, her voice pitched high and worried over all the chaos. "I know asshole, that's my kid that's lost in there, now verify whatever you

need to and fucking let me in."Catra looked about ready to bowl over the security guard with Bow and Glimmer close behind.

"Catra?"Adora called out loudly , flat out ignoring the employees who huddled around her as she made a beeline to the barricade currently closing the aquarium to new visitors. "I'm so glad you're here."Adora then glanced at the guard. "Please let them in, they're family ."

The security guard quickly lifted the barricade, clearly recognizing Adora as the mother of the lost child. The three of them rushed forward towards Adora, but she only had eyes for Catra who looked pale, eyes tight with worry. Adora hugged her tightly to her chest and fell apart.

"I'm so sorry I swear I was paying attention to them, I looked up for one moment to look at the aquarium map and they were gone." Adora couldn't keep herself together any longer , her knees wobbling as she blubbered into Catra's shoulder.

"I know , this isn't your fault. They're a spry kid. It' s okay. We're going to find them, Dor . I swear."She rubbed soothing circles into Adora' s back, her own voice shaking.

"You're right. I'm sorry I just—I don't know how to deal with this alone."Adora admitted. She slowly let go of Catra, taking a step back to give her space.

Glimmer reached for her and gave her hand a light squeeze. "You don't have to do it alone. We're all going to work together to find Finn."Glimmer chimed in. Adora led them back to the employees that talked to her earlier.

"This is Finn' s mother, Catra, and our friends, Glimmer and Bow." Adora introduced curtly, more worried about what the next steps were to find her baby.

"What have you been doing and what can we do to help find them?" Catra asked, her words almost running together from how fast she

was speaking.

The group of employees looked at each other. "We locked down the aquarium and we have employees looking for Finn in every quadrant of the aquarium. We also have a description of them and their name put on our entrance and exit screens in case someone's seen them." One of the senior employees explained. "It would be helpful for you four to look for them. They might be hiding, scared that so many people are looking for them. A familiar voice might be what's needed to coax them out of hiding."

"Of course, let's start looking then." Catra urged, looking at Adora with wide eyes.

She nodded quickly, grabbing a pair of the employee walkie-talkies and giving one to Glimmer. "Bow, Glim, start on the far side where the bigger fish tanks are, Catra and I will start at the dolphin tank. If we dont find them, well end up meeting in the middle." Adora swallowed the lump in her throat as she thought of the possibility of not finding Finn.

"On it." Glimmer and Bow walked at a quick pace in the right direction. Adora grabbed Catra's hand and led her towards the dolphin tank, taking big steps. Catra hustled beside her, gripping her tightly.

They stayed mostly silent, looking around the tanks and other visitors searching out any mop of blonde hair.

Adora jumped when she felt her phone ring. She pulled it out quickly, hoping that it would be some sign of Finn. Instead, Frosta's work phone number was on her screen.

She sighed, disappointed. "It's just work." Adora declined the call, letting it go to voicemail.

"You dont have to get that?" Catra asked cautiously.

Adora turned to glance at Catra sharply pressing her lips together. "Catra what are talking about?" She couldn't help how harshly her tone was. "There's nothing more important than Finn right now. Whatever it is, I'll deal with it later."

"You're right, sorry." Catra apologized awkwardly. She looked like she wanted to ask something, but she shook her head and looked away from Adora. Guilt started welling up in Adora's chest.

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have snapped at you." She sighed grabbing one of her own wrists in her hand.

"It's fine, we're the definition of high-strung right now." Catra dismissed with a wave of her hand. She was quiet for a moment. "What are we going to do if we can't find them?" She gave voice to the fear that ran nonstop through Adora's mind.

"We can't afford to think like that right now Cat. We need to try to put our heads together on this. Finn's a smart kid they wouldn't just walk away with a stranger." She reasoned, hoping to reassure not only Catra but also herself.

That Finn was smart as a whip and highly distrustful of strangers were two of the only facts Adora found comforting as of late.

Catra tapped Adora's shoulder quickly, leaving her hand there after she caught Adora's attention. "Look, we're going about this all wrong," she said looking back at Adora.

Adora could feel her brow furrowing, not sure what Catra meant. "What are you getting at?" She asked.

Catra gestured between them as if the answer was obvious. "We're Finn's mothers. We know them best. Instead of trying to look around randomly, let's think about what we know about them. Where would they go?" She posed the question aloud. Adora continued to scan the area as she mentally retraced their steps from earlier in the day.

“Well, we started with petting the sting rays because they had an employee set up there at like noon. We saw the jellyfishes, the penguins, the tropical tank.” She put a hand on her forehead as if willing the memories forward with her touch.

“Did you see Swift Wind?” She asked, the last of Finn’s favorite aquarium activities.

“I mean we looked but he wasn’t in his tank. We asked one of the employees and he has an injury on his tail, so they put him somewhere else.” Adora’s eyes widened in realization at the same time as Catra.

“Adora. That’s it!” She yelled out, looking sure of herself for the first time that day.

“You’re right! Finn must be looking for Swift Wind! If we find Swift Wind, maybe that’ll lead us to Finn!” Adora beamed, so excited to have their first real lead on finding Finn.

They walked up to the first employee they found—thankfully it was Netossa.

“We need to know where Swift Wind is. You know, that old nurse shark Finn loves so much.” Adora explained when she saw a look of confusion cloud Netossa’s face.

“He’s in one of the rehab tanks. That area is restricted from visitors.” She supplied, looking between the two of them.

“We think Finn might have snuck in looking for him. Can we check the area? Please?” Catra asked, an edge of desperation creeping into her question.

“Of course. Let me get you there.” Netossa quickly walked them through a door with a large “employees only” sign, taking a few turns until they could see a few smaller tanks with some awful-looking fish and other aquatic animals.

"Finn! Baby , it's your moms, please come out if you're here." Catra was clearly trying to use her soothing voice, but her frayed nerves betrayed her. She gripped Adora's hand tightly as she looked around for any signs of Finn. Everything was dead quiet.

"Finnie please if you're here it' s going to be okay, but you have to come out now." Adora tried, her eyes scanning the poorly lit area desperately. She felt dread pooling in her stomach if Finn wasn't here, she really had no idea where to find them.

She heard a sniffle from behind her. Adora whipped around and saw a blue shoe peeking out from behind an old box.

Adora crouched down and leaned forward. "Finn?" She breathed out. Slowly, Finn's wild hair peeked out from behind their hiding place and Adora felt her body melting in relief. She collapsed onto the ground, pulling Finn into her arms. Soon Catra joined them, both mothers touching Finn's head, their arms, making sure they were okay.

"Oh Finn, I'm so glad you're here." Catra pressed kisses into their hair. Adora could see the tears running freely down her cheeks.

"I'm sorry! I wasn't trying to run away! I just wanted to find Swift Wind to make sure he was okay." Finn' s voice was tremulous. Adora held them tighter to her, wanting to just smush them into her chest, never letting go.

"Did you know we were looking for you bud?" Adora asked, voice wet with tears.

Adora could feel Finn's hesitant nod on her shoulder. "Y eah, but everyone was yelling. I didn't want to be in trouble." They confided as if it was a secret, fear clear in their voice. They looked up at their moms, clearly spooked by the whole ordeal.

"Y ou aren't in trouble right now . We're going home, okay? It' s been a long day for all of us." She soothed, rubbing Finn' s back. Adora felt

like she'd been run over by a truck now that the adrenaline was finally leaving her body.

She glanced over Finn's head to Catra, both of them crying over their newly found child.

Then

The paperwork took longer than forever, and Adora displayed herculean strength when she kept her cool every time she and Catra got side-eyed by a case manager for being *one of those couples* but it would all be worth it if things went well today.

Today, they got to take their kid home. Finn. They had met the small kid a few weeks ago and it was love at first sight. It felt like they were already Finn's family and Adora didn't know what she'd do if the adoption fell through.

Catra was tearing through the house, pacing, making sure all the outlets and cabinets were babyproof, and moving anything dangerous above hip height. She had a manic look in her eyes.

"Dor , what if they don't want to give them to us? What if something goes wrong and—" Catra stopped mid-thought, a nauseous look crossing her face. Adora could sympathize. She was holding it together, but not by much.

"Love, we've been over the paperwork at least thirty times and everything looks good. Even the social worker said so. We're ready for anything, you'll see." She says it to reassure herself as much as to reassure Catra.

Catra let out a small whimper before she pressed her lips together, silencing any further sound.

Her beautiful eyes turn to Adora, seeking comfort. "What if I'm not a good mom Dora? Kids love you, but I'm not like that."

Catra had always been uneasy around small children while Adora loved to roughhouse with them.

Adora quieted Catra with a kiss. It's a kiss she felt down to her bones. This was her wife and soon they were both going to take care of a kid together. It was a literal dream come true.

"You know, at first, I was surprised when you brought up having kids. You never seemed to like them, and to be honest, I wasn't even sure that you were ever going to want them."Adora commented. She felt relieved that Catra wanted the same thing she did. Catra eyed her wife, unsure where this conversation was heading. "But you were so sure and passionate that you wanted to raise kid. That you wanted to provide stability and a home. And I'm in awe that I get to share all of that with you Cat. I have no doubt that we can figure this out together."

Catra gave her a fond look. "You're such a sap."

"Besides, you got along amazingly with Finn in the supervised visits we had. If anything, I'm going to have to worry about being the odd one out!"

Catra cracked a smile at that because it was true. The first time they met, Finn walked straight up to Catra and with a very serious face, pointed at a book they were holding indicating they wanted help reading. And by reading, they just pointed at pictures, mostly babbling, and occasionally getting the right word for what was depicted. Catra cheered loudly when that happened, to Finn's great amusement.

"Finn's going to be the luckiest kid because they're going to have you in their corner. Take it from someone whose been supported by you their whole life, there is no better feeling."She tucked an errant curl behind Catra's ear.

"Stop it, dummy."She blushed as she buried her head into Adora's neck. *Success*.

"And it's not just us. Our parents are taking turns to visit in the next few weeks to help and all our friends are almost as excited as we are to get to know Finn. They are going to have so much love they aren't going to know what to do with it."

It won't be anything like me growing up, although she doesn't say that to Catra.

"I'm so happy to be doing this with you." Catra still hid in Adora's neck, her warm breath tickling Adora. She melted at the words, pulling Catra tighter into her chest. "I can't imagine anyone I'd rather have by my side for all of this."

The process was daunting, but once they decided they wanted to adopt, Catra had been on a warpath, taking out every obstacle in their way. It was kind of amazing.

"Hey, wanna know something?" Catra peeked out from Adora's neck, suspicious of the grin Adora couldn't stop on her face.

"What?" Catra said suspiciously.

"You are gonna be a MILF now!" Catra snorted then groaned pushing Adora away.

"God, you're the worst why did I marry you!" Her squeaky laugh betrayed that she wasn't actually annoyed.

"Because you love me." Adora wiggled her eyebrows for good measure. Catra rolled her eyes but grabbed Adora's hand, running her thumb over it. Before Catra could answer, a sharp ringing pierced their good mood and suddenly everything tensed again.

Adora looked at the contact for the social worker lighting up her screen. She answered the phone as she looked at Catra, holding her breath. She smiled as she listened to the woman on the line. It was time. They were bringing Finn home.

Now

The relief they all felt was present like a fourth person sitting in the car. Adora felt exhausted and boneless, continually glancing at Finn through the rearview mirror. Catra opted to sit next to them, practically smothering them in hugs as Adora drove them all to her house.

"Finn, next time you want to do something like that you need to talk with one of your moms okay?" Catra murmured as she rubbed her hand up and down their arm.

"I know . I just wanted to check on Swift Wind really quick and Mermista told me before that the sick sharks get put in the back. I didn't want them to say no." Finn explained, looking down at their shoes.

Catra breathed in sharply through her nose, containing her anger. "I understand that Finn, but your safety comes first. Sometimes we can't do the things we want or have the things we want just because we want them." Catra' s eyes briefly found Adora's eyes in the rearview mirror, although she couldn't imagine why . "You can't compromise your safety like that. Promise that next time you're going to talk with an adult?"

"I promise." Finn nodded very seriously , still looking down.

Catra wrapped Finn up in her arms again. Adora's gut twinged with longing to hold her kid.

"Okay good, now are you hungry?" She asked.

"Yes! I want pizza!" Their eyes are bright at the prospect of food. Adora grinned as she parked in the driveway.

"Okay , well order pizza now , let's get out of the car. You head up to the shower straight away alright? You smell like fish sticks." Adora

made a face scrunching up her nose and mouth in an exaggerated fashion. It made Finn giggle and that was everything.

Finn bounded towards the door and Adora followed until she felt Catra pull her back. She shot her a questioning look. Catra swallowed hard.

"Can I stay? I just" Catra's eyes filled with tears again as she took a shuddering breath. "I don't want to let them out of my sight today."

"Of course, Cat. You're always welcome. I would never keep you from them, especially after something like this." She soothed while offering her a smile.

Adora opened the door and watched Finn climb up the stairs. She sighed watching them go, her stomach tightening as they got out of sight. She felt Catra squeeze her shoulder.

"I know." Catra sighed. A quiet understanding filled the two words.

The worst-case scenario was still at the forefront of Adora's mind.

"I love them so much, Cat. I can't imagine what I would've done if something happened to them on my watch."

Catra reached out and put a comforting hand on her shoulder. "Hey, it's okay they're fine. It was just a scare, and we'll figure out how to put it behind us." It was Catra's turn to soothe Adora it seemed.

"Yeah." She gave Catra a cautious glance. "When you said you wanted to stay you meant the night right?"

She slowly nodded, looking away and dropping her hand as she did so. "Yeah. I don't think I'll be able to sleep anyways but at least here I can look at them all night if I want to." She explained, a determined look filtering onto her face.

"Okay, mama bear." Adora joked, bumping her fist gently against Catra's shoulder. "We could put them in the middle of the bed?" She

suggested, terrified of breaking the understanding between them but not knowing how else they were both meant to stay with Finn all night.

A shadow of something crossed Catra's face, too fast for Adora to interpret. "Yeah, that's fine."

Adora heard the doorbell for the pizza, she stepped back from Catra and got it. Almost like Finn was listening for it, they ran down cheering as Adora returned with the boxes.

"I think this is a cuddle puddle type of night don't you think Finn?" Adora asked while serving the pizza on disposable plates.

Finn perked up at that, although they tried to hide it. "In mom's bed?" They clarified, looking between their parents.

Adora took the lead and nodded. "Yeah bud, let's hang out for a bit and go to sleep there. Pizza first though."She added.

Finn happily munched away on pizza and after watching a movie they fell asleep. Adora carefully lifted them into her arms trying not to wake them. She could feel their eyelashes flutter briefly when she moved them, but they stayed limp in her grasp. Catra followed behind her closely as they climbed the stairs. When they get to her room, Catra pulled the sheets down so Adora could put Finn in the smack dab center of the bed.

"I can get you some clean clothes to borrow if you give me a second,"Adora whispered to Catra, careful to not disturb the sleeping child in the room. She nodded.

Adora carefully picked out a nondescript white shirt and black shorts. She picked up something similar for herself, making sure to cover more skin than she usually did for sleep. She handed the soft clothes to Catra and gestured to where Catra knew the bathroom to be.

She scooted in behind Finn facing where Catra would be whenever she was done changing. A few moments later Adora heard her quietly padding to her side of the bed. Both their eyes were glued to the kid between them.

"I don't know how I'm ever letting them get further than five feet from me at any given time." Catra sighed, hand reaching out to brush a stray hair off of Finn's face.

"I'm thinking we should invest in an ankle monitor to avoid another jailbreak," Adora whispered conspiratorially, trying to bring a smile out of Catra. It worked for the most part, although she tried to hide it with an eye roll.

"Honestly, you're joking but it would solve a lot of our problems today." She countered. The atmosphere between them sobered as they glanced at the sleeping figure lying between them.

"We have them here Catra. They're safe and we'll keep them that way alright?" She tried to catch Catra's eyes again. "And I'm sorry. I can't believe it didn't occur to me earlier that Finn might be looking for Swift Wind, I was just so panicked."

Catra made a noise of general disapproval. "Stop apologizing for that. It could've happened to anyone." She pointed out, her split eyes boring into Adora's blue ones.

"If I had thought of that, I could have found them, and then you wouldn't have even been scared at all I could have just told you after." Adora could hear her guilt reflected in her tone as she mumbled mostly to herself.

"You don't have to carry everything on your own Adora." She chastised. "Especially when it has to do with Finn. You absolutely had to call me for this."

For a moment, Catra's hand crept passed Finn as if she was going to touch Adora but then it stopped midair and returned to Finn's hair.

It was probably for the best that Catra didn't touch her if the way Adora's heart started thudding was any indication.

"I didn't know what else to do, but I knew it would be better if you were there." She confessed, hoping it wouldn't be too much. Calling Catra had been just as much about her own comfort as it had been about finding Finn.

"We figured it out together Dora. It's what we do." Catra said so simply like it was just a fact of life.

"Thank you for today. I owe you so much Catra." She owed Catra for every good thing that had come into her life, most of all Finn.

Catra scoffed her gaze narrowed. "You don't owe me a thing." She softened as she looked down at Finn. "Thanks for letting me stay here with Finn." She replied easily, burrowing further into the covers. The sight of her on what used to be her side of the bed squeezed at Adora's heart.

"Anytime Cat." It didn't take long for Adora to drift to sleep, lulled by the breathing of the two most important people on Etheria.

Chapter End Notes

Finn is safe! And I think, all things considered, this chapter could have been a lot angstier! We are at the home stretch folks, what do you think is going to happen come morning? Let me know!

I posted two things since the last update:
This one is for the folks who are 18 and up and interested in explicit content (this is from the By Any Other Name Universe): Take All Myself
This one is for Superhero AU/Masks and Mistakes Universe fans, the second arc starts now: Disguises and Destruction

(Also I may or may not post something in a few hours. I haven't decided yet but y'all have been alerted).

As always, kudos and comments keep me pushing forward (especially as I get the final few edits together for this fic). Also follow me on Twitter itll be fun I promise.

Next week: The last time we see Catra's POV in this fic! We have two. chapters. left.

A Crashing Reality

Chapter Summary

The family has breakfast.

Catra and Adora play at recess.

Catra goes to Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra slowly woke up, feeling some sunlight peep in from the window facing the backyard. She squinted against the streams of harsh light, turning her head. Adora always forgot to close the blinds fully. As she opened her eyes, she could feel something warm settle over her hip. She looked down to see Finn spread out over the entirety of the bed.

Finn had tossed one of their legs over her while their head somehow ended up on Adora's stomach, completely horizontal. Catra could feel the residual relief lap up over her as she looked at Finn. They were such a wriggly kid when they slept.

She watched her two bedmates from the safety of the covers. Both Finn and Adora were uncovered, their legs sprawled in opposite directions and the covers mangled between them. When you looked at how the two of them slept, two identical sprawled-out hurricanes, it was hard to believe they weren't biologically related.

Adora looked so rumpled and soft while sleeping, her mouth half opened as she breathed deeply, the ends of her exhalations moving some of the flyaway hairs in front of her face. Her whole body was relaxed, a far cry from yesterday when she was wound tight like a coiled snake.

Catra couldnt help the pang in her chest when she looked at her . Not for the first time since last night, she thought about how this was likely the last time she would ever share a bed with her wife. She wasnt sure if replacing the memory of the last time they slept in the same bedfacing away from each other , a frigid distance of what felt like miles between themfelt healing or if it was just sad.

She pushed the thought away as she noticed Adora start moving into the beginnings of a stretch as she pushed one of her arms over her head. Suddenly Adora's blue eyes opened and she felt as if she was the center of the universe for the way her blue eyes focused on her. She smiled softly, looking as if she awoke from a good dream.

"Good morning."She of fered quietly , scratching at her scalp in a mindless way. "Did you sleep well?"

She gave her a smile in return, tapping on Finn's leg, which was still hooked over hers. "I got to keep my part of the covers which is always a success when Finn's involved."She sidestepped Adora's actual question.

"That's true."Adora lowered her gaze to where Finn slept soundly on her torso, a fond smile creeping over her face. She ran her fingers through their hair softly, careful not to wake them.

"I'm never going to let them live this down when they are grown. Im going to tell every single partner they have that they cant be trusted in aquariums."She whispered, feeling comfortable enough to joke about the terrible time they had yesterday.

Catra could clearly imagine it too, an older Adora teasing a teenage or young adult Finn while they begged Catra to intercede on their behalf and reign in their mom. Her smile at the image dimmed when she realized she wouldnt be there for that conversation.Finn would likely introduce their partner to her and Adora separately. There'd be some other woman there smiling indulgently as Finn sighed at their mothers antics.

Adora could sense the shift in Catra, staying quiet as she observed her. "You alright there?" She tried, cautiously eyeing her as she tried to remain still to not wake up the lightly snoring child in her lap.

Catra shook her head, trying to dispel the odd mood she found herself in this morning. "I think I'm just feeling weird after everything yesterday. It was a lot." She hedged.

Adora relaxed again, still thrumming her fingers through Finn's hair. "Definitely. I think it'll take a few days for all of us to come down from everything that happened."

"I need to leave soon it's s" Catra glanced down at her watch "almost one in the afternoon. Damn, we slept a lot."

"It's the adrenaline, puts you out after." Adora seemed to struggle with something for a moment. "Do you want some breakfast before you go?" She gives Catra a shy smile she knows well she always pulls it out when she thinks she can convince Catra to see things her way.

"Are you asking me to cook so you can have something besides cereal or toast?" Catra teased gently, poking Adora's forehead.

"I can make some food you know I'm a functional adult." She huffed but her eyes creased with her smile.

Catra noticed Finn peeking one of their eyes open and then closing it again. "Finn what do you think of mom's cooking?" She asked, knowing they would be on her side. Finn opened both eyes and looked up at Adora, already suppressing a giggle. They pat their pillow Adora's torso consolingly.

"Mom tries really hard which is important." They supply helpfully with a wide grin on their face.

Adora lays back with a dramatic groan. "I'm constantly slandered by my own family. When will the betrayal end?" She pulled Finn up into

her arms and tickled them, pulling a cute giggle from their kid. Catra doesn't pay attention to their play fight, her heart still caught in her throat from Adora's casual use of the word *family*. Wasn't that what she'd been missing the most?

She shakes her head at their play fight but mostly at herself. "No need to fight children, I'll cook and we can eat together before I head out."

Finn cheered, getting up to run down the stairs, Adora hot on their heels. For a moment she's alone on the bed she used to sleep on every night.

Adora's head popped back into view leaning back to peek in through the door frame. "I'll get Finn dressed and you can just meet us downstairs in the kitchen alright?" One of Adora's dimples flashed as she smiled, and she was gone again, not waiting for a reply.

There and then Catra decide that the most difficult part of this afternoon was not that it felt uncomfortable~~it's~~ that it wasn't.

Then

I hate Octavia so much. Catra sat on the edge of the playground watching the other kids play. *Recess is supposed to be fun, but it sucks now that Octavia's class is here too.* Octavia always made fun of her. She said that Catra's hair was ugly, her eyes were weird, and that her food smelled funny.

Before it was only during lunch and after school, but now Octavia and her friends were always around during recess too. It was the worst! Octavia had just shoved her to the ground and told her she wasn't allowed on the playground until she was done with it.

Catra stared forlornly at the ground wondering how life could get any worse.

She heard a whisper. "Octavia is a big meanie sometimes." She looked up at the girl who was speaking to her. She had straw-colored hair and big blue eyes. She crouched down and extended her hand, offering to help Catra up.

Catra wanted none of that. "I dont need your help." She said loftily, getting up while trying to hide the tremble of her lower lip. The girl didnt seem to mind.

"I'm Adora! Do you want to play?" Adora looked earnest, bright eyes begging her to play along.

Catra was still afraid. "I cant. Octavia's there." She muttered grudgingly.

"So?" The blonde girl shrugged. "We dont have to play with her we can just play us two."

"She's always mean to me at lunch. I hate that we have recess together." She complained. She looked down at the ground, tears stinging her eyes. "Octavia will push me again if I go to the playground."

Catra expected Adora to turn around and leave. *Everybody* was afraid of Octavia. That is not what the blonde did.

"We can have our own fun here!" She chirped, blue eyes never leaving her face.

Catra rubbed her own arm. "But what if Octavia comes back here?" She tried not to betray how helpless she felt.

"You look out for me, and I look out for you," Adora said simply like that was the solution to all their problems. "Nothing really bad can happen as long as we stick together."

She didnt believe this girl. "You promise?" She asked, hope glimmering on the edges of the words.

The girl's smile was blinding. "I promise."

She stood up and eyes the girl for a moment. *Idon't really want to sit in this corner all by myself anyways.*

"What' s your name?" She asked.

"Adora. I already said it silly ." She beamed at being asked her name even though Catra hadnt paid attention when she introduced herself.

"I'm Catra."

"Nice to meet you Catra. Y our eyes are cool." She stared at one and then the other.

"Octavia said that they were weird." She grumbled.

Adora reached out and gently touched one of the curls on Catra's head. "Octavia is just a meanie," Adora whispered the word again so that the teachers couldnt hear her . "My favorite is cops and robbers so we can play that one first."

Catra let Adora drag her to play.

Now

Catra lingered through a board game after their late breakfast, getting to her apartment way later than she intended.

Walking away from Adora and Finn felt worse than it usually did like she was leaving behind a piece of herself inside the house she used to live in. Even though she was just at her apartment yesterday morning, it felt like she hadnt been there in ages. She walked right up to her door noticing something odd on the floor.

Peeking out from under her doormat was a yellow package creating a noticeable lump. Catra's brow furrowed as she moved the doormat

aside and picked up the package. She tossed it on the counter, resolving to read it later. She felt kind of sticky and gross. She moved to shower and change out of yesterday's clothes.

Her bathroom was one of her favorite parts of her apartment, the water pressure was amazing, and the lights weren't bright enough to be annoying. As she shampooed her hair, she thought about the day she had. She felt off balance from staying over at the house, there is no doubt about that, but being around Adora and Finn just felt so good. There was no place she'd rather be.

As she dried her hair, she noticed she had a notification on her phone and a miss call. Both were from her attorney. She narrowed her eyes on the phone, wondering why her attorney would be sending her a text so late in the day. She couldn't help the nerves that built up as she opened it up.

Her heart started beating faster as she read through the message. *Hey, it's Spinny. I couriered over your divorce papers, but the damn messenger didn't wait for you. Let me know if you received the copies. You and Adora can sign, and it'll just be a matter of filing it with the judge. It could all be over tomorrow! Please confirm receipt of the documents. Read them over, and let me know if you have any questions.*

There on the counter were her divorce papers and she hadn't even known. She looked at them for the first time, really inspecting the package. It was a manila envelope, the stack of papers inside seemed thick from the grip she had on it. She slowly opened the envelope, carefully pulling out the long document she was meant to initial on each page and sign. She saw Adora's name and hers printed along the top caption.

She slowly pursued the settlement, a perverse blend of legalese and her life. She recognized so many things on it—Finn's birthday, the address of their house, the damn heirloom clock they received as a wedding gift. Her life, carefully categorized and divided, permanently cleaved from Adora's.

t could all be over tomorrow .

Her chest felt too tight, her palms sweaty and shaking as she held the papers in her hand. She qickly shoved them back into the envelope, closing it. Wishing they'd just disappear . She took a step back as if the envelope would hurt her~~in~~ a way , it already had.

"I cant do this."She said it out loud to her empty apartment. She wasnt sure why this moment was it, but she didnt have it in her to sign those papers. She couldnt do it. Not now . Not when what she really wanted, *more than anything*, was to make things right with Adora.

Catra grabbed the package and stepped out of the house, getting back into her car to go to her home~~to~~ Adora. She wasnt sure what she was doing, trying not to think and just drive. Getting to Adora' s was turning into a nightmare. Already, there were two car crashes stopping traffic, and it was raining to boot.

Sitting in bumper-to-bumper traffic, Catra made a phone call. She contemplated calling Scorpia or Glimmer, but she knew there was only one person she could trust with this.

"I need you to tell me if Im being absolutely batshit right now ."She stated bluntly over the phone the moment the line went live.

Lonnie let out a grunt of surprise. "Catra? What're you doing? The shop isnt even open today ."She sounded confused and she heard her walking away from some type of background noise.

"I dont want to get a divorce. I think Im going to ask Adora to take me back."She whispered frantically . Saying the words aloud made Catra's palms start to sweat.

"Oh. Oh Shit! Why are you calling me?"Lonnie seemed even more confused than before.

"Hey , dont say it like that, were friends! Y ou're the most levelheaded person I know about these things. And you have two boyfriends, you must know *something* about how relationships are supposed to work."

She made an affronted, judgy noise. "Honestly Cat, that' s pretty sad, what's up with your other friends?"

"Not the point Lonn! Are you going to help me or what?" She said exasperatedly .

"Okay , fine. What brought this all on?" She asked.

She took a deep breath as she kept her eyes on the road. "Y esterday we had a rough day. We lost Finn at the aquarium— they're fine, but it was quite the scare." Catra searched her memories for when these thoughts started taking root in her. "But honestly I think this started before I— mean you know we've been trying to be friends."

Lonnie snorted. "Y eah, you mean all the moon eyes you've been making at your phone for the last six months. Every time Adora spams your phone."

"Ugh, I do not make eyes— anyways *not the point*. She apologized and we've been closer than ever and two days ago I found out she turned down the branch manager position." She spoke rapidly as if her thoughts would disappear if she didn't get them out in the open.

"She did what? Adora? Y ou sure she didn't get a personality transplant from an alien?" The disbelief in her voice was palpable. Catra felt vindicated by it.

"That' s what I said! I mean she wanted that position since we were twenty and she was interning with Eternia! It' s the whole reason we moved away for her to get her master's degree! And now she doesn't give a shit?" She raged as confusion and resentment mingled in her throat.

Glimmer implied that somehow, it had to do with Catra. With Adora's feelings for Catra. That made her buzz, nervous energy sifting through her. *But if Adora still loves me, why would she let her job come between us? Why would she say she knew we couldn't be more than friends when we reconciled?*

"Why do you almost sound angry? Is this not a good thing?" Lonnie asked curiously.

She pressed her lips together. "It just bothers me. She couldn't take a step back when we were together but suddenly, we're separated and she just decides it isn't worth it?"

"I mean it's news to you and me, but you've been separated for over a year before you even started talking again. It's been what, a year and a half since you moved out? People change Catra. Haven't you changed this whole time?"

"I have. I mean, I think I have." She's less angry for one thing. And although her relationship with Starla didn't work out it was an experience that helped her realize what she did want. She was more self-confident and knew the way she wanted to be treated in a relationship.

"You have Catra. You've grown and learned a lot about yourself. Take it from someone who hangs around you for over forty hours a week." Lonnie affirmed before switching gears. "Okay, so Adora might be experimenting with work-life management. Does that fix everything that was wrong with your marriage?"

Catra winced at Lonnie's critical tone, hand tightening on the steering wheel. "No, it doesn't. To be honest I don't even know what I would want to hear from her." She knew the darker thoughts that were running through her mind. *What, you prioritize this thing over me for so long and now you're just going to quit?* "Besides there is a close to zero chance that she wants to get back together anyway." She stared out at the rain, feeling hopeless. "What am I doing?" She muttered to herself.

Catra sighed as she evaluated pulling a U-turn before she blew up her life all over again.

"Okay relax for a second, I'm not telling you that you can't patch things up, but you can't go in there and just kiss her and hope for the best," Lonnie explained. Catra could feel her heartbeat as if it was making her whole body throb. "I know you Catra. It's not just the job. What else happened?"

"I got the divorce papers today." She eyed the manila folder in her passenger seat distrustfully.

"Okay, now that makes sense to me. Feels more real, doesn't it?" Lonnie had a smug knowing tone as she delivered the question. "I told you that the papers make things feel different."

Catra bit back the response she wanted to give. "Yeah, it does." She wasn't sure she could describe the breathless gut punch actually holding the papers in her hands turned out to be. "We've just grown so close in the last few months, and it feels like before sometimes... Like she still loves me."

"You've been a lot happier recently. And to be perfectly honest, I thought you might have already gotten back together but you both wanted space to figure it out without the scrutiny." Lonnie floated the idea with a hesitant voice.

"Wait, you really thought we were back together?" Disbelief colored her voice. Of all the things for her co-workers to think—

"Catra, everyone at the shop thinks you're back together. Perfuma and Scorpia think so too—we talked about it when I had lunch at the tea shop the other day. You've been awfully cozy lately." She'd defended.

"Okay, I'm going to pretend you didn't say that because I don't have the space to deal with that right now." Finally, traffic started to free up and Catra's car started moving forward again.

"My point is just that I do think your relationship with her has changed pretty radically and that isn't just in your head." She surmized.

"I guess part of me recognizes that things have changed at some level, but there is still so much we need to talk about."

In this time apart Catra gathered new concerns, whenever she let herself think about her marriage. Even *if* Adora cared and wanted to be together. Even *if* she turned down the branch manager position for her.

Did Adora really love Catra or just the fact that Catra has always been there? Did she even know Catra anymore after two years of not truly connecting, between the end of their rocky marriage and the separation afterward?

Her mind snapped back into the present when she heard Lonnie's voice over the phone again. "Look, I don't think you're batshit, and I also think there isn't much I can tell you one way or another whether you should get back together with Adora. You need to talk to her and trust your gut." She advised. "Also, you don't need to make an all-or-nothing decision after one conversation. You have options Catra. Use that head of yours."

"Okay , Lonn. Thanks for talking to me, I have to go." She was back near the house she had left just this afternoon.

"Let me know how it goes Cat, I can always put ice cream in the work fridge."

"I'll keep that in mind." She straightened up to her full height, pressing back into the driver's seat.

Catra needed answers and she was determined to get them. She finally pulled up to Adora's driveway. She takes a few moments to look at the rain droplets skimming the windshield, trying to slow her breathing. She grabbed her umbrella and the manilla envelope as

she willed her legs to move towards the door. She knocked, her heart pounding.

An alarmed Adora opened the door, stepping out of the way for Catra to enter the house. She crowded forward, eyes raking over Catra in a worried fashion.

"Cat what are you doing here? I mean you're always welcome, I just did something happen?" She posed the question with a slight tilt of her head, an errant blonde lock slipping in front of her blue eyes. "Finn went to bed if you wanted to see them."

Catra stared at the dorky blonde, not sure if she knew anything anymore. Her hands trembled at her sides as her heart trembled in her chest.

"Hey Adora."

Chapter End Notes

I have held back. Every. Time. So I could have THIS be Catra's first "Hey Adora" This is the FIRST scene I envisioned when I thought about writing a divorce AU and when I gave my beta my terrible terrible first draft I told her "there are only two things you can't change 1) Catra's "Hey Adora" and 2) the last thing Adora says to Catra before the fic ends." AND BOY did a lot of things change since then but I'm SO glad I got to share this scene with you all today. I REALLY WANNA KNOW WHAT Y'ALL THINK!

Also, I have posted like MAD this week:

If you want to read an angsty comphet-related fic you should scope out The Scenic Route. NGL I'm pretty proud of this one.

If you are a fan of the canon-divergent Future Catra and Finn time travel, Unnamed Constellation is for you. I'd been working on it for the same amount of time as Divorce AU lol.

And if Adora being a bit of a goof when asking Catra out appeals to you, Tooth Be Told, I Love Her would be your fic.

Please provide kudos and comments!Also, follow me on Twitter if you want to see the absolutely sentimental Twitter thread that I will inevitably post about this fic after next Friday . And I've already partially written the a/n for the next chapter and I cried so uh yeah.

ONE. MORE. CHAPTER.

Next Week: We made it. It's finally happening.

A Fresh Foundation

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora finally talk.

Catra and Adora get married.

Catra and Adora kiss.

Chapter Notes

I absolutely need to thank BlueCoin00 who absolutely TORE divorce AU apart when it was a trash 45k word disaster and the first fiction Id written in a literal decade. This fic would not be half as good without their influence. I also need to thank PlagueVectress for naming the fic and every single chapter, I love both of you so much and your support has meant everything to me.

Final thank you goes to pettylabelle_ who read this over for me and assured me that this chapter closes out the fic with some justice. I assume every SPOP fan has read Pettys work but if you havent you are missing out and should go there IMMEDIATELY

I hope yall enjoy .

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Hey Adora." Catra's voice was breathless, her chest heaving as if shed run a marathon. Her eyes wildly searched Adora's face, then behind her. "Can I come in?" She asked tentatively .

Adora was confused as to why she had an upset Catra on her doorstep. She racked her brain for reasons why shed be here so late. Finn was long asleep.

"Catra, you're scaring me. Is everything okay? Is this about Finn?" She searched her face looking for answers, finding none. "They're fine upstairs." She added again, hoping that it would get Catra to respond to her.

Something must be horribly wrong.

"I'm going to ask you something, and I'd appreciate it if you were honest with me." Catra' s voice was controlled but it sounded like it was teetering on the edge of something else. Some emotion that Adora couldn't identify .

Adora brushed her sweaty palms on her leggings. She noticed the rain and the raised goosebump on Catra's skin. "Why don't we come inside, get comfortable?" Adora suggested instead. She wanted to know what Catra wanted but she didn't want her catching a cold on her watch.

Catra nodded mutely and Adora followed her in, feeling like she was heading into the principal's office instead of her living room. Catra dropped a few of her things on the coffee table and then bundled herself up in a blanket. She wasn't too wet given that she used an umbrella. She looked so small on the couch, sunken in on herself. It worried Adora like nothing else.

"What'd you want to ask me?" Adora prompted, desperate to know where Catra's head was at.

Catra stared at her evenly as she nuzzled into the blanket. "W ere you offered the promotion to be the Bright Moon branch manager?"

Adora looked up, startled. She hadn't thought about the potential promotion in weeks and had no idea how Catra caught wind of it. It wasn't a secret, but she tried not to bring up her job to Catra.

"Y eah, I did get offered the position." Adora furrowed her brow , she still had no idea where this was going. Why would Catra show up on her doorstep to talk about her work? It made no sense.

"And did you take it?" Catra watched Adora intently, she didn't know what Catra searched for.

"Um, no I didn't. Heh." Adora's hand reached behind her neck without her permission. She wasn't exactly sure why, but she felt like she was in trouble.

"Why?" Catra kept staring, her expression gave nothing away.

"What do you mean why, Cat? What are you getting at?" Adora felt frustrated like she was taking a pop quiz she was doomed to fail.

"Adora, you slaved at that job for years. You *always* wanted to become the Bright Moon branch manager. Why'd you turn it down so suddenly? And then you hid it from me?" Catra's voice was bordering on angry and accusatory, her eyes flashing in a way that took Adora back to fights they hadn't had for almost two years now.

Just like then, Adora felt defensive. "I didn't keep it from you on purpose! I just didn't think it was important." She explained with a furrowed brow.

Catra looked indignant like she was about to interrupt.

This conversation was getting away from Adora. She felt panicked—the last time a conversation with Catra felt this out of control of a conversation she left the house with a packed bag. She started speaking before Catra could, grabbing both of her hands so she would stay put for the moment.

"Wait, wait! You asked me a question give me a chance to answer it, will you?" She said sternly, staring her down. Catra glared for a moment, but she thought better of it and nodded at Adora, her expression partially cleared as she stayed seated on the couch.

Adora ran her fingers through her hair. "Okay. I wasn't hiding it from you. It's just for a long time we didn't talk about my work at all. It feels like an unspoken rule. And then after we talked about it, I

honestly forgot to bring it up—I didn't see why it would be important because I wasn't going to take it." Adora took a deep breath, sitting down beside Catra and squeezing her hands. "I turned it down because it wasn't the right job opportunity for me. That's the honest truth."

"It wasn't the right job opportunity for you." Catra echoed incredulously. "You wanted that job since we were in college Adora. What gives?"

She looked down at the ground, not sure she could meet Catra's eyes and talk about this. "I was prioritizing the wrong things. It's true, I value my career and I'm good at my job but after you *left* I"—Adora tried to keep her voice from trembling—"I knew that I didn't want to keep losing the things that were most important to me. I wanted to spend time with Finn, my friends, my family." *With you,* her heart added.

"So you did it for Finn?" Catra summarized, somehow looking disappointed.

Adora shook her head. "I did it for *me*, Catra." She held her eyes this time, trying to make her understand. "I want to be present in my own life. I don't want to look back in fifteen years and regret not being around for the people who matter." *I already have enough regrets to live with.*

Catra contemplated her for a moment. "That's good." She said slowly as she nodded. "I'm glad. Finn deserves your attention." The tone of her voice didn't match up with her words.

Why is Catra so upset about this? Now Catra couldn't meet her gaze and some pieces started to fall into place for Adora.

"Were you hoping I'd done it for you, Cat?" She whispered the suspicion aloud, her heart beating straight through her chest.

Catra's face betrayed her, flushing as she dropped Adora's hands completely. Adora's heart soared. Before Catra could deny it, Adora spoke up. "It's the only thing that makes sense with you banging down my door in the middle of the night to grill me on my career decisions." She tried to keep her voice light, but even the shadow of the idea that Catra wanted Adora to put her first felt heavy.

"The thought might've crossed my mind." She admitted while biting her lip. She then shook her head, looking down at her empty hands. "you're right, this was stupid, showing up here so late, I should just" Catra moved to pull away, but Adora lightly tugged her back, not wanting to keep her in place if she truly wanted to break away. Catra eyed her warily but sat still.

"It was also for you Cat. I wanted to be around for you in any capacity you'd allow." She admitted. She couldn't bear the thought that Catra didn't understand how important she was to Adora, even if it meant exposing her heart for Catra to see. At this point, she had to know right? There was no way Catra didn't know how in love with her Adora was. "I know you don't want me that way, but I need time to be around if I want to be a good friend to you."

Catra's eyes looked like saucers, mouth slightly agape. "Where's this coming from?" Catra demanded, looking genuinely puzzled. Adora furrowed her brow and leaned forward, closer to Catra confused by the question. "This idea that I don't want you. You're wrong. I've *never* not wanted you, Adora."

Her heart started beating faster and her eyes widened. *Maybe this isn't as hopeless as I thought.*

Catra took a deep breath. She pulled a manilla envelope from the coffee table and put it in Adora's hand. She bit her lip as she read the side. *An: Please Sign and Return* with Catra's address embossed on the side. *These must be the divorce papers.* Adora felt her heart crumbling in her chest. She read the whole situation all wrong.

Catra's voice trembled as she spoke again. When she did, it tilted Adora's world on its axis yet again.

"I haven't signed these papers because I don't want a divorce. Not really." She whispered quietly, the admission hitting Adora like a sledgehammer.

Adora must be dreaming. Or she knocked her head and fell into a coma. *Man, that would suck.*

Then

Adora must be dreaming. Or she knocked her head and fell into a coma. *Man, that would suck.* There was no other way to explain how she felt, standing at the altar, on the verge of marrying the love of her life. After so much time spent together, they would officially belong to each other. *I've always been Catra's though.* She can't say she was always certain that they would end up together but she'd hoped and wished and reamed for this day for way longer than she cared to admit.

She tried to keep taking deep breaths but Catra left her breathless in the best of ways. Catra looked absolutely amazing in her suit. It was a dark burgundy color and the shirt she wore was a crisp white with gold detailing. Adora knew she'd gone to multiple fittings to tailor her outfit, but it was otherworldly.

They were holding hands in front of the officiant and all Adora could think about was when she'd be allowed to kiss Catra. Adora had no idea how she was expected to make it through a reception after this. It felt like love was bursting under her skin at a microscopic level, every cell in her body vibrating with the emotion of it.

Adora stared dazedly at Catra for a few more moments until she realized that it was silent. Too silent. Catra leaned in, her eyes dancing with humor.

She was much closer than Adora expected and her eyes fluttered close as she felt her lips on the shell of her ear. "It's your turn to say your vows, princess."Adora flushed. *Oh shit.*

Adora collected herself, clearing her throat. She had a paper but she didn't need to look at it~~the~~ vows were embossed onto her very soul. "Catra, we've known each other our whole lives."Catra rolled her eyes playfully at that but squeezed her hands. Adora squeezed back as she stared at her love. "I can't remember a time when I wasn't in love with you, and I hope a time like that never comes. Because you're it for me Cat. I've known it since I was in high school, hopelessly pining after you."That triggered scattered groans and chuckles from their friends and family.

Adora continued, trying to keep the tremor out of her voice. "I can't believe I'm *so* lucky to get to marry not only the most beautiful woman I've ever met but also the best person I know."She could see Catra's eyes misting over there. "I promise to support you, to be present in our lives together, to honor you, to listen to you, and most of all~~I~~ promise to love you and make you feel loved every single day."

Adora beamed at Catra as she finished her vows, vows she intended to keep for life. It was going to be her and Catra at the end of the world.

Now

Adora felt hope rising in her chest like a buoy, threatening to lift her off the ground. She stomped it down violently. *What does that even mean Catra?*

Catra looked uncomfortable at the question.

"Oh, shit I said that out loud."Adora realized, feeling heat rush to her face. That broke the tension in the room. Catra giggled.

Okay, Adora, you can fucking do this. At this point, you can't turn back.

She clenched her hand in her lap. "Cat, do you mean that you might want to try to fix things? Between us?" Adora held her breath, her whole body coiling in anticipation of the answer.

"I think it would be great if we could." Catra's response was soft, tentative, her eyes never leaving Adora's.

Adora vibrated with joy. "So, we both want the same thing then?"

Catra shrugged, eyes guarded. "I guess it depends on you. What do *you* want, Adora?" Catra scooted closer, playing with the frayed edge of one of the throw pillows on the couch.

Adora took a deep breath. "What I've always wanted. I want us to be together. I want to be married again. I want to be a family." *No use holding back now.* "I love you, Cat. I always have."

Catra stared at her and Adora tightened her grip on Catra's hands. "Catra. Can I touch you?" She asked softly.

Catra's eyes widened, giving a shuddering breath as she nodded. Adora gently squeezed Catra's hand before letting go, using the back of her finger to gently touch her wife's cheek, letting her thumb trail down to her jaw. Her skin was so soft, dotted with freckles Adora had loved for ages. Catra leaned into Adora's touch, her eyes closing for a brief moment before they trained on Adora again.

"I love you too, Adora." She murmured, moving her hand to cover Adora's keeping it in place on her cheek. For a moment, Adora just stared at Catra in disbelief. She'd never dreamed of hearing those words again. She pressed her forehead against Catra's just breathing with wide eyes as she took in the woman she loved.

Then she leaned up, closing the gap between them to press a kiss to Adora's lips. She groaned, one hand winding around Catra's waist,

the other stayed on her face as she breathed her in. She tasted the same, and her lips moved the same, but somehow Adora felt like this was their first kiss. She never felt so much just holding and kissing a woman, not even Catra.

Catra kissed her like a woman possessed, like she missed her, had been missing her the whole time they were apart. Adora bit back a moan as Catra deepened the kiss, her hands inching across the hem of Adora's shirt. Everything started to feel hot and all Adora wanted to do was lay Catra out on the couch and show her exactly how much she'd longed for her.

Catra pulled back slightly, her eyes searching Adora's gaze. In her haze, Adora said the only thing she could think of.

"Slap me." She blurted out.

Catra raised an eyebrow pulling further back. "What? No! Adora that's so weird." She kicked one leg out to nudge Adora's calf.

"Pinch me then." She insisted with a broad grin.

Catra's eyes softened as she caught on to what Adora was implying. "You're such a dork." She shoved her in the shoulder half-heartedly, as if that would prove that this wasn't a dream.

Adora pressed another soft kiss on her lips, marveling at the fact that she could. *She can kiss Catra.* The thought was dizzying.

"Yours though." The words slipped out unintentionally and she felt her gut freeze as Catra tensed.

The smile on Catra's face dimmed momentarily. "We should talk before we make any promises we can't keep." She hedged, eyes guarded once again.

For a second it was just like all the times that the reality of their separation intruded on an otherwise perfect moment. She felt some

of the burning in her skin subside

"Okay ." Adora nodded. "No more kissing? While we talk?" She clarified. She wanted nothing more than to kiss Catra a million times over, but she desperately did not want to fuck up any chance of being *them* again.

"Sure." Catra nodded although Adora thought she looked a little disappointed. Then again, maybe she was just projecting.

"So we love each other and want to stay together ." Adora tried out the statement, putting it out into the universe.

Catra stared at her. "I don't get it." She burst out, her earlier anger returning so fast it gave Adora whiplash. "You pushed me away when we were together Dor! And then you asked to be friends! How does that add up to what you say you want now?" She was practically whining by the end of it, demanding an explanation.

Adora scoffed, her hand reaching out to hold Catra's wrist, needing to keep some part of her close. "Well— eah! I thought *you* wanted to be friends! Stars, Cat you had a girlfriend when I asked for your friendship. What kind of asshole would I be, hitting on you then?"

Catra raised her eyebrow. "What kind of asshole would you be hitting on your wife while she had a girlfriend? Weird question Dor , Ill pass on that."

Adora couldn't help but snort at Catra' s dry humor. The moment felt so normal, so right, Adora moved her grip on Catra's wrist to interlace their fingers instead.

"I thought you didn't want me, Cat." It came out with a whimper . "I'm willing to do anything to have you in my life in some way. Even if we are just friends, it' s better than being without you at all." It felt so good to admit.

Catra's eyes were soft, her mismatched eyes melting Adora to her core. "I thought the same thing—that being friends was way better than strangers, even if it wasn't all that I wanted. I felt the same way."

"Then let's *be* together." The words flew out of Adora's mouth, desperate and hopeful. Her hands were itching to touch Catra everywhere, not just her palm or her lips.

Catra sighed. "It's not that simple Dora. There are *so* many reasons we separated. Things between us weren't great when I left."

Adora's smile dimmed at that. "Yeah, I know that, Cat."

"I can see how you could love me and ask for friendship, but that doesn't explain how you acted before we separated." She pointed out. "I mean, one of the biggest reasons I left that night is because I assumed you didn't love me anymore. What was a meant to think? You didn't pay attention at all Dora."

"Can I say something before we get into that?" Adora asked tentatively. Catra nodded squeezing

"Nothing I say is going to be a valid excuse for how I treated you. And I'm so sorry that it happened." Adora apologized again with a sigh. "I look back now, and I can't believe that I did that to you. Every sacrifice I made for my job felt small and doable, but I didn't consider the way those sacrifices snowballed. Or how those sacrifices affected my family. You."

She narrowed her gaze. "Adora, if this is going to work, you're going to have to stop apologizing." Adora took a deep breath too caught up with the idea of them *working* for her to be cowed by Catra's glare. "And I'm sorry too."

That caught Adora's attention. "You don't have anything to be sorry for." Adora immediately rebuffed.

Catra cupped her cheek and tilted her face up, making sure Adora could see all of her. "Yes, I really do. You didn't make it easy, but I should have tried harder to talk with you. And once I left, I shouldn't have doubled down as hard as I did."

Adora frowned at that. "No, but I should've reached out. I should have called and knocked and begged at Scorpia's door until you let me talk to you."

Catra bit her lip as she pulled a strand of Adora's hair back into place. "Why didn't you?"

She looked down, ashamed. "I thought you wanted space, that you'd come back to talk about it when you felt ready." She realized how stupid that was now.

"It's what I should've done Dor. We both carry responsibility for how everything went down, it's not just on you. You don't get to be a martyr here." She tilted Adora's chin up again. "Will you accept my apology?"

She gives Catra a timid smile. "Of course Cat."

They're silent for a moment, leaning against each other for support. Adora ran her hands over Catra's shoulders, pulling her close and smelling her. She could feel Catra smile against her when she realizes what she was doing.

"Weirdo." She said with love in her eyes.

"Yours." She doubled down. "Catra." Adora finally asked something she'd been dying to know. "What was it like for you? How do you think it went wrong?"

"I don't think that you want to hear about that," Catra warned, voice low and scratchy.

I do. I want to understand—actually listen how I should have listened then." She explained. "When we talked about the holiday party it hurt, but it's like you said—if you can't be honest about how you felt then how can we move forward?"

She leaned her head against the couch, eyes intent on Catra.

She sighed, looking down at their joined hands as she searched for the words. "It was miserable. I felt unseen and unloved." She recited the words slowly, watching for Adora's reaction. She nodded. The words hurt but that's how Catra felt. She tried to ignore the guilt gnawing at her gut. "I don't know if you realize just how cold you turned on me Dora."

"No, I didn't realize you felt that way at all." Adora bit her lip. "Which is obviously part of the problem."

"I mean Adora what was I supposed to think?" She asked again. "We barely spoke to each other and when we did talk, it was always about how you needed me to take care of something at home so you could be at work." She explained with an underpinning of frustration. "It felt like you were just using work as an excuse to hide from me. That you were too afraid to actually end things." Catra shrugged one shoulder. "So, I did it for you."

Adora's heart felt torn open listening to Catra retell her version of events. *And I didn't even notice how she felt at all*.

"That wasn't it at all. I don't think I know how to not be in love with you with Cat. I was careless and stupid and wrong for a lot of things, but it was never lack of feeling on my end." She shook her head, trying to find the words that would explain to Catra how she felt. "I wanted to give you and Finn things. I thought that if I could provide enough, Finn would never feel the way that I did with Weaver." She ran a hand through her hair, trying to keep the tears from her voice. "And I didn't want to let anyone down, so I just put my head down and put in the hours, did what I thought I was supposed to."

“We just wanted you Dora.” She whispered eyes filled with tears.

“I know that now. I just felt like my whole life Catra, you always gave me everything. I was a foster kid with not a dollar to her name and you had stability, home, love, a warm meal every night. And you shared that all with me.” Adora sniffled, taking one of her hands to wipe her eyes on her shirt sleeve. “I know now that it was wrong. I love being around Finn and you. I love being able to make time for my friends, the gym, talking to Mara it feels like I have my life back and I didn’t even know I’d lost it.”

“I’m really happy that you took a step back and that you’re enjoying those things,” Catra said, an almost proud look overtaking her features. It made Adora’s heart swell.

“I didn’t realize it at the time, but I was probably just as miserable if not more miserable than you were. I just didn’t think about it it was just how things were.”

Catra nodded at the explanation. “I’m not sure that Ill ever really get it but I think I get it enough to try to let go.”

“I didn’t really get how bad things were until I saw you out with Starla one time.” Adora confided in her.

“I saw you too, you know?” Adora looked at Catra dumbly. She quickly clarified. “At the bar, picking up a girl one night. I felt like I was either going to throw up or punch her.”

Adora’s eyes widened. “I thought you hadn’t seen me! God that night was awful, you looked so happy with Starla, and I couldn’t remember the last time I made you that happy. I couldn’t do much more than kiss that girl because of how upset I was that night.”

She had a faraway look in her eyes as if revisiting that night. “I mean it was terrible but that was also when Starla saw us in the same room. She said that was when she realized that we didn’t have a future together.”

Adora furrowed her eyebrows. "Really? But we were so broken then." What could Starla have possibly seen to make her think that Adora would somehow come between her and Catra?

"Yeah. Apparently, I look at you like I love you or something." She tried to make it lighthearted but the look on her face made it anything but.

Adora felt her gut clench and she swore she was about to lift off the ground again. "Catra, Im just a woman. You cant look at me like that if you dont want me to kiss you." She said a bit desperately.

Catra smirked coyly. "Maybe we can take a break."

"A break?" She asked as she leaned in closer to Catra's space.

"Yeah. From the no kissing rule."

Adora eyed her for a moment. She leaned forward and pressed a soft, barely there, kiss to Catra's lips. It was the gentle sweet thing she should've given her earlier. She stopped herself from taking it further—she isnt sure she could take it, kissing Catra again and then realizing that they couldnt work things out.

"What do you need for us to be viable together?" Adora prompted.

"We need to go to couple's counseling." Where the first words out of Catra's mouth to Adora's surprise. "There's so much to unpack there is no way we can do it without hurting ourselves or Finn in the process."

Adora nodded slowly, bringing a hand to briefly touch Catra's cheek. "I think that's a great idea." She bit her lip. "I've actually been thinking about going to individual therapy too."

"Really?" Catra asked, surprised.

"Yeah, I mean it's not normal for me to have these panic attacks when I go to Thaymor. I havent dealt with Weaver and all the bullshit

around her dying yet. It could be good to have someone to talk to." She shrugged helplessly.

"That sounds good Dor ."She smiled at her and it made the tension in Adora's shoulders ease.

She cleared her throat, trying to stay on task. "So, counseling. What else?"

"Space,"Catra added.

Adora's head snapped up at that. "Space how?"She asked carefully .

Catra took a deep breath, gaze dropping to one of the throw pillows for a minute. "This time that we've been apart, we haven't been fully honest with each other because we were trying so hard to be friends and not upset each other. I don't think we really know each other Dor ."

Adora was about to protest but Catra silenced her with a glare. Catra was practically pressed up to her chest, which cut the heat behind it. "I want to know that you love me for me, not for who you grew up with or who I used to be. I want to be seen for who I am now." Catra's lower lip trembled.

Adora reached out and held her against her chest. "I love every version of you. I love the Catra I grew up with, the one that I pined after, the one I dated, and the one I married. And you want to know something? I love the Catra that left me."Catra looked confused at that. "Y ou were brave and stood up for yourself and for the things that you wanted and somehow you made my life better in the process. If you hadn't done that, I don't know that we would be sitting here now. I just wish I wasn't so much of an idiot that you had to be that brave at all."

Catra was crying in earnest now shaking in Adora's arms. Adora soothingly rubbed up and down Catra's arm until her sobs turned to

tiny hiccups. *Ireally have the cutest wife.* The thought didnt feel bittersweet anymore.

"But if we try again, Im happy for us to move slow and feel it all out. I think that's a good thing."Adora reassured. She gave Catra a moment to collect herself, holding her and murmuring sweet nothings until she calmed down.

Catra looked up at her, no longer teary-eyed but still emotional. "What would you need to try again?"She asked.

Adora really thought about the question. She steeled herself, thinking Catra might not like her answer. "I think we should still get a divorce."Adora vocalized.

"What?"Catra recoiled as if burned but Adora reached out and brought her back into her orbit.

"Listen give me a minute. Trust me?"Adora winced at the phrase. "I know Im asking for a lot after everything but just"…

"Fine."She eyed Adora distrustfully , at odds with her words.

Adora pushed forward anyways. "We've been separated for a year and a half. We hit out rough patch at least a year before?"She looked to Catra for confirmation. She nodded lips pressed together. "That's almost three years since we've been in a good place in our relationship. It's why you want to move slow."She added.

She looked down at their joined hands. "Cat, being married is the opposite of slow. It comes with expectations and pressure. We need a blank slate. I think we should get a divorce and then if we decide it's right, we can get married again. And it wont be because we decided to stick it out or some nonsense, itll be because we affirmatively want it."

"So, you want to divorce me to date me?"Catra clarified with a raised eyebrow, the edge of a smirk playing on her lips as Adora's

explanation sunk in.

Adora shoved her. "It sounds weird when you say it like that."

"Because it's absolutely weird." She laughed.

"I mean I won't fight you on it if you want to stay married." She joked. Her smile faded a bit as she reached out to hold Catra's hand. "But I want the chance to do it over. I want to make things right again Catra, from the bottom up. It's what you deserve."

"*We* deserve." She corrected gently .

"So you want to do it?" Adora asked with her breath held tight in her chest.

Catra laughed, loud and clear and true. "Yeah, Ill divorce you, princess." She reached out and grabbed the envelope, gesturing for Adora to follow her.

They both walked into the kitchen, Catra opened and organized the document while Adora searched for a pen. Now that it didn't mean the end of everything, the papers didn't look nearly as intimidating. After Adora initialed each page, she placed a kiss somewhere she could reach Catra~~her~~, cheek, her hand, the top of her head~~until~~ Catra started to expect it and turned to catch her lips.

"You know, you're making this divorce go twice as slow as it could with all your delay tactics." She teased as she leaned in for another kiss, this time catching Adora's bottom lip between her own and tugging gently. "Is this your lawyer's litigation strategy?"

"Well, I think the delay has worked out for both of us, hasn't it?" She replied smartly. She pulled Catra into her arms as they go to the final page. "You know I love you more than anything?" She whispered into her hair.

Catra's eyes tightened slightly. "I'm willing to try to learn that again." She offered a compromise.

It stung but it was fair. Adora placed a gentle kiss on her forehead and gave her an understanding smile. "That's okay." Adora took the pen back from Catra's hand and signed her signature on the bottom line and Catra did the same.

For a moment they were quiet in each other's arms, somehow closer and also divorced. Adora knew that they had a lot of difficult conversations and moments ahead of them if they wanted a fighting chance to make this work, but there was still one more thing she needed to do.

She pulled back slightly to look Catra in her eyes, one hand rubbing circles on her hips. "Cat, I've broken so many promises to you. Maybe every promise I've ever made to you. I'll never stop being sorry for failing to be the wife you deserve."

She had a knot in her throat and butterflies in her belly. She could feel her blood pumping through her veins, here in this house they'd lived and loved in, the sound of the heirloom clock ticking the minutes on their new adventure now.

"I know that the things that are broken between us took a long time to break. They'll take a long time to fix. But I love you so much and I want to get to know you again. Catra would you please go on a date with me?"

Catra looked up at Adora as a slow smile overtook her face. She nodded. Adora wrapped her arms around Catra crushing her to Adora's chest. She felt the urge to look up at the vintage clock on the wall, but she stopped herself. They had all the time in the world again.

Chapter End Notes

It's over. We made team! (I'm apologizing for how long this note is going to get RN because I have lots of feelings).

This was always going to end in divorce the moment the divorce papers came to play. In my first draft, I actually didn't even have them file at all but once I changed it so that they DID file, I realized that these two needed a fresh start and that's what a divorce gave them.

(Fun fact: my grandparents actually did this-got a divorce and then remarried and stayed married for over 50 years until my grandma passed)

This fic has seen me through a lot of things and I had to open up my heart to write it in a way that felt authentic and genuine to me. I hope it felt the same to you. Without this fic I don't know that I would have picked up writing fanfiction again and the SPOP community has brought me so much self-reflection and joy, I know my life would be worse off without it.

If you hadn't realized before, you might note that this is part of a series now... that's because I wrote a one-shot from this universe a while back but I didn't want to confirm that it was an epilogue of sorts until I finished the fic. Feel free to check it out to see some Catradora as girlfriends fluff! (Also I did some editing so there are some extra lines in there now about the divorce if you read it the first time around).

Next order of business: I've decided I am doing a sequel! It will be more of a hurt/comfort an fluff fic and it's going to navigate the actual dating process and rebuild their relationship. Will include things like Adora making things right with Catra's family, them telling Finn that they are dating, therapy, Adora visiting Thaymor and dealing with her Weaver trauma, and a host of new problems as they try to get used to calling each other girlfriends again lol. There is no timeline on this but my brain has been BUZZING with it so I doubt it'll take that long for me to start getting it together.

So what's next from me? I will be posting the first chapter for a few multi-chapter fics I've been working on! I have at least five new multichapter fics that I will be posting in the next few weeks (in no particular order): Soulmark AU, Conqeror AU, Dating Your Best Friend's Ex AU, Amnesia AU, and Corporate Rivals AU. I hope you'll consider checking some of them out as I post! I'll also be continuing my First Kill AU and Superhero AU as well as my gaggle of one shots.

As always, please leave me a comment or kudos I love hearing your thoughts. Also follow me on Twitter for updates and notifs about things I'm working on!

Special thank you to everyone who stuck with me from the first week and encouraged me to keep going and posting. This fic means so much to me in part because I got to share it with all of you.

Hope to see some of y'all in my other works! And see you when the seqel hits hopefully lol

End Notes

Wow, I am honestly so thrilled to post this. I remember mentioning to a friend that I really wanted to read a Catradora Divorce AU but I couldn't really find many and she just said "well, why don't you write it?" and that was the seed that let me stop telling myself I was a bad writer and to just see what would happen if I let myself write. I still don't think I'm a great writer but I am happy to share what I have written with a community I value a ton :)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!